

NDMC set to align with Jan Vishwas Bill

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) is set to align its enforcement approach with the Centre's Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Bill, 2026, which decriminalises over 1,000 minor offences and signals a shift towards trust-based governance.

The Bill was passed by Parliament on Thursday. In total, at least 105 provisions linked to fines, penalties and imprisonment have been amended or removed under the NDMC Act through the Bill, along with 47 proposed changes to property taxation, aimed at making the system simpler, transparent, and citizen-friendly.

The NDMC on March 30 said that implementing the Unit Area Method (UAM) introduced by the Bill could reduce property tax by 30 to 50 per cent, particularly benefiting old and self-occupied properties.

The Bill was introduced by Minister of State for Commerce and Industry Jitin Prasada in the Lok Sabha, which proposed multiple changes to

KEY HIGHLIGHTS: JAN VISHWAS (AMENDMENT) BILL & NDMC REFORMS			
CORE GOVERNANCE SHIFT - Trust-Based Approach: Moves from punitive enforcement to a “facilitative environment” by decriminalising minor offences - Compliance First: Replaces immediate criminal action with warnings for first-time or minor lapses (eg documentation gaps) - Legal Relief: Over 1,000 minor offences decriminalised nationwide; 105 provisions amended or removed specifically within the NDMC Act	MAJOR PROPERTY TAX OVERHAUL - Introduction of UAM: Implementation of the Unit Area Method (UAM) for tax calculation. - Significant Savings: Expected 30% to 50%	reduction in property tax, specifically benefiting old and self-occupied properties - New Tax Structure: Property tax now bifurcated into two components: 1. Building Tax 2. Vacant Land Tax - Fairer Assessment: New “age factor” relief for older buildings and separate assessments for different property uses (eg shop vs storage)	
		ENFORCEMENT & PENALTIES - Decriminalisation Stats: 86 provisions converted from fines to penalties 16 provisions saw fines completely removed - Imprisonment clauses replaced by financial penalties	
		ECONOMIC & ADMINISTRATIVE IMPACT - Revenue Growth: Despite tax cuts for individuals, NDMC tax collection is projected to rise from ₹1,045 crore to ₹1,350 crore this year through better compliance - Streamlined Disputes: New adjudicating officers and appellate authorities to resolve grievances faster and reduce the burden on courts	

the NDMC Act, 1994.

Highlighting the benefits of UAM, NDMC Vice-Chairman Kuljeet Chahal earlier referred to the reduction of about 30 to 50 per cent in property tax in

the NDMC area, noting that the age factor will provide relief for older properties, and bifurcation will allow separate assessment of different portions of a property (such as

shop and storage).

The Bill further proposes a complete overhaul of the tax structure, specifying that property tax will now comprise two components: building tax

and vacant land tax, replacing the earlier Section 61 of the New Delhi Municipal Act, 1994. NDMC's tax collection stood at ₹1,045 crore last year and is expected to rise to approximately ₹1,350 crore this year.

The reforms aim to reduce the fear of criminal action for minor and first-time lapses, replacing immediate penalties with warnings and encouraging voluntary compliance among citizens and businesses.

For the NDMC area, which is home to the nation's political capital and high-profile residents, the shift could translate to fewer punitive actions for minor violations such as documentation gaps or procedural delays.

Officials indicated that the emphasis will now be on giving violators an opportunity to rectify mistakes before penalties are imposed.

Under the framework, first-time and minor offences will invite warnings instead of prosecution, while penalties, where necessary, will be proportionate to the severity of the violation to ensure balanced enforcement.

Jan Vishwas Bill: Two minor offences under Delhi Police Act 1978 scrapped

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In a significant step towards decriminalising outdated and minor regulatory provisions, Parliament on Thursday cleared the Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Bill, 2026. The legislation removes criminal penalties, including fines and imprisonment under two specific sections of the Delhi Police Act, 1978, which the Government has described as no longer relevant in contemporary times.

The Bill, which amends 80 central laws and rationalises over 700 minor offences across various statutes, aims to promote “trust-based governance,” reduce the burden on the judicial system, and ease compliance for ordinary citizens. It replaces many criminal provisions with civil penalties or simply omits them altogether, building on the earlier Jan Vishwas Act of 2023.

Under the new law, Section 95 of the Delhi Police

Act which penalised allowing a child under seven years of age to commit a nuisance in or near a public street or place stands omitted.

The provision previously attracted a fine of up to ₹100. It covered situations where a guardian or person in custody permitted a young child to ease themselves or otherwise cause annoyance to passers-by.

Similarly, Section 102(c), which made it an offence to be found in any building or vehicle between sunset and sunrise without a satisfactory explanation, has also been removed. This clause carried a punishment of up to three months' imprisonment and was often viewed as a broad,

vaguely worded provision reminiscent of colonial-era vagrancy laws.

These changes form part of a larger package that eliminates certain offences entirely while converting others from criminal to civil liabilities.

Official summaries of the Bill highlight the omission of provisions such as giving false fire alarms under the Delhi Police Act, alongside similar outdated clauses in other municipal and copy-right laws. The overarching goal is to move away from ‘Inspector Raj’ by treating minor infractions through administrative warnings or fines rather than criminal prosecution.

Unauthorised sale in Delhi Metro to attract penalty up to ₹5,000

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■ New Delhi

Selling or exposing for sale any article without authorisation in the Delhi Metro will soon attract a penalty of up to ₹5,000.

Besides, drunken behaviour, holding demonstrations, and walking on tracks in the Delhi Metro is set to attract heavy fines as the Centre brings in changes under the Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Bill, 2026. The Bill was passed by the Parliament on Thursday.

Anyone drunk on Metro premises will be fined between ₹2,000 and ₹5,000 if the Bill clears Parliament. This is currently capped at ₹500. The passenger can also be removed from the Metro premises if found drunk.

The Government has also tweaked the penalty for



holding demonstrations on Metro trains and stations. Holding sit-in protests and putting up posters attracts a penalty of up to ₹10,000 under the proposed law.

Currently, such offences are punishable with imprisonment for a term which may extend to six months, or with a fine which may extend to one thousand rupees, or both.

Walking on metro tracks, which attracts a fine of up to

₹500, will be penalised with up to ₹20,000 once the tweaks come into force. Among these is the unauthorised selling or offering for sale of any article in metro railway carriages or premises.

At present, such an offence attracts a fine ranging between ₹100 and ₹400. Under the amended provisions, this will be replaced with a penalty of up to ₹5,000 under Section 73 of the Act.

Noida plot row: HC seeks decision in six months

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Noida

A legal dispute over the alleged subdivision and transfer of a portion of a prime commercial plot in Noida has reached the Allahabad High Court, which has directed authorities to decide a pending statutory revision within six months.

The matter relates to Plot No C-001/A in Sector-16B, originally allotted under NOIDA's 2010 commercial builders scheme for the development of the “Delhi One” project.

The court's direction came after a petitioner approached it, citing inaction by the revisional authority on complaints challenging the legality of certain transactions linked to the plot.

According to details placed before the court, the plot measuring about 40,056.72 square metres was allotted to a consortium comprising

Vistar Construction Pvt. Ltd., Advance eGraphics Pvt. Ltd., 3C Universal Developers Pvt. Ltd., and Jaksons Limited. The consortium later formed a special purpose vehicle, Boulevard Project Private Limited (BPPL), to develop the commercial project.

The dispute centres on allegations that a portion of the plot, measuring around 3,352 square metres, was subdivided and sub-leased in violation of the terms of the original allotment and applicable rules.

As per the petition, BPPL sought permission in December 2016 to subdivide this portion and execute a sublease in favour of Wise Zone Builders Private Limited. At that time, the entity was stated to be a subsidiary linked to the project.

The petition further states that NOIDA executed a tripartite sub-lease deed on April 28, 2017, which was registered a day later. On the



same date, it is alleged that 100 per cent shareholding of Wise Zone Builders Private Limited was acquired by a Max Group entity, Max Estates Limited, through a share purchase transaction.

The petitioner has alleged that the sequence of actions, sub-division, sub-lease, and subsequent transfer of ownership was carried out in contravention of the scheme conditions and lease deed provisions.

The plea seeks a declaration that these actions are

Development Act, 1973, read with Section 12 of the U.P. Industrial Area Development Act, 1976. The revision challenges permissions and orders related to the subdivision and sub-lease, and seeks to set aside changes in the project's constitution approved by Noida.

When the revision was not decided, the petitioner approached the Allahabad High Court, Lucknow Bench, seeking directions for its early disposal.

The High Court, while disposing of the writ petition, observed that the revisional authority should consider and decide the matter in accordance with law at the earliest. It further indicated that the process should preferably be completed within six months.

The court also noted that if the revision is not decided within a reasonable period, the petitioner would be free to approach the court again.

The Pioneer

Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

1, No 14874064X Hav/Clk (SD) Hem Raj S/o Toti Ram, resident of Villa - Likhli, PO - Likhli Teh - Hodal, Distt - Palwal, State Haryana-121107 hereby solemnly affirm and declare that in my service record the name of my wife has been wrongly mentioned as Radha instead of Ku. Radha. Both the names refer to same and one person.

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PD(749)C

I, Santilata Tripathy, Mother of No.17031020N HMT/ M.TECH (SA) Biswaranjan Tripathy, R/o- Vill/PO- Chandeswar, Teh- Chilika, Dist- Khordha, Odisha- 752023, have changed my name from Santilata Tripathy to Shantilata Tripathy, vide affidavit dated 03/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(751)C

I, Varudu Hinnammudu, Mother of No.15229688W Hav(GNR) Varudu Kumaraswamy, R/o- Vill- Chodasamudram, Teh- Saravakota, Dist- Srikakulam, Andhra Pradesh- 532426, have changed my name from Varudu Hinnammudu to Varudu Chinnammadu, vide affidavit dated 03/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(753)C

I, Manjit Kaur, W/o- JC- 502330A Sub Darshan Singh, R/o- Vill- Duniya Mazra, PO- Jhansa, Teh- Pehowa, Dist- Kurukshetra, Haryana, have changed my name from Manjit Kaur to Manjeet Kaur, vide affidavit dated 03/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(757)C

I, Seema Devi W/o- No.6496805L Hav Shyam Singh, R/o- Ramhet Colony, Bhulwana (94) Palwal, Haryana- 121106, have changed my name from Seema Devi to Seema, vide affidavit dated 03/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(756)C

I, No. 10136893W Rfn Amit, R/o- Garpura Khurad, Tosham, Bhiwani, Haryana, have changed my Son's name from Tushar to Tushar Mahla, vide affidavit dated 03/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(755)C

I, Venkayamma, Mother of- No.14449589H Hav Punna Reddy Vajrala, R/o- PO- Bollavaram, Mdl- Muppalla, Dist- Palnadu, Andhra Pradesh- 522403, have changed my name from Venkayamma to Vajrala Venkayamma, vide affidavit dated 03/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(754)C

I, Rajesh W/o Rajeev Yadav, R/o RZ-3/77, Gali No. 7, East Sagarpur, New Delhi- 110046, declare that Neha Yadav is my daughter, in her documents, my name is written as Rajan Shree Yadav whereas my correct name is Rajesh, both names Rajan Shree Yadav & Rajesh pertain to one & same person i.e. myself.

PD(752)C

I, Varudu Hinnammudu, Mother of No.15229688W Hav(GNR) Varudu Kumaraswamy, R/o- Vill- Chodasamudram, Teh- Saravakota, Dist- Srikakulam, Andhra Pradesh- 532426, have changed my name from Varudu Hinnammudu to Varudu Chinnammadu, vide affidavit dated 03/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(750)C

I, Hajerabi, Mother of No. 4586852X Nk Shaikh Gause Shaikh Farid, R/o- Samrat Colony, Basmath, Dist- Hingoli, Maharashtra- 431512 have changed my name from Hajerabi to Bibi Hajra Shaikh Farid, vide affidavit dated 03/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(745)C

I, Santilata Tripathy, Mother of No.17031020N HMT/ M.TECH (SA) Biswaranjan Tripathy, R/o- Vill/PO- Chandeswar, Teh- Chilika, Dist- Khordha, Odisha- 752023, have changed my name from Santilata Tripathy to Shantilata Tripathy, vide affidavit dated 03/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(743)C

I, hitherto known as AMARJEET SINGH alias AMARJIT SINGH son of Bhag Singh residing at 359, Dhaka Johar, Nirankari Colony, North West Delhi-110009 have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as AMARJIT SINGH.

PD(744)C

I, hitherto known as Baby Jain Alias Sarita Jain D/o Rajender Jain W/o Dinesh Jain R/o T-231, Gali No

CM Rekha unveils action plan 2026 to tackle pollution

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Friday launched a comprehensive Air Pollution Mitigation Action Plan 2026, announcing strict enforcement measures including a “No PUC, No Fuel” rule and restrictions on the entry of non-compliant vehicles into the Capital from November 1. The plan outlines a wide-ranging strategy to curb pollution through enforcement, technology, and time-bound action. It targets key pollution sources such as vehicular emissions, road dust, construction activity, industrial discharge, and biomass burning. Addressing a high-level

review meeting at the Mukhyamantri Janseva Sadan, the Chief Minister said the initiative marks a shift from policy intent to execution. She stated that clean air and environmental protection are central to the Government’s agenda, backed by dedicated budgetary support. Under the plan, strict action will be taken against vehicles without valid Pollution Under Control certificates. Authorities will use automatic number plate recognition cameras and digital systems to enforce compliance. From November 1, only BS-VI compliant, CNG-powered, or electric goods vehicles will be allowed to enter Delhi.



Non-essential traffic will also be regulated. Officials said additional restrictions could be imposed during periods of severe pollution. These may include staggered office timings, work-from-home measures, and curbs on polluting vehicles. The Government is also focusing on expanding public transport to reduce dependence on private vehicles. The bus fleet is set to increase to 13,760 by 2028-29, with priority given to electric buses.

Integration of metro and regional transit systems with feeder services is planned to improve last-mile connectivity. To support electric mobility, the Government will install 32,000 charging points over the next four years. A new Electric Vehicle Policy 2026 is being prepared, focusing on two-wheelers, commercial vehicles, and the transition of Government fleets to cleaner fuels. Traffic congestion, a major contributor to emissions, will be addressed through interventions at 62 identified hotspots. Authorities plan to deploy an intelligent traffic management system and introduce smart parking solutions to improve traffic flow and reduce emissions.

KEY HIGHLIGHTS: AIR POLLUTION MITIGATION ACTION PLAN 2026	
IMMEDIATE & STRATEGIC ENFORCEMENT	URBAN MANAGEMENT & INFRASTRUCTURE
❑ No PUC, No Fuel: Mandatory valid Pollution Under Control (PUC) certificate required for refueling at all petrol pumps ❑ Entry Restrictions (Nov 1): Only BS-VI compliant, CNG-powered, or electric goods vehicles allowed into Delhi ❑ Tech-Driven Monitoring: Use of ANPR (Automatic Number Plate Recognition) cameras, GPS tracking for sweepers, and the AI-enabled C&D Portal 2.0 for construction sites	❑ Traffic De-congestion: Focused interventions at 62 identified hotspots using Intelligent Traffic Management Systems (ITMS) ❑ Road Redevelopment: 3,500 km of roads to be paved with green buffers to reduce road dust ❑ Dust Control: Deployment of mechanical sweepers, anti-smog guns, and mandatory mist spray systems for large buildings
GREEN MOBILITY & PUBLIC TRANSPORT	WASTE & LANDFILL TARGETS
❑ Fleet Expansion: Targeted increase to 13,760 buses by 2028-29, with a core focus on electric buses ❑ Infrastructure: Installation of 32,000 EV charging points over the next four years ❑ Connectivity: Integration of Metro, Regional Transit, and feeder services (including 500 mini e-buses) for last-mile access	❑ Landfill Clearance Deadlines: Okhla: July 2026 ❑ Bhalswa: December 2026 ❑ Ghazipur: December 2027 ❑ Biomass Ban: Strict prohibition of open burning with a shift toward electric heating alternatives

LPG black market: Police recover 500 cylinders, arrest 11

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

While the Government assured Delhi that the West Asia crisis would not disrupt cooking gas supplies, a parallel economy was quietly flourishing in rented godowns, residential homes, and TATA Ace vans navigating industrial back lanes. Over the past ten days, Delhi Police has made a series of raids across the Capital, recovering nearly 500 LPG cylinders from illegal hoarders and black marketers who had turned a public crisis into private profit. The numbers tell a story of organised exploitation. Six separate operations in Sangam Vihar, Chhawla, Dabri, Rohini, Palam Village, and Bawana have led to eleven arrests and the seizure of cylinders from HP Gas, Bharat Gas, Indane, and Go Gas. The accused range from registered delivery agents who simply never delivered to the anti-auto shopkeepers charging ₹200 per kilogram



for gas that customers were struggling to find through legitimate channels. The most troubling pattern to emerge from the raids is the role of authorised delivery personnel. In Sangam Vihar, the Crime Branch’s Anti-Narcotics Task Force raided three rented godowns in L Block on March 25 and recovered 183 Indane cylinders: 154 of them filled. All four accused, Sher Singh, Suraj Parihar, Raghu Raj Singh, and Jitender Sharma, were registered delivery agents of an authorised Indane agency based in Sheikh Sarai. Their method was systematic: they collected cylinders from the agency, skipped

deliveries, stockpiled the surplus, extracted one to two kilograms of gas from each filled cylinder using iron pipes and pokers, transferred it into empty cylinders, and sold both in the open market at inflated rates. “The instruments used in illegal refilling included iron pokers, iron pipes, and a weighing scale,” said DCP Kushal Pal Singh, Dwarka District, confirmed the accused was selling cylinders to caterers and local residents at above-market prices. In Dabri’s Seetapuri area, the Crime Branch caught Mohan Lal Garg, 61, running an illegal refilling operation from his shop on April 1. He was charging Rs 200 per

kilogram. “A dedicated team was constituted to nab hoarders in view of the ongoing apprehension regarding the LPG shortage,” said DCP Harsh Indora, Crime Branch, Delhi. At Palam Village on March 28, three men, a driver, a delivery boy, and an assistant delivery boy, were caught transferring gas between cylinders at a vacant plot rented specifically for the purpose. The operation was linked to Blue Flame Gas Service, Janakpuri. SDM Dwarka and officials from BPCL and the Food Safety Department inspected the site and confirmed the illegal activity. Forty-five Bharat Gas cylinders were seized. The most recent bust came on Thursday at Bawana’s DSIIDC industrial sector. Anil Kalita, 50, was stopped in a TATA Ace with 27 cylinders. He then disclosed two additional storage rooms where 48 more were found stacked without safety measures, without documents, and without any authorisation.

Govt rolls out a multi-level strategy to manage pressure on LPG supply

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A multi-level strategy involving coordination with the Centre for policy intervention has been rolled out to manage pressure on LPG supply and the broader energy sector. The announcement came at a press conference held by the Government’s Department of Food, Supplies and Consumer Affairs. Additional Commissioner Arun Kumar Jha said Delhi has around 56 lakh domestic LPG connections, and residents are being urged to ensure that their connections are registered in the correct name to prevent misuse and diversion. Jha said at the same time, the government is pushing for expansion of Piped Natural Gas (PNG). “Wherever PNG connections are available, residents should shift from LPG to PNG,” he said, adding that the



A worker off-loads LPG cylinders from a carrier truck for distribution amid the ongoing West Asia war in New Delhi

pipeline network has now reached “every village”. A control room has been set up to monitor the situation and receive complaints and inputs. The Government earlier urged citizens to report suspicious activities through helpline numbers 011-23379836 and 8383824659, which would be operational between 9 am and 7 pm every day. It promised that verified complaints will be acted upon promptly and

informants’ identities will be kept confidential. On the enforcement front, a crackdown is underway. On Thursday, at least 100 LPG cylinders were seized from Alipur and Bawana, officials said. Authorities further said action is being taken at three levels, including enforcement and intelligence gathering. “The intelligence department is also actively working on this,” an official said.

Burari: Woman confined, assaulted after suspected of stealing cashews

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A man has alleged that his wife was confined in a room and brutally assaulted by three women who accused her of stealing a packet of cashew nuts in the Burari area of north Delhi. According to the FIR registered at Burari police station, the incident occurred on March 28 between 9.15 and 9.30 pm as the woman was returning home from work and stopped at a grocery store near a Government school. In her complaint, the woman claimed that after completing her purchase at the counter, the three women demanded to see the bill for her items. As she began to comply, the trio allegedly pushed her, hurled abuses, and accused her of theft. When she resisted, the accused allegedly snatched her mobile phone and dragged her to the back



warehouse of the store, where they physically assaulted her, read the FIR. The victim further alleged that a man briefly intervened, but the assault continued. She sustained injuries during the attack, including swelling under her right eye and a fracture in her right hand. She stated that she requested her phone but lost consciousness during the assault. According to the FIR, she regained consciousness upon hearing her husband’s voice, who had arrived at the scene after someone from the store asked him to come quickly. The store staff eventually returned her mobile phone,

after which a PCR call was made. Subsequently, a PCR van arrived at the scene and took the woman to Burari Government Hospital, where she received initial treatment. Doctors documented a medico-legal case (MLC), noting the history of physical assault. She was later referred to a higher centre for further treatment and underwent care at LNJP Hospital on March 29. The police stated that the woman did not provide her statement immediately at the hospital, indicating that she would do so after her treatment. On March 30, accompanied by her husband, she visited the Burari police station and based on her complaint, the police registered a case under Sections 115(2) (voluntarily causing hurt), 127(2) (wrongful confinement) and 3(5) (common intention) of the BNS, launching further investigation into the matter.

Shot fired as road rage turns violent in Faridabad

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Faridabad/New Delhi

A routine morning commute turned violent in Haryana’s Faridabad on Friday when a road rage argument escalated into gunfire, leaving a motorcyclist with a narrowly escaped injury after a bullet grazed his face. The incident took place around 10:30 am on Balaji College Road in the Ballabgarh area under the Adarsh Nagar police station. The victim, identified as Vivek, was on his way to work when he encountered a man riding a two-wheeler rashly, with a woman seated behind him. According to the police and the victim’s account, Vivek objected to the reckless driving and asked the rider to be careful. What began as a caution quickly turned into a heated verbal exchange between the two. Police said the accused then allegedly pulled out a pistol from his bag and pointed it at Vivek. As the sit-



uation escalated, Vivek attempted to snatch the weapon to prevent any harm. During the scuffle, the pistol went off. The bullet grazed Vivek’s face and passed by, leaving him with minor injuries. He managed to escape serious harm in what police described as a close call. Recounting the incident, Vivek said, “I was going to my company for duty around 10.30 in the morning. Ahead of me, a young man and a woman were riding a bike in the wrong manner. When I asked him to drive properly, an argument started. Both of them began fighting

firearm and the bag. The area was secured, and a preliminary investigation was initiated. A case has been registered at Adarsh Nagar police station, and efforts are underway to trace the accused. Station House Officer Manoj Kumar said, “We are searching for the man and the woman who fled the scene after firing the shot. CCTV footage of both has surfaced, and they will soon be arrested.” Police spokesperson Yashpal confirmed that teams have been deployed to identify and locate the accused. “Police reached the spot immediately after receiving information. We are searching for the man and the woman who fled after the firing. CCTV footage has also come to light. Both accused will be arrested soon,” he said. Officials said the abandoned two-wheeler may help in identifying the suspects. The seized weapon is also being examined as part of the investigation.

Flood Control & Irrigation Dept brings reform in tendering process

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a significant step towards ensuring transparency, fairness, and accountability in public works, the Flood Control & Irrigation Department has introduced a key reform in the tendering process by making the submission of Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) completely online. Earlier, bidders were required to physically deposit EMD at the office where the project was located. This system often led to unnecessary interface, potential information leaks, and concerns regarding fairness in the bidding process, Minister of Irrigation and Flood Control Parvesh Sahib Singh said on Friday. Under the new system, EMD will now be accepted only through online mode, and bidders will upload a scanned copy on the e-procurement portal along with their tender documents. The original Earnest Money Deposit will be required to be submitted only by the L1 bidder within a stipulated timeframe after the opening of bids. This move ensures that no official or external entity can track who is bidding for which project during the process, thereby eliminating scope for bias, pressure, or manipulation. It marks a decisive shift towards a more secure and impartial system. Parvesh Sahib Singh said, “This reform is about building trust in the system. By moving EMD completely online, we are eliminating unnecessary human interface and ensuring that the bidding process remains fair, transparent, and free from any undue influence. Our priority is clear. Honest contractors should get a fair opportunity, and public money should be utilised with full accountability.”

LG Sandhu interacts with DC, MI players

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Friday visited the Arun Jaitley Stadium and interacted with players from the Delhi Capitals (DC) and the Mumbai Indians (MI) ahead of their Indian Premier League (IPL) match scheduled for Saturday. During the visit, the Lieutenant Governor met Delhi Capitals captain Axar Patel and other members of the team, extending his best wishes for their upcoming home match. The encounter will be the team’s second game of the season at their home ground. He also interacted with Mumbai Indians players Rohit Sharma and Suryakumar Yadav. The visit came on the eve of what is expected to be a high-profile clash between the two teams in the national capital. In a post on social media platform X, the Lieutenant



Delhi Lt Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu interacting with Mumbai Indians’ Rohit Sharma at the Arun Jaitley Stadium in New Delhi

Governor said he wished both teams a spirited and sportsmanlike performance. He noted that it was encouraging to see players of international stature participating in the league. “It is always encouraging to see such world-class talent and experience representing the very best of Indian cricket,” he said. Highlighting the broader

role of sports, the Lieutenant Governor said that cricket and events like the IPL serve as a unifying force. He added that sports foster a shared sense of national pride and bring people together beyond competition. “Beyond the competition, sports remain a powerful medium to foster unity and a shared sense of national pride. May the match be a cel-

ebration of true sportsmanship and a thrilling experience for all fans in the National Capital,” he said. Apart from meeting players, the Lieutenant Governor also took time to acknowledge the contribution of ground staff at the stadium. He interacted with the staff responsible for preparing the pitch and maintaining the venue. He described their role as crucial to the success of any sporting event and said their efforts often go unnoticed despite being essential. “Their tireless efforts and meticulous preparation behind the scenes are the true backbone of every successful sporting event,” he said. He added that the quality of the playing field and overall match experience depend heavily on the dedication of the ground staff. “It is their hard work that ensures a world-class field is ready for our players to excel,” he said.

Delhi represents cultural expressions of every region of India, says Mishra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi minister of art, culture and tourism Kapil Mishra on Friday said, “Delhi, as a ‘Mini India’, represents the cultural expressions of every region of the country. Festivals and traditions from across India are celebrated here in their most vibrant and expansive forms. This is Delhi’s true identity, and continuous efforts are being made to strengthen it.” He made this observation after inaugurating the three-day Indraprastha Cultural Festival 2026, organised by the Delhi Government. The festival brings together over 100 eminent speakers, more than 50 cultural performances, literary sessions, youth town halls, and special exhibitions, presenting India’s rich civilisational heritage alongside contempo-



rary cultural discourse on a single platform. Mishra described the festival as “a significant step towards cultural renaissance.” He stated, “The very selection of the name ‘Indraprastha’ is a cultural assertion in itself. It reflects an effort to re-establish Delhi’s historical and civilisational identity, which has long been presented within

a limited perspective.” Appreciating the efforts of Sangam Talks and all associated contributors, he remarked, “Platforms where dialogue is based on facts, logic, and evidence are the ones that truly guide society. When discourse progresses with a scientific temper and credible evidence, misinformation and falsehoods automatically diminish.”

IN FOCUS



Members of the Christian community take part in a procession on the occasion of Good Friday in Jammu on Friday

PTI

ECI directs West Bengal DGP to review lapse in police deployment



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

The Election Commission of India (ECI) has taken serious note of the deployment of police personnel for providing security to individuals allegedly linked to the ruling TMC ahead of the West Bengal elections, a senior official said on Friday.

Describing the matter as a “lapse”, the official said the poll panel has issued directions to the DGP to ensure corrective measures at the earliest.

“Before the announcement of elections, the West Bengal

Government had deployed 2,185 police personnel to provide security to 832 people belonging to Trinamool Congress directly and 144 others, who include TMC supporters,” the top official told PTI.

“The ECI has taken serious note of this lapse and has directed the DGP to conduct a strict professional review within the next 2-3 days fairly and equitably,” he added.

The Commission has emphasised that security deployment must remain impartial and in line with established norms, he said.

No cause for concern over proposed FCRA amendments, says Rijiju

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Reaching out to the Christian community on Good Friday, Union Minister Kiren Rijiju who is in Kerala campaigning for the BJP said there was no cause for concern regarding the proposed FCRA amendments.

The Union Minority Affairs Minister held discussions with representatives of the various churches and Christian organisations in the state in the evening and said that they raised concerns with regard to cancellation of FCRA licences. The concerns raised by them were “genuine”, Rijiju told reporters after the meeting.

The union minister said that no person or organisation working genuinely for the welfare of the people will be penalised.

At the same time, he said that those trying to damage national security will not be spared. Rijiju said that the Centre will target illegal people and anti-Indian groups, while protecting genuine people who are contributing to the development of the country. He said that it was the duty of the Government to listen to its citizens. “After the election, I will meet them again,” he said, and requested the Congress and Communists not to mislead people by spreading rumours about the FCRA amendments.

Father Eugene Pereira, a representative of the Latin Archdiocese here, who was present for the discussion with Rijiju, said that the union minister has promised a special designated authority to enquire into the concerns raised by the church and the Christian organisations.



Pereira also said that the minister promised to hold the amendment bill and have further discussions.

“We presented our concerns to him. He understood that our organisations play a key role in development. This bill will not be put forward in this Parliament proceedings. The minister was very positive, and he told us that he would make a representation to the prime minister, sharing our concerns,” he said.

Besides Pereira, representatives from the Syro Malabar Church, the Believers Eastern Church, the Malankara Orthodox Syrian Church and the Latin Catholic Archdiocese also attended the discussion.

Earlier, Rijiju, in a social media video, assured that minority communities, especially Christian missionaries, need not worry, as the Narendra Modi-led Government will protect their interests and offer support wherever possible.

Rijiju claimed that the Communists and Congress in Kerala are spreading rumours and misleading NGOs, especially those working for the welfare of the people, regarding the proposed amendments to

the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act. His remarks come amid Opposition to the proposed FCRA amendments from various Christian churches and priests in poll-bound Kerala.

Rijiju said that the BJP Government is only seeking to “improve” the provisions of the Act to check the “illegal flow of funds for unlawful and anti-national activities.”

“I would like to assure that no innocent person or legitimate organisation will be targeted wrongfully,” he said. “The foreign funds that come to India should be used for good purposes, for the welfare of the people. If those funds are used for radical purposes, to mislead the youth against India's interests, they must be checked,” he added.

He also assured that all minorities in India are well taken care of by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, following the spirit of *sabka saath, sabka vikas*. (with all, for the development of all).

“We work for everyone, unlike Congress, which used to make Muslims their vote bank and mislead the Christian community. That is absolutely wrong,” he claimed. “For us, everyone is equal. Every

Indian has to be treated by the same yardstick. So there is nothing to worry regarding the FCRA provisions,” Rijiju added.

The minister contended that Kerala is now witnessing massive support for the NDA parties, and therefore, the Congress and Communists are “nervous and spreading lies.” “This kind of misinformation campaign is not good for democracy,” he added.

Rijiju questioned what the Congress and Communists have done for Kerala after ruling it for a long time, turn by turn.

“In the last 12 years, many major initiatives of the Narendra Modi Government have not been properly implemented in Kerala. It deserves a better Government. So, without going into detail, I would like to assure you that whatever concerns minority communities, particularly Christian missionaries, may have, there is nothing to worry about,” he said.

“Our government will protect your interests and offer support wherever possible, he added.

He claimed that before he became Minority Affairs minister, micro-minorities “faced unfair treatment,

Amaravati as Andhra Capital has nationwide support: CM Naidu

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Amaravati

Despite alleged conspiracies orchestrated by the opposition YSRCP, Amaravati's status as the Capital of Andhra Pradesh has received unanimous support from the country, Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu said on Friday.

Addressing a press conference, Naidu asserted that after receiving the central Government's sovereign seal, no one can alter the status of the Capital city in the future.

the capital, he said that similar attempts were continuing.

“The dreams of five crore people have been fulfilled with the help of the Centre's sovereign seal. Nobody will be able to change anything in the future,” he said.

Noting that there are 50 parties in both Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha, he said, “Despite ideological and personal differences, and no direct connection to Andhra Pradesh's capital, they all supported the Amaravati Bill to safeguard the interests of the country.”



“They (YSRCP) wanted to destroy Amaravati, but we brought a law. Today, the entire country stands behind Amaravati. Overcoming all conspiracies, Amaravati has emerged victorious.”

The Andhra Pradesh Reorganisation (Amendment) Bill, 2026, making Amaravati the capital of the southern State, was passed by the Parliament.

He claimed that letters were written to the World Bank, opposing Amaravati and false narratives were spread against the project, including claims about its viability and safety.

Alleging that such actions were aimed at “damaging”

Naidu attacked the opposition party, alleging that it has no sense of national interest and is not concerned about Andhra Pradesh's progress.

He expressed his gratitude to Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah for the passage of the Amaravati Bill in Parliament.

The CM said PM Modi had laid the foundation stone for Amaravati in line with the Singapore master plan.

He further said that PM, who had originally laid the foundation stone and later returned to relaunch construction activities, is expected to inaugurate the major projects in Amaravati in 2029.

100 TPD biogas plant in Civil Lines to curb Yamuna pollution, says MCD

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 100 TPD (tonnes per day) compressed biogas plant is set to come up between the Bhalaswa and Jharoda dairies in north Delhi's Civil Lines area, aimed at managing cattle waste and preventing it from entering the Yamuna, officials said.

The proposal for the project will soon be submitted to the Municipal Corporation of Delhi by the National Dairy Development Board (NDDB). The plant is planned over an eight-acre site located between the two dairy clusters, they said.

“Around 6,000 cattle have been identified in the sur-



rounding areas, generating substantial quantities of organic waste. The facility will have a capacity of 50 tonnes per day (TPD) each for Bhalaswa and Jharoda dairies,” officials said, adding that a survey to assess cattle population and waste generation was conducted last month.

Meanwhile, experts said that nearly 80 per cent of pollution in the Yamuna in Delhi is caused by domestic sewage, while the remaining 20 per cent comes from sources such as dairy waste, solid waste dumping and small-scale industries.

“Dairy waste is not the dominant source of pollution,

but it is a low-hanging fruit, it is localised, easier to manage and can be converted into a resource,” environmentalist Bhavreen Kandhari said.

Experts further said cattle waste from dairy clusters is a relatively untapped resource in tackling pollution and can be effectively utilised under a “circular economy model” by converting waste into clean cooking fuel.

“With LPG prices rising, people have a natural economic incentive to shift towards biogas. But communities will cooperate only if they clearly see direct benefits like cheaper or free fuel. For that, creating awareness among dairy owners is very crucial,” she said.

Rain and dust storm lash Delhi; IMD issues Orange alert

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi witnessed light rainfall accompanied by thunderstorms across parts of the city after a dust storm swept through the national Capital in the morning. The India Meteorological Department has forecast thunderstorms with lightning on Saturday, with maximum temperature expected to reach 33 degrees Celsius and the minimum around 20 degrees Celsius. Two successive western disturbances are likely to affect northwest India during the week, with peak activity on Friday, Saturday and Tuesday, the IMD said.



On Friday, the maximum temperature was recorded at 33.7 degrees Celsius, 0.3 degrees below normal. An orange alert (be prepared) has been issued for South, Central, and New Delhi, while a yellow alert (be

aware) is in place for southwest, west and northeast Delhi. Station-wise data showed that Palam recorded a maximum of 32.7 degrees Celsius, 1.6 degrees below normal. Lodhi Road and the Ridge station both

logged 33 degrees Celsius, with the latter staying 1.7 degrees below normal. Ayanagar recorded 34 degrees Celsius, 0.1 degrees above normal.

Parts of the city witnessed light rain during the day, with the India Meteorological Department (IMD) forecasting light showers, thunderstorms and gusty winds in several areas later in the day as well.

Weather experts attributed the morning dust storm to a disturbance over the western Himalayas, which has induced a cyclonic circulation over central Pakistan and adjoining Haryana and Rajasthan.

FROM PAGE - 1

One crew rescued from downed US jet in Iran

Earlier, a channel affiliated with Iranian state television claimed on Friday that a US fighter pilot had ejected from an aircraft over southwestern Iran. It was not clear what may have happened to the plane, including whether Iran was claiming it was shot down or had another issue. If the claim is confirmed, it could lead to yet another dramatic escalation in the war, nearing the end of its fifth week.

Iran fired on targets across the Mideast on Friday, as Tehran kept the pressure on Israel and its Gulf Arab neighbours, despite US and Israeli insistence that Iran's military capabilities have been all but destroyed.

The anchor on the Iranian channel urged residents to hand over any “enemy pilot” to the police and promised a reward for anyone who did. The channel is in Kohkiluyeh and Boyer-Ahmad province, an intensely rural and mountainous region that spans over 15,500 square kilometres (5,900 square miles).

Authorities also urged the public to search for the pilot in neighbouring Chaharmahal and Bakhtiari province.

An on-screen crawl earlier urged the public to “shoot them if you see them,” referring to social media footage circulating of what appeared to be US aircraft in the area. The channel showed metal debris in the back of a pickup truck while making the announcement, but provided no other immediate details.

Authorities in the United Arab Emirates shut down a gas field after a missile interception reportedly rained debris on it and started a fire.

Activists reported strikes around Tehran and the central city of Isfahan, but it wasn't immediately clear what was hit. A day earlier, Iran said the US hit a major bridge, which was still under construction, killing eight people.

In Lebanon, an Israeli drone strike on worship-

pers leaving Friday prayers in the town of Sohmor killed two people and wounded 11, according to the state-run National News Agency. More than 1,900 people have been killed in Iran since the war began on Feb 28 with US and Israeli strikes. In a review released Friday, the Armed Conflict Location and Event Data, a US-based group, said they found that civilian casualties were clustered around strikes on security and state-linked sites “rather than indiscriminate bombardment” of urban areas.

NCERT now declared deemed university

Three years back, the Centre had approved granting the deemed-to-be-university status to NCERT in the ‘de-novo’ category. A de-novo deemed university is an institution that can apply to the UGC for setting up a new institution as a deemed university, which will undertake study and research in unique and emerging areas of knowledge that are not offered by any existing institution.

The notification has listed certain conditions for granting the status. These conditions prevent the NCERT from indulging in any activities that are “commercial” and “profit-making” in nature, and mandate that all academic courses or programmes must conform to the norms and standards prescribed by the UGC and the statutory bodies or councils concerned.

The notification also mandated the NCERT to start new programmes, off-campus or on off-shore campuses, “only in accordance with the norms and guidelines issued by the UGC, from time to time, on the subject”.

Currently, the graduate and post-graduate programmes offered by the NCERT's Regional Institute of Education (RIE) are affiliated with local universities like Barkatullah University, Bhopal, MDS University, Ajmer, University of Mysuru, Utkal University, Bhubaneswar and the North-Eastern

Hill University, Shillong.

Further, the MoE has said that the NCERT will take appropriate steps to begin research programmes, doctoral programmes and innovative academic programmes.

The government has also mandated the NCERT to start participating in annual rankings of institutes issued by the National Institutional Ranking Framework and has asked it to “compulsorily” create the Academic Bank of Credits (ABC), identities of its students, and upload their credit scores in digital lockers that can be reflected in the ABC portal.

Silenced, not defeated, says Chadha on RS...

However, in a veiled warning, he said, “Don't mistake my silence for surrender. I'm a quiet river now, but I know how to rise into a flood.”

Hitting back, AAP leaders, including Delhi AAP chief Saurabh Bharadwaj and IT cell head Anurag Dhanda, defended the leadership's decision and justified Chadha's ‘demotion’ in the Upper House. Bharadwaj launched a pointed attack, accusing Chadha of indulging in “soft PR” rather than taking on the PM Narendra Modi-led government. Taking a swipe at one of Chadha's parliamentary interventions, he said, “A small party gets very limited time there, and instead of talking about samosas, it is more important to raise the country's real issues.”

Bharadwaj also questioned Chadha's role in Parliament and his absence on major political issues. “Whenever there is an issue, and the opposition walks out, you do not join the walkout. For the past several years, I have not seen you raise any issue in Parliament where you questioned the Prime Minister or the BJP government. How can politics of fear work like this?” he questioned. AAP national media in-charge Anurag Dhanda also criticised Chadha, ques-

tioning whether someone who ‘fears’ Prime Minister Narendra Modi can fight for the country. In West Bengal, the right to vote is being snatched away. When a proposal against the CEC came up in the House, you (Chadha) refused to sign it,” Dhanda said on X. Former Delhi Chief Minister and senior party leader Atishi also questioned Chadha over his silence on key issues, asking why he was “so scared” of raising questions against the Centre and the BJP. “The democracy and Constitution of the country are in danger, yet you failed to speak on issues such as rising LPG prices,” she said.

CBSE implements new 3-language formula

In continuation of the board's phased implementation of multilingual education, a third language will be made mandatory from Class 6 with effect from the academic session 2026-27, ensuring that every learner studies at least two Indian languages. “While the same scheme of languages should be adopted, under exceptional circumstances for students returning from foreign schools where the third language studied till Class 8 or 9 is not available in domestic schools, such students may be exempted as per approved norms. However, such students will be required to study the total number of subjects as stipulated in the scheme of studies,” the official added.

According to the officials, the third language or R3 is not being made mandatory for Class 9 students yet. “R3 level textbooks will be introduced in Class 6 this year. They will write their board exams in 2031, and that is when the entire scheme will change, and the three-language formula will be entirely implemented,” the official added. Mathematics and science will see a major structural shift with the introduction of a two-level system starting in the 2026-27 academic session. “All students will study the

standard curriculum and appear for a common 80-mark examination of three hours; those opting for higher proficiency can choose an additional ‘advanced’ level in either or both subjects. This advanced component will consist of a separate 25-mark, one-hour paper designed to test higher-order thinking skills and deeper conceptual understanding.

“Students must mandatorily take the standard exam, while the advanced paper remains optional. Importantly, performance in the advanced paper will not be added to the overall aggregate; instead, students scoring 50 per cent or above will have the advanced-level qualification reflected separately in their mark sheet,” the official said.

The two-level system (standard and advanced) in mathematics and science will begin in the 2026-27 academic session for Class 9 students, and the first board exams for Class 10 students with this structure will be held in 2028 for that cohort. Computational thinking and artificial intelligence will also be introduced as compulsory subjects for classes 9 and 10. They will be introduced as modules with internal assessments in the current academic session, and will become a compulsory board exam subject for Class 10 in 2029. These subjects are being introduced in classes 3 to 8 in the current academic session. With the new curriculum, the board is making art education, vocational education, and physical education mandatory in classes 9 and 10. Textbooks are set to be introduced for art education and physical education.

“In the current academic session, Class 10 students will have school-based assessments for art and physical education. In the 2027-28 academic session, they will have vocational education as a compulsory subject with an annual or board exam, while art and physical education will continue to be assessed through school-based internal examinations,” he said.

Rajnath highlights Navy’s role in securing trade routes



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Visakhapatnam

Underlining that 95 per cent of the country’s trade, including energy supplies, is conducted through sea, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Friday noted the Indian Navy’s indispensable role in securing commercial shipping lanes and oil tankers against emerging maritime threats.

Speaking at the commissioning ceremony of Indian Navy Ship (INS) Taragiri here, the Defence Minister said the Indian Navy continuously maintains its presence in the Indian Ocean — whether it is the Persian Gulf or the Malacca Strait.

His comments assume significance following the disruption of oil supplies and blockage of oil tankers in view of the prevailing situation in West Asia.

According to him, a strong and capable navy is not an option for the country, but a necessity. “There are many sensitive points in the sea where our Navy has continuously made its active presence to ensure the smooth supply of goods. Whenever

there is a situation of tension there, the Indian Navy has ensured the security of our commercial ships and oil tankers,” Rajnath Singh said.

The Indian Navy has proven that it is not only capable of protecting the interests of the country, but if necessary, can also take every step to ensure the safety of its citizens and trade routes around the world, he added.

Citing history, the defence minister said that without strengthening the naval power, no country can be considered powerful in the right sense, and therefore, when Prime Minister Narendra Modi talks about Viksit Bharat by 2047, the basis of marine power becomes very important.

As the fourth platform under Project 17A, Taragiri is a 6,670-tonne warship built by Mazagon Dock Shipbuilders Limited, Mumbai, showcasing advanced design and engineering excellence.

The warship features a sleeker structure with a significantly reduced radar cross-section, enabling stealth operations and

enhanced survivability in complex maritime environments.

With indigenous content exceeding 75 per cent, the ship highlights the maturity of India’s domestic defence ecosystem, involving over 200 Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs) and supporting thousands of jobs.

Taragiri is powered by a Combined Diesel or Gas (CODOG) propulsion system, offering high-speed and high-endurance capabilities for diverse naval operations.

The frigate is equipped with advanced weapon systems, including supersonic surface-to-surface missiles, medium-range surface-to-air missiles and a specialised anti-submarine warfare suite. These systems are integrated through a modern combat management system, enabling swift and precise responses to emerging threats.

Apart from combat roles, Taragiri is designed for humanitarian assistance and disaster relief operations, enhancing its operational versatility in both peace and conflict scenarios.

Russia offers expanded energy supplies to India amid West Asia crises

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

As tensions in West Asia continue to unsettle global energy markets, Russia has stepped forward with an offer to boost crude oil and natural gas supplies to India, signalling a deepening of strategic cooperation between the two nations.

The proposal was highlighted during high-level discussions held in New Delhi on Thursday between Russia’s First Deputy Prime Minister Denis Manturov and key Indian officials, including National Security Advisor Ajit Doval and External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar. Manturov also met Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman and called on Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

Energy cooperation emerged as a central theme across these engagements, reflecting both countries’ shared interest in ensuring stability amid ongoing geopolitical disruptions. According to a Russian statement, Manturov emphasised that Russian firms are well-positioned to steadily increase supplies of both crude oil and liquefied natural gas (LNG) to meet India’s growing demand.

The discussions come at a time when the global energy landscape is under significant strain due to the ongoing crisis in West Asia. Disruptions in shipping routes, particularly through the strategically vital Strait of Hormuz, have driven up international oil and gas prices. The narrow passage handles a substantial share of the world’s energy shipments, making it a critical chokepoint for global supply.

India, which relies heavily on imports to meet its energy needs, has been particularly sensitive to these fluctuations. West Asia has traditionally been a major supplier, and any instability in the

region has immediate implications for India’s energy security.

Against this backdrop, Russia’s offer is seen as both timely and strategically significant. It not only provides India with an alternative supply channel but also reinforces the broader trajectory of strengthening bilateral ties.

The issue was also discussed during the meeting of the India-Russia Inter-Governmental Commission on Trade, Economic, Scientific, Technological and Cultural Cooperation (IRIGT-TEC), co-chaired by Manturov and Jaishankar. The two sides reviewed progress in multiple areas, including trade, industry, connectivity, and technological collaboration.

Efforts to expand bilateral trade and investment were high on the agenda. Both countries explored measures to facilitate smoother trade flows and create favourable conditions for increasing economic engagement despite the evolving global environment.

Russia also highlighted its growing role in supporting India’s agricultural sector, noting a significant rise in fertiliser exports. Supplies to India increased substantially by the end of 2025, with

Moscow expressing readiness to continue meeting Indian requirements.

In addition to energy and trade, discussions covered emerging sectors such as innovation, critical minerals, and mobility. The two sides also exchanged views on broader regional and global developments, including the West Asia conflict.

The meetings reviewed the implementation of decisions taken during the 23rd India-Russia Annual Summit held in December last year, where both countries outlined an ambitious roadmap to strengthen economic ties. The plan aims to elevate bilateral trade to USD 100 billion by 2030 through sustained cooperation across key sectors.

Civil nuclear energy also featured in the talks, with Russia expressing strong interest in expanding collaboration in this domain. Officials indicated that there is considerable potential to deepen engagement, building on existing partnerships.

As geopolitical uncertainties continue to reshape global supply chains, the India-Russia partnership appears poised to play an increasingly important role in ensuring energy security and economic resilience for both nations.



Russia’s First Deputy Prime Minister Denis Manturov meeting External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar
REPRESENTATIVE IMAGE

Nation Focus



DMK’s Kanimozhi warns BJP allies face bleak future

DMK MP Kanimozhi Karunanidhi on Friday said political parties aligning with the BJP face a bleak future, labelling the AIADMK’s ties with the saffron party a “betrayal alliance” that deceives both the State and its own cadre.

Campaigning in the Nilakottai Assembly constituency for DMK candidate Nagajyothi, Kanimozhi launched a scathing attack on AIADMK leader Edappadi K Palaniswami, accusing him of “heading a betrayal alliance” that has deceived the State and its own party cadre. “No one who formed an alliance with them (BJP) has ever had a future. Maybe, they will send you as a Governor to some State. Choose which town you like... if you tell them now, they might send you,” she said.



Congress, DMK share blame for seat confusion: Narayanasamy

Veteran Congress leader V Narayanasamy has said that both his party and the Dravidian partner, the DMK, are responsible for the confusion over seat-sharing and dismissed it as a minor setback. The DMK did not buy the argument and said it was the Congress that committed a “big mistake” of fielding nominees in six additional segments. The 78-year old former chief minister asserted that talks must not have been allowed to prolong.

In an interview with PTI, Narayanasamy dismissed the AINRC-BJP Government as a regime that completely “betrayed” the people of Puducherry.

People desire change and this was evident when we undertook a padayatra recently in Puducherry.

J&K LG orders magisterial probe into Ganderbal youth killing

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

Jammu and Kashmir Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha on Friday ordered an impartial magisterial inquiry to contain the growing public anger against the alleged killing of a local youth during an encounter in the Arhama area of Ganderbal district of Central Kashmir.

According to the communication of the Home Department dated April 2, 2026, the District Magistrate, Ganderbal has been directed to conduct a thorough and impartial inquiry into the matter to ascertain facts and circumstances leading to the

death of Rashid Ahmad Moghul.

As per the directions, the inquiry is mandated to be completed within seven days, with the final report to be submitted directly to the home department.

“I have ordered a thorough and impartial magisterial inquiry into the Arhama, Ganderbal incident. The inquiry will examine all aspects related to the incident and ensure that justice is served,” the LG’s office posted on X.

Soon after the police authorities on Wednesday revealed the identity of the deceased killed during the



A security personnel stands guard during a search operation in Ganderbal, Jammu and Kashmir on Wednesday
PTI

Arhama encounter the family members of the deceased raised hue and cry claiming he was killed in a

fake encounter. The family had also demanded a high level probe into the incident.

After the encounter was over, Srinagar based Chinar Corps posted on X, “During the night of 31 Mar 26, the cordon was tactically reorganised amidst the intermittent firing underway. Own troops effectively retaliated with a calibrated response resulting in one terrorist eliminated”.

Chief minister Omar Abdullah on Thursday also demanded a “transparent and time-bound” probe with public disclosure of facts, while PDP president Mehbooba Mufti alleged the incident was a “fake encounter,” identifying the deceased as an orphan who operated an NGO.

UDF renewed hope for people of Kerala: Rahul

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Thiruvananthapuram

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Friday shared a video on social media of him enjoying a hearty breakfast with party leaders in Kerala recently, while discussing the ground realities in connection with the Assembly polls in the State. Kerala will go to the polls on April 9.

In the video, he sits down to breakfast with Congress general secretary KC Venugopal, Leader of Opposition in the State assembly V D Satheesan, and some party candidates, and holds discussions with them on



issues such as brain drain, lack of jobs, and the proposed amendments to the FCRA.

“In between bites of appam, puttu, and omelette, the UDF leaders and I had a very interesting conversation on the ground realities of the Kerala election. It’s evident that Kerala deserves change—an overhaul of the education

system, real opportunities for youth, and a Government that supports its people in sickness and old age,” the former MP from Wayanad Lok Sabha constituency, said in his post on ‘X’.

“UDF is a renewed hope for the people of Kerala—our team is strong, united, and ready to lead,” he added.

During the breakfast meeting, Satheesan informed Rahul about how the Congress-led UDF was “exposing and criticising” the Government for a long time.

“For the first time, we are bringing alternatives wherever the Government has failed,” he said.

Indian airlines begin partial resumption of Middle East flights amid ongoing conflict

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Domestic carriers such as IndiGo, Air India and SpiceJet have initiated a phased restoration of flight operations to and from the Middle East, even as widespread disruptions persist due to airspace restrictions linked to the ongoing US-Israel conflict involving Iran.

The resumption remains limited, with airlines operating select routes while closely monitoring the evolving security situation.

Thousands of flights continue to be cancelled across the region, reflecting the

scale of disruption to global aviation networks.

IndiGo announced that it would operate 17 departures, covering 34 flight sectors, to eight destinations in the Middle East on Friday. The airline said it is working in coordination with relevant authorities to progressively reinstate more services while ensuring passenger safety.

Similarly, Air India and its subsidiary Air India Express confirmed the resumption of flights to key destinations such as Jeddah and Muscat after authorities reopened the airspace over Saudi Arabia and Oman.

SpiceJet, meanwhile, has scheduled special evacuation-oriented flights from the United Arab Emirates to India on March 6 and 7, with additional services planned for March 8.

These flights are aimed at assisting passengers affected by cancellations and travel uncertainty across the region.

Airlines have urged passengers to remain cautious and follow official communication channels.

IndiGo specifically advised travellers to wait for direct notifications regarding their flight status before heading to airports, given the fluid situation.



ation. Air India also announced ad-hoc repatriation flights from major regional hubs including Dubai, Ras Al Khaimah and Fujairah on March 6, subject to regulatory clearances.

However, the airline clarified that scheduled services to several other West Asian destinations will remain suspended until March 10.

To ease passenger inconvenience, Air India has offered flexibility in ticket changes.

Travellers holding tickets issued until March 4 for journeys between February 28 and March 8 can reschedule their travel within one month

without incurring additional charges or fare differences.

The aviation sector continues to face significant operational challenges.

Traffic at Dubai International Airport showed signs of recovery on Thursday, nearly doubling from the previous day, though it still stood at only about a quarter of normal levels.

Industry data underscores the magnitude of disruption: more than 44,000 flights were scheduled across the Middle East between February 28 and March 5, but over 25,000 have been cancelled so far due to the crisis.

India’s aviation regulator, the Directorate General of Civil Aviation, said it is actively coordinating with airlines and other stakeholders.

A dedicated Passenger Assistance Control Room has been set up to support stranded travellers and address grievances.

Authorities also emphasised that airfares are being closely monitored to prevent any unreasonable surge during the crisis period, as efforts continue to stabilise operations in one of the world’s most critical aviation corridors.

Ganga meets bathing standards, pollution levels declining: Govt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Ganga water meets bathing standards at all monitored locations and pollution levels in the river are declining, according to the Government.

In a written reply to a question in the Lok Sabha, Minister of State for Jal Shakti Raj Bhushan Choudhary on Thursday said pH and dissolved oxygen levels of the river meet the required norms for bathing criteria across all locations, based on median water quality data for 2025 (January to August).

He said the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) monitors water quality of the River



Ganga at 112 locations across five main-state States of Uttarakhand (19), Uttar Pradesh (41), Bihar (33), Jharkhand (4) and West Bengal (15).

The minister said water quality with respect to biochemical oxygen demand (BOD) conforms to bathing criteria in the entire stretch of

the river in Uttarakhand, Jharkhand, Bihar and West Bengal, except certain stretches in Uttar Pradesh, including Farrukhabad to Purana Rajapur in Kanpur, Dalmou in Raebareilly, and downstream Mirzapur to Tarighat in Ghazipur.

He said bio-monitoring

conducted during 2024-25 at 50 locations along River Ganga and its tributaries and 26 locations along River Yamuna indicates that biological water quality predominantly ranges from “good” to “moderate”, reflecting the ecological potential of the rivers to sustain aquatic life.

The minister said a “diverse and holistic set of interventions” has been undertaken under the Namami Gange Programme for cleaning and rejuvenation of Ganga and its tributaries, including waste water treatment, river front management, ensuring e-flow, rural sanitation, afforestation, biodiversity conservation and public participation.

US-sanctioned tanker diverts Iranian oil from India to China

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A US-sanctioned Aframax tanker carrying Iranian crude oil has rerouted mid-voyage from a planned destination in India to China, according to ship-tracking data, preventing what would have been India’s first such import in nearly seven years.

The vessel in question is the Ping Shun (built in 2002, Eswatini-flagged, sanctioned by the US Treasury’s Office of Foreign Assets Control in 2025). It is on time charter to Iran’s State-owned National Iranian Oil Company (NIOC) and was carrying approximately 600,000 barrels (6



lakh barrels) of Iranian crude, loaded earlier in March from Iran’s Kharg Island.

Earlier this week, the tanker began signalling Vadinar in Gujarat, India, home to Nayara Energy’s refinery, as its destination. This raised expectations of the first Indian purchase of Iranian crude since

imports largely halted in 2019 due to US sanctions pressure.

Near the Indian coast, the ship took a sharp turn south and is now signalling Dongying in China’s Shandong province as its destination.

Data from tracking firms Kpler and Vortexa confirm the change. The final destination

could still shift, but it has reverted to Iran’s dominant export pattern, China has taken over 90 percent of Iran’s crude exports in recent years.

Analysts, including Sumit Ritolia of Kpler, attribute the reroute primarily to payment-related issues. Iran has reportedly tightened terms, shifting away from 30-60-day credit windows toward upfront or near-term settlement, which complicated the deal for Indian buyers amid ongoing US sanctions risks. A temporary US sanctions waiver (issued March 21, 2026, allowing transactions for already-loaded cargoes until April 19) did not resolve counterparty or financial channel concerns.

■ States Focus ■



500 CAPF COMPANIES TO STAY IN BENGAL AFTER MAY 4

Around 500 companies of Central Armed Police Forces (CAPFs) will continue to remain deployed in West Bengal even after counting of votes on May 4 for post-poll law and order duties, an Election Commission official said on Friday. An additional 200 CAPF companies will be retained in the State for security of electronic voting machines (EVMs), strong rooms and counting centres, the official said. "Around 500 companies of CAPFs shall continue to remain deployed in West Bengal for post-poll law and order duties even after the completion of counting, till further orders," the official said. "In addition to the 500 companies, another 200 companies shall be retained in the State for security arrangements of EVMs, strong rooms and counting centres and remain deployed till the completion of counting," he said.



DMK AND AIADMK ALLIES FACE OFF IN 21 CONSTITUENCIES

As smaller parties rally behind the Dravidian majors, ruling DMK and Opposition AIADMK have allowed their allies in a direct duel in 21 constituencies in the April 23 Assembly election to prove their strength in their respective strongholds. These smaller parties, divided among the two major combines – the SPA (under the DMK) and the AIADMK-led NDA – will have the backing of the Dravidian majors, respectively, but they would have to eventually demonstrate their individual influence among the voters in the seats they are contesting.

Only NDA can free Assam of infiltration, protect its culture: Yogi

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Barpeta/Barchalla

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Friday said that only the BJP-led NDA can free Assam from infiltrators and prevent demographic change. Asserting that BJP Governments deliver what is promised, he said it would ensure “*Virasat-Vikash*” (heritage and development) stay together.

Addressing back-to-back rallies in Barpeta and Barchalla, the BJP leader alleged that the Congress had failed to protect the State and its people during its long tenure in power.

“The Congress had been in power for 60 years in Assam. But it only encouraged infiltration, violence and riots. It put the local culture and heritage under threat,” he said, campaigning for Asom Gana Parishad (AGP) candidate Dipak Kumar Das in Barpeta.

He also targeted the AIUDF, charging it with encouraging infiltrators and aiming to come to power with their support.

“The Congress and AIUDF are working together to compromise the culture and heritage of the State,” he said.

The UP chief minister asserted that the NDA Government would ensure peace and protection in the State.

“Each infiltrator will be identified and driven out. BJP-led NDA will not allow love jihad and land jihad and



Uttar Pradesh CM Yogi Adityanath during a public rally ahead of the Assam Assembly elections in Borchala, Sonitpur district

any change in the demography,” he said.

Adityanath said the NDA would ensure “*virasat-vikash*” (heritage and development) stay together, as it has done in States where it is in power.

“Assam has witnessed a massive transformation in the last 10 years, and I urge your sustained support for the NDA in this election,” he said.

Citing the example of his State, Adityanath claimed that there have been no riots or curfew in the northern State in the last nine years of BJP regime.

“No one can read namaz on the roads. No one can shout out from any place of worship in Uttar Pradesh anymore,” he said. The construction of the Ram temple is another instance of the BJP delivering on its promise, the UP CM added.

Taking a swipe at the Congress over the cancellation of its Barpeta candidate’s nomination, he said the party had “fled the

Mamata blames AIMIM, ISF for Malda gherao incident

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Hariampur (West Bengal)

West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee on Friday blamed the AIMIM and ISF for the gherao of judicial officers in Malda district and accused the Congress and the BJP of instigation.

Stating that the mastermind behind Wednesday’s gherao of the judicial officers for several hours in Malda district’s Mothabari was arrested by the State’s CID, Banerjee claimed that this police organisation is still under her control and not of the Election Commission.

“The BJP loaned him (the accused) from the AIMIM and brought him here,” she alleged, while addressing an election rally at Hariampur in Dakshin Dinajpur district.

“ISF is with them; Congress and BJP have also provided instigation,” the Trinamool Congress chief alleged, stating that the Criminal Investigation Department (CID) arrested the main accused, advocate Mofakkarul Islam, from Bagdogra airport when he was trying to flee.

“It is they who engineered the violence in Malda’s Mothabari,” she said.

Alleging that goons were being brought in from outside to create unrest in poll-bound West Bengal, Banerjee said, “They don’t even spare the judges.”

Banerjee accused the AIMIM, whose chief Asaduddin Owaisi has come out in support of Aam Janata Unnayan Party

(AJUP), floated recently by former TMC MLA Humayun Kabir, of having divided votes in the Bihar assembly elections to help the BJP win the polls.

Kabir has vowed to take on the TMC and also the BJP in all assembly seats in Muslim-majority Murshidabad district.

Pointing out that voters’ names were deleted during the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) exercise and expressing agreement with their anguish, Banerjee said she has fought for their rights and for their names to be included in the electoral rolls.

She questioned why the assembly polls could not be conducted with the same electoral rolls used in the 2024 general elections. “If the voter list contained names of infiltrators, Modi also won with their votes earlier, so he should resign first,” she said.

“Money is being brought in using CRPF vehicles,” she alleged, claiming that she knows where these were going.

“I have a record of these movements and will expose them at the appropriate time,” she said. Banerjee said that the presence of Union Home Minister Amit Shah in West Bengal during the polls will lead to a reduction in the BJP’s vote share.

Shah has said he would camp in West Bengal for 15 days during the two-phase assembly elections in the State on April 23 and 29.

“You may stay in West Bengal for 365 days, but that will not change anything,” Banerjee said.



West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee addressing a public meeting ahead of the State Assembly elections in Dakshin Dinajpur

Accusing the BJP of having created a ruckus near her Kalighat residence on Thursday during the nomination rally of Leader of Opposition Suwendu Adhikari, led by Shah, she said, “It is futile to expect any courtesy from them.”

Claiming that the names of 40,000 voters of Bhabanipur constituency, from where she is contesting to get reelected, have been deleted in the SIR exercise, she asserted, despite that the TMC will win this election.

“I am your candidate in all the 294 constituencies in the State... Forget whose name is there as our party nominee,” the TMC chief said.

Kerala CM slams Revanth Reddy for misinformed attack

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan on Thursday hit back at his Telangana counterpart Revanth Reddy after the latter’s sharp criticism of the Left Government during a campaign visit to the State.

In a Facebook post, Vijayan said the Telangana Chief Minister was “misinformed,” and accused Reddy of “ridiculing” Kerala and its people while concealing the weaknesses of his own State.

“By conveniently ignoring



Kerala CM Pinarayi Vijayan

the bulldozing of the homes of the poor in his own State, he appears ready to lecture Kerala on social progress and

public welfare – clearly, he has been seriously misinformed by someone,” Vijayan wrote.

“Telangana Chief Minister is welcome to Kerala to learn about welfare models”, the Kerala CM said. He said Reddy, while campaigning for the UDF candidates for the April 9 Assembly polls in Kerala, had made remarks against the State.

Inviting Reddy to the State to learn about its welfare model, Vijayan said Kerala was moving forward through “sustainable and inclusive development”. He also

accused Reddy of backing those trying to undermine it.

Responding to allegations of corruption and administrative failure, Vijayan said, “He claims that Kerala is marked by ‘corruption and administrative failure’, but he should be willing to look at official data. Is he unaware that Kerala is among the least corrupt States in the country?”

Citing figures, he pointed out that Kerala ranked first in the NITI Aayog Sustainable Development Index (2023–24) with 79 points, while Telangana was placed sixth.

PM Modi holds roadshow to back AINRC-BJP in Puducherry polls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Puducherry

Prime Minister Narendra Modi held a grand roadshow on Friday and sought support for the AINRC-BJP alliance in the April 9 election to the territorial Assembly.

The Prime Minister, flanked by AINRC founder leader Chief Minister N Rangasamy and BJP leader, Home Minister A Namassivayam, held his roadshow between the Ajanta signal point and the Kamarajar statue/Raja theatre signal, a distance of less than 2 km, and it took nearly an hour for the show to conclude.

Earlier, on his arrival, he was accorded a rousing welcome by the BJP workers amid chants of ‘*Bharat Mata Ki Jai*



PM Narendra Modi during a roadshow ahead of the Puducherry Assembly elections in Puducherry

and ‘*Jai Shri Ram*’. As the prime minister’s open campaign vehicle slowly moved on, he waved at the people, and they showered flowers on

him and his campaign vehicle.

Flags of the BJP-AINRC Congress fluttered all across the city, and it was maximum from the SV Patel Road, the starting point of the roadshow and till the Anna Salai-Kamarajar Salai junction where the event culminated. Police had made elaborate security arrangements in view of the prime minister’s visit.

Cultural shows and traditional dance programmes added colour and spice to the PM’s roadshow in Puducherry. A large number of supporters had gathered well in advance to welcome the prime minister, and party leaders were confident that the PM’s visit would boost the victory prospects of the ruling AINRC-BJP combine.

BJP seeks clarity from Stalin over alleged Raja audio tape

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

Tamil Nadu BJP spokesperson Narayanan Thirupathy demanded on Friday that Tamil Nadu Chief Minister MK Stalin should “come out very clear” regarding an alleged audio tape of DMK MP A Raja, asserting that the clip exposes the ruling party’s true stance on social justice.

An unverified audio clip was released on social media, which allegedly features Raja expressing grievances about his time in prison as an undertrial in the 2G spectrum allocation scam case, in which he was ultimately

acquitted by the trial court.

In the audio, the speaker (purported to be Raja) claims that during his imprisonment in Tihar Jail, the DMK leadership completely ignored him. He allegedly States that no one from the party visited him for two months until Kanimozhi was also brought to the prison.

Addressing a press conference here, Thirupathy said: “Now, that shows the Dravida model, DMK’s attitude towards, you know, social justice. Raja very clearly says that he was in jail and till Kanimozhi came to Tihar Jail, nobody visited him from DMK.”

Challenging the DMK leadership to refute the claims,



Tamil Nadu BJP spokesperson Narayanan Thirupathy

Thirupathy said the person who had released the audio had openly challenged DMK leadership to sue him if they have the guts.

“Both Stalin and Raja have to come clean on this,”

ABHISHEK BANERJEE SLAMS CENTRE

Kolkata: Senior TMC leader Abhishek Banerjee on Friday accused the Narendra Modi Government of causing hardships to people through “mishandling” of issues such as LPG supply, demonetisation, SIR hearings and the lockdown. Addressing an election rally in West Bengal’s Purulia district in support of party candidate Arjun Mahato from Joypur Assembly seat, Banerjee alleged that prices of essential commodities have risen sharply under the present dispensation.

“Prices of LPG cylinders have risen from ₹400 to ₹1,000, milk from ₹28 to over ₹60, kerosene from ₹14 to ₹40. Prices of every essential commodity have skyrocketed,” he claimed. “The Modi Government only forces people to stand in long queues - from LPG dealers’ camps to SIR hearing camps, from bank branches and ATMs after notebandi. It never thinks about the agony and misery of people,” he said.

Banerjee also referred to the days of lockdown, which “was declared by the Modi Government in an unplanned manner,” and how it compounded the misery of thousands of migrant workers from Bengal who were stranded at their workplaces due to the sudden shutdown and had great difficulty in returning.

Alleging that the BJP was trying to control the Election Commission and influence the elections in West Bengal in their favour, the Diamond Harbour MP said, “They (BJP) have the remote control, but we have the EVM button which they cannot take away from us.”

Accusing BJP MP Jyotirmoy Singh Mahato of “doing little to improve the living conditions of the electors in Purulia Lok Sabha constituency, Banerjee said, “I dare both Mahato and the local BJP MLA, Narahari Mahato, to submit a break-up of projects you have implemented for the people.”

BJP announces 27 candidates for Tamil Nadu Assembly polls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi/Chennai

The BJP on Friday released a list of 27 candidates for the Tamil Nadu Assembly polls, fielding Union Minister L Murugan from the Avanashi seat and former Telangana Governor Tamilisai Soundararajan from Mylapore.

Though it was speculated that former State party chief K Annamalai would be fielded, he had asked the party to relieve him of the responsibility of campaign manager, citing his father’s health.

In March, he had said that he had not sought an opportunity to contest.

BJP Mahila Morcha national president Vanathi Srinivasan will contest from Coimbatore (North), according to the list issued by the party.

The party has named Kirthika Shivkumar as its candidate from Modakkurichi, S Vijayadharani from Vilavancode, and Nagesh Kumar from the Thalli seat.

Polling for the 234-

member Tamil Nadu Assembly is scheduled to be held on April 23.

The party has retained three sitting MLAs, renominating senior leader MR Gandhi from Nagercoil. Party president Nainar Nagenthran, who won from the Tirunelveli constituency in the 2021 election, has been fielded from Sattur.

Vanathi Srinivasan, who defeated actor-politician Kamal Haasan from Coimbatore South, has been nominated from Coimbatore North.

The party has nominated Kirthika Shivkumar from Modakkurichi, from where BJP candidate C Saraswathi, a doctor by profession, defeated DMK leader Subbulakshmi Jagadeesan in 2021. Both Sattur and Coimbatore North were allotted to the AIADMK during seat-sharing negotiations.

The AIADMK had offered the Avanashi (SC) seat, from where its former Speaker P Dhanapal had won in the previous election.



been falsely reporting about a planned public rally in Tamil Nadu, and subsequently spreading fake news that the event was cancelled because the Prime Minister “suddenly got angry”. Condemning these speculative reports, he questioned where this “screenplay and direction” was coming from, terming them entirely baseless.

Clarifying the official schedule, he stated, “He is coming here (Chennai), and he’s going to Puducherry. He will be staying here tonight. And tomorrow he will be meeting some important people before leaving for Kochi in Kerala for campaigning.”

PM, Himanta prepared roadmap for tribal development, BJP’s win to ensure its implementation: Shah

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Friday said Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma have prepared a roadmap for tribal development, and the BJP’s return to power in the State would ensure its implementation. Addressing a rally at Dudhnoi in Goalpara district, Shah said that Congress never made an Adivasi woman the country’s President, but Modi changed that, and Droupadi

Murmu became the nation’s first citizen.

“The Prime Minister at the Centre and the Chief Minister in Assam have a roadmap for the development of tribals in the State. It will be taken forward if people give the BJP a mandate for the third successive time,” he said.

Addressing a rally in Kamrup district’s Palashbari, Shah said there are allegations that the Assam Congress president has links with India’s enemy country. “But he stays conspicuous-

ly mum about it,” Shah said.

He also accused the Congress of trying to stop a Bill for setting up an IIM in Palashbari. It was the BJP which ensured that the institute was set up in the State, he asserted, adding that BJP’s policy for the State was ‘Approach Assam, Aspire Assam and Inspire Assam’.

In Dudhnoi, Shah alleged that the Congress never spoke of tribal welfare and its successive Governments since Independence had spent only ₹25,000 crore on



Union Minister Amit Shah at a public rally in Goalpara, Assam

tribal development. But in the past 11 years, the prime minister has given ₹1.38 lakh crore for the community, he said. The Union Minister termed Goalpara ‘Mini Assam’ as several tribes, including the Rabha, Bodo, Hajong, and Koch, along with Adivasi tea garden workers, reside in the district. Only the BJP can ensure their development, he said.

Shah also asserted that tribal areas will not come under the ambit of the Uniform Civil Code (UCC).

“The Congress is spreading rumours to scare tribals that they will be affected by the UCC, but this is absolutely untrue, and no tribal will fall under its ambit,” he said.

“Each tribal family will be given a cow and a buffalo, and I, as the cooperation minister, will ensure this,” Shah said.

On the recent violence in the adjoining Garo hills of Meghalaya, Shah said that infiltrators sought to capture power in the Garo council by marrying tribal women, and

this led to the strife.

He accused the Congress of making Assam a hub for infiltrators, and the BJP Government has already started the process of sending them back. “Give us another five years in power in Assam, and we will rid the State of each and every identified infiltrator by sending them back,” he said.

Elections to Assam’s 126 assembly constituencies will be held on April 9, with the counting of votes scheduled on May 4.



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Order Order

Thane MACT awards ₹44.13 lakh compensation to kin of man crushed to death by crane

Thane: The Motor Accident Claims Tribunal (MACT) in Maharashtra's Thane district has granted a compensation of ₹44.13 lakh to the family of a 46-year-old man who died after a JCB crane crashed into a motorcycle in 2020.

Tribunal member RV Mohite directed the crane owner and the insurer New India Assurance Co. Ltd. to jointly and severally pay the compensation with 9 per cent interest per annum from the date of the petition. A copy of the order passed on March 24 was made available on Friday.

The accident occurred on February 5, 2020, when the victim, Prabhakar Bajrangji Sharma, was riding pillion on a motorcycle and a speeding JCB crane first dashed into a pedestrian and then hit the two-wheeler and ran over him.

Sharma, who was employed as an assistant manager in an automobile firm, sustained serious injuries and died during treatment at a hospital in Navi Mumbai.

The vehicle owner and the insurance company contended before the tribunal that the motorcyclist had been negligent. However, it rejected these claims, citing a lack of evidence.

"The evidence on record shows that the operator of the offending vehicle (crane) was driving it in a rash and negligent manner," the tribunal stated, observing that there was nothing on record to show any contributory act on the part of the deceased. The insurance company sought to avoid liability by claiming the crane operator did not have a valid licence for the vehicle. The tribunal dismissed this technicality, noting that the unladen weight of the JCB was 7,460 kg, falling under the Light Motor Vehicle (LMV) category.

The tribunal awarded ₹44.13 lakh compensation to the deceased man's wife and three sons.



Tripura HC directs State to submit ATR on infiltration

Agartala: The Tripura High Court has asked the State Government to submit a detailed report on the steps taken to prevent infiltration from across the border within the next three months, an advocate said on Friday.

A division bench headed by Chief Justice MS Ramachandra Rao issued the directive on Thursday while hearing a petition filed by three persons, including Tipra Motha Party MLA Ranjit Debbarma.

The petitioners alleged that despite the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) issuing guidelines for preventing infiltration, the state government has failed to take effective measures to address the problem. "The division bench asked the State Government to submit a detailed report within the next three months on the steps taken to detect, detain and deport infiltrators, as per the MHA guidelines," Anthony Debbarma, who represented the petitioners, said.



HC protects personality rights of preacher Aniruddhacharya

New Delhi: The Delhi High Court has protected the personality rights of preacher Aniruddhacharya, who is also popular as 'Pookie' Baba, and restrained the unauthorised use of his name, voice and image for creating memes, videos or any other content, including AI or deepfake content.

Justice Tushar Rao Gedela passed the interim order on March 30 on a lawsuit by Aniruddhacharya. The court also directed social media entities, Meta, X and Google to take down the offending content identified by the plaintiff, which unlawfully used or imitated his persona. The court opined that there was prima facie a strong case in favour of the plaintiff, who was a well-known, popular and well-accepted personality. The court stated that the nature of the content flagged by him was not "mere parody" and appeared to be disparaging and infringing his personality rights.



Can disabled cadets can be treated as ex-servicemen, SC asks Centre

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court has asked the Centre if military cadets who become unfit due to disabilities sustained during training can be given ex-servicemen status, enabling them to avail reservation benefits in Government and semi-Government jobs.

A bench of Justices BV Nagarathna and Ujjal Bhuyan said a majority of the military cadets were below the age of 30 and would need employment.

"During the course of submissions, one of the aspects that was discussed was as to whether the boarded-out cadets could also be considered as ex-servicemen or ex-military personnel for the purpose of having the benefit of reservation for such persons in various governmental and semi-Government jobs and posts," the bench said.

"Learned ASG to seek instructions on this aspect, so that the scope of the ex-military personnel could also include the boarded-out cadets, since a majori-

Digital integration a procedural norm: Justice Nath

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Ahmedabad

Technology has not replaced constitutional institutions but has changed the environment in which their legitimacy is formed, Supreme Court Justice Vikram Nath said on Friday, noting that digital integration is no longer an "add-on" but a procedural norm.

He was delivering the 21st Justice PD Desai Memorial Lecture on 'Open Justice in Digital Republic' here.

Justice Nath stated that the live streaming of court proceedings strengthens accountability within the system, widens access for strangers, keeps an institution connected to its people, and can become one of the most effective instruments to improve legal literacy in India.

"Citizens today learn, debate, criticise and participate through phones and platforms. Public accountability is increasingly shaped in digital spaces. Technology has not replaced constitutional institutions, but it has changed the environment in which their legitimacy is formed," Justice Nath said.

The digital is no longer an add-on, but part of the procedural norms, he said,

adding that openness becomes a privilege of geography and resources if we measure it only with physical access.

"If technology can extend the public gallery without compromising dignity and fairness, openness becomes closer to a constitutional promise that is usable to the citizen at large. Once openness can travel through technology, the real question is how we design it responsibly," he said.

Justice Nath pointed out that a constitutional idea becomes meaningful only when it is translated into an institutional habit, and this needs planning, discipline and a design that ordinary people can actually use.

He further said that Gujarat's experience with live-streaming court proceedings is a valuable case study.

Justice Nath served as the chief justice of the Gujarat High Court when it launched live proceedings on YouTube on October 26, 2020, during the COVID-19 lockdown, becoming the first high court in the country to do so. It went on to launch live streaming of full court in July 2021.

Now, 19 high courts have



made live streaming operational, he said, adding that while the broader ecosystem is clearly expanding, it also shows unevenness because implementation and quality differ widely.

Streaming exists in many places, but the experience can be difficult for ordinary viewers, as links can be hard to locate, streaming can be intermittent, etc., he said.

"Gujarat has stood out. It has pursued live streaming with simplicity that respects and prioritises users. Proceedings are streamed on an official YouTube

channel in a manner that allows citizens to find courtrooms with ease and to follow proceedings without needing insider guidance," he said.

The SC judge said that while live streaming is only the first step, the next frontier is comprehension, accessibility and authenticity, the ability of citizens to follow what is happening, to locate it later and to trust that what is being seen is genuine.

And this is where artificial intelligence will increasingly enter the courtroom ecosystem, he said.

SC modifies order, asks RPSC to allow one aspirant instead of 713 to appear in exam

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Friday modified its April 2 order and directed the Rajasthan Public Service Commission to permit one candidate instead of 713 to appear in the sub-inspector police/platoon commander recruitment examination, 2025, scheduled on April 5-6.

In a relief to the RPSC (Rajasthan Public Service Commission), a bench of Justices Dipankar Datta and Satish Chandra Sharma, which assembled on a holiday, modified its Thursday order.

The RPSC is scheduled to hold the examination for recruitment of 1,015 sub-inspectors/platoon commanders on April 5-6 and over 7.70 lakh candidates are likely to appear in the test.

The order was passed on



an application filed by the RPSC alleging that material facts were suppressed from the bench, which asked it to issue provisional admit cards to 713 candidates including applicant Suraj Mal Meena who had approached the court.

On Thursday, the bench took up Meena's plea and granted relief to him and 712 others by asking the RPSC to issue admit cards to all of them. It said the results of those who would appear in

the examination in terms of its order would not be published till such time that the Rajasthan High Court pronounced its verdict on two separate petitions related to the test.

On Friday, taking note of submissions by the RPSC's counsel, the bench modified its order and restricted the relief of allowing over 700 candidates to take up the test to Meena alone.

The bench, however, said the other candidates, who

are not before the apex court, may approach the high court and seek permission to reappear if the pending verdict asks the RPSC to conduct a further test for them.

The test for sub-inspectors and platoon commanders in the state was earlier cancelled following allegations of large-scale irregularities and malpractices.

The RPSC decided to hold a fresh exam without granting any age relaxation to those who were barred on this count. This led to the filing of a petition before the single-judge bench of the high court in Jaipur.

The candidates were allowed provisionally to appear in the exam. This order was later stayed by the division bench of the high court, leading the aggrieved candidate to approach the top court.

HC stays Haryana's stilt-plus-four floors policy

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Chandigarh

The Punjab and Haryana High Court on Thursday stayed the operation of the Haryana Government's 'stilt-plus-four floors' policy for residential plots, observing that the State appears to have put public safety at risk merely to earn more revenue.

The interim order came on a petition challenging the July 2, 2024 order issued by the additional chief secretary of the town and country planning department. The order had permitted construction of 'stilt-plus-four floors' on residential plots, raising the earlier cap of 'stilt-plus-three floors'. It had also introduced a composition mechanism even in cases where building plans had not been approved.

The order was passed by a division bench of Chief Justice Sheel Nagu and Justice Sanjiv Berry.

"It appears that the State of Haryana merely to earn more revenue has put the safety and security of members of general public at stake," the court observed. The bench also said the State and its functionaries had ignored the desperate shortage of infrastructure in Gurugram while implementing the policy.

"State and its functionaries turning a Nelson's eye towards the desperate



shortage of infrastructural requirement in Gurugram city have given a go by to the all important aspect of conducting 'Infrastructure Capacity Audit' before implementing the stilt + 4 policy. It thus seems that the State has abdicated its constitutional duty of ensuring clean and healthy urban environment for the citizens of Gurugram," the order read.

The court said that as the arguments in the matter were taking time to conclude, it was appropriate at this stage to restrain the State from implementing the policy.

"Since the arguments are taking long time to conclude for reasons attributed

to the counsel for the rival parties, it is deemed appropriate by this Court, at this stage, without commenting on the validity of the impugned order/notification dated 02.07.2024, to restrain the State from going ahead with the 'stilt + 4 floor policy' for the residential plots and to stay the effect and operation of the impugned order/notification (Annexure P-6) for the time being, till the next date of hearing," the order said.

During final arguments on January 1, the court took note of photographs submitted by the petitioner which prima facie showed that internal roads in Sector 28, DLF Phase-I, Gurugram were as narrow as 12 to 15 feet.

The court then constituted a commission comprising the additional advocate general of Haryana or his nominee, counsel for the petitioner and the secretary of the District Legal Services Authority, Gurugram, to carry out a physical inspection of the area and examine the prescribed width of internal roads and the actual width available for traffic.

According to the inspection report, the prescribed width of the internal roads in Sector 28, DLF Phase-I, Gurugram is either 10 metres or 12 metres — measured from the boundary wall of one private plot to the boundary wall of the plot opposite.



Courts not experts in faith, says seers' body SEEKS TO INTERVENE IN SABARIMALA CASE

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Courts should not determine essential religious practices as they are a matter of faith held to be sacred by the followers of a religion, the Akhil Bharatiya Sant Samiti has told the Supreme Court while seeking to intervene in the upcoming Sabarimala review proceedings.

A nine-judge bench headed by Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant is set to commence the final hearing on April 7 on petitions relating to discrimination against women at religious places, including the Sabarimala temple in Kerala, and on the ambit and scope of the religious freedom practiced by multiple faiths.

In September 2018, a five-judge Constitution bench had, by a 4:1 majority verdict, lifted a ban that prevented females between the ages of 10 and 50 years from entering the Ayyappa shrine at Sabarimala and held that the centuries-old Hindu religious practice was illegal and unconstitutional.

The Akhil Bharatiya Sant Samiti, in its plea filed through lawyer Atulesh Kumar, has sought the court's nod to intervene in the Sabarimala review proceedings.

The organisation, which describes itself as an umbrella body representing 127 sects of the Sanatan Dharma, including approximately 18.5 lakh priests and 12 lakh seers, has said courts are not equipped to act as "experts" in religious matters. The plea says the judiciary should only intervene in religious practices if those directly violate public order

but also counterfeit transparency — the appearance of authenticity without authenticity itself. That is why open justice will increasingly require infrastructure," he added.

Justice Nath said that the idea of open justice is older than any technology and deeper than a mere rule that a courtroom should be open to the public.

"Open justice is understood as a constitutional method of exercising judicial power. Courts have a duty to decide disputes that involve liberty, livelihood, property, reputation and rights. ...A constitutional democracy insists that adjudication by a court must not be done in secrecy; the process must be capable of public scrutiny. Courts do not derive authority from secrecy; they derive authority from reasoned public work," he said.

Open justice is also broader than mere entry into a courtroom, he said.

"It has several elements, each of which contributes to its legitimacy. Entitlement of people to attend court as a spectator; full, fair and accurate reporting; duty of judges to give reasoned decisions; public access to judgments," Justice Nath said.

or on the grounds of morality and health. It says the fundamental right to equality (guaranteed under Article 14 of the Constitution) should not be used to override the right to freely profess and practice religion (Article 25).

"Religion is a matter of faith and religious beliefs are held to be sacred by those who share the same faith. Thought, faith and belief are internal, while expression and worship are external manifestations thereof... the phrase 'equally entitled to', as it occurs in Article 25(1), must mean that each devotee is equally entitled to profess, practice and propagate his religion, as per the tenets of that religion," the plea has said.

"The courts should not determine the essential religious practices because the court is not an expert in religious matters/practice. The courts should step in only when such religious practice violates public order, morality or health," it has added.

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विद्युत पारेषण मण्डल-ग्रथम, पनकी, कानपुर
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Editor's
TAKE

Is the old world order giving way?

The crisis in West Asia is causing structural shift in global power. The post-World War II order, long anchored by the US, now appears to be eroding

After every great upheaval, the world order shifts and readjusts to the new realities as new players emerge and the old players, worn out by war and drained of their resources, are often relegated to the background. The West Asian crisis is perhaps this peculiar moment for the US. If one country has paid heavily for this war, it is the United States of America. Its attrition is staggering, perhaps running into billions of dollars and more than that it has lost its credibility in the eyes of its allies and the Gulf countries, which it was supposed to protect. Dubai, Saudi Arabia and other US supporters are bearing the brunt and facing the heat as their skies lit up every night with the Iranian missiles and drones. Moreover, the US failed to open the Strait of Hormuz which is choked by Iran, disrupting the world oil supply. The US has asked its allies for help. None did. The indications are clear the US stands alienated in the war that may prolong and drain it further. In this background the UK and other allies are meeting to discuss the opening of the Strait of Hormuz, sans the United States! For nearly eight decades, the global order has been defined by the US and its might in the aftermath of World War II and institutionalised through frameworks like the Bretton Woods Agreement. The United States - militarily dominant, economically pre-eminent, and diplomatically indispensable was the dominant power, its only challenger was Russia in the cold war days. Today, however, the unfolding crisis in West Asia suggests that the US supremacy has taken a severe it. The recent initiative led by the United Kingdom-bringing together over 40 nations to consider sanctions against Iran - is telling not just for what it seeks to achieve, but for who is missing.

The absence of the United States from these talks is significant as the US has alienated its allies who are now seeing security structures beyond the US. For perhaps the first time in decades, Western allies are actively crafting independent responses to a global crisis. Interestingly at one point of time the US was asking its allies to "take responsibility" for securing maritime routes and is now keen to have everyone on board. For Europe, this Strategic autonomy is now becoming imperative. Nations like France and Germany are advocating diplomatic solutions, resisting military escalation.

The road ahead is not a smooth one, but a beginning of an unstable world that would need a new anchor and mechanism to fill the gap if the US goes into a shell. Russia and China would rush to fill in the void but that would again be the beginning of chaos, not stability. A multipolar world distributes responsibility and reduces overdependence on a single actor. Yet, it also introduces uncertainty. Without a clear anchor, global governance can become fragmented.

What is emerging instead is a more diffuse system, where regional powers, coalitions, and issue-based alliances play a greater role. The challenge ahead is whether this emerging order can develop the coherence and legitimacy that the old system, for all its flaws, managed to sustain.

How the US ‘pause’ became Iran’s unraveling

The ‘Five-Day Pause’, presented as a diplomatic opening. What follows is not peace but a volatile vacuum — a region reshaped by force, shifting global power, and a human cost beyond strategic calculation



UDAI
KUMAR

When the White House unveiled its so-called “Five-Day Pause” on March 23, 2026, the language was deliberately measured — invoking diplomacy, restraint, and the possibility of de-escalation. It suggested a fleeting opening for negotiation, a momentary suspension in a conflict spiralling towards greater destruction. Yet beneath this carefully crafted rhetoric lies a far more deliberate and consequential reality. What has unfolded in the Persian Gulf is not a ceasefire in any meaningful sense. It is a calculated pause within a broader campaign — a precise and methodical dismantling of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps, executed with strategic clarity and ruthless timing. By the middle of that week, the IRGC — long the backbone of Iran’s military projection and internal control — had effectively ceased to function as a unified force. For decades, it served as both shield and sword of the Islamic Republic, extending Tehran’s influence across the region while maintaining its grip at home. Now, what remains is fractured and volatile: a disoriented network of fighters without leadership cohesion, their command structure shattered, their ideological authority eroded by the very population they once dominated. In the immediate term, this disarray may prove dangerous, as remnants lash out unpredictably. Over time, however, it risks sliding into irrelevance. This moment does not mark the end of a long shadow war — it signifies that its decisive phase has already concluded.

The past few weeks have produced a strategic outcome rarely seen in modern conflict. Through a combination of sustained Israeli operations and overwhelming American military force, the foundational pillars of Iranian power have been systematically targeted: leadership, energy infrastructure, and internal security mechanisms. Each has been degraded to a point where recovery, at least in the short term, appears improbable.

At the highest levels, the vacuum is absolute. Key figures who once defined the regime’s authority are no longer in play, leaving behind a disjointed command environment. Intelligence networks have been disrupted, communication lines severed, and mid-level operatives left to improvise in a landscape devoid of direction. These are no longer coordinated military units executing strategy; they are isolated actors navigating uncertainty, awaiting outcomes they cannot influence.

Within the broader military structure, deeper fractures have emerged. The longstanding divide between the regular armed forces and the IRGC has widened into open dysfunction. Reports from the ground suggest resource hoarding, break-



downs in supply distribution, and growing mistrust between units. The consequences have been stark: desertions, collapsing morale, and an accelerating erosion of any semblance of unified defence.

It is within this context that the so-called pause must be understood. Rather than an act of restraint, it functions as a strategic instrument — a narrow window designed to shape behaviour before the next phase begins. By temporarily withholding strikes on critical infrastructure, particularly the power grid, the United States has introduced a calculated pressure point. The message is implicit but unmistakable: those still positioned within the remnants of state authority are being offered a limited opportunity to disengage before far more devastating measures are deployed.

The early effects of this approach are already visible. Maritime transit through the Strait of Hormuz has resumed under a new and uneasy arrangement, one defined less by stability than by shifting power dynamics. What was once a contested chokepoint has, for the moment, been reconfigured under a framework in which security guarantees are tightly linked to American oversight.

Beyond the immediate theatre of conflict, the consequences are radiating outward, reshaping global alignments in subtle but significant ways. Control over critical transit routes has reinforced the centrality of American financial and military systems.

Simultaneously, the long-contested issue of Iran’s nuclear ambitions has been fundamentally altered. Key facilities have been rendered inoperable, achieving through force what decades of diplomacy failed to secure. This development has opened the door to new regional alignments, with longstanding rivalries giving way to pragmatic cooperation shaped by shared security concerns. Energy markets, too, are entering a period of recalibration. With multiple supply

sources in play and the prospect of Iranian output eventually re-entering under different conditions, pricing dynamics are shifting. The implications extend well beyond economics, influencing geopolitical leverage and the stability of states heavily dependent on energy revenues.

Yet even as analysts map these strategic outcomes, the underlying reality remains unsettled. The scenario constructed by military planners points towards a decisive escalation should current conditions persist — one that could cripple essential infrastructure on a scale not seen in decades. Such an outcome would not merely weaken a regime; it would transform the daily lives of millions, pushing an already strained society into profound hardship. And this is where the limits of strategic analysis become starkly evident. Behind every abstraction — every reference to “operations,” “targets,” or “infrastructure” — lies a human story that cannot be reduced to metrics or outcomes. The past weeks have inflicted immense suffering on ordinary people: families displaced, lives interrupted, futures erased. These are not incidental details in a broader narrative; they are its most enduring and consequential elements.

As the clock continues to tick on this precarious pause, the world watches not only the unfolding of power but the shaping of memory. For the millions living through this moment, the experience will leave an imprint that endures far beyond any immediate political outcome. History has shown, time and again, that the aftermath of such upheaval is determined not solely by those who wield power, but by those who survive its exercise. Whatever order eventually emerges will be built upon this foundation of loss and transformation. It may reflect new alignments, new balances, and new calculations of interest. But it will also carry the weight of what has been destroyed — a reality that no framework of strategy can fully contain, and no justification can entirely resolve.

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SINCE 1865

Finding meaning in the stillness of age



SANGEETA
MITTAL

2ND OPINION

In the later seasons of life, a subtle shift often takes place — an unspoken heaviness that arrives quietly, without clear reason. There are days when the heart feels low, not because something is outwardly wrong, but because something within is stirring. A sense of loneliness, a faint sadness, or the feeling of being left behind begins to surface. In such moments, many elders find themselves asking softly, “Why do I feel this way?”

The answer rarely lies in the present alone. More often, it is rooted in layers of lived experience — old memories, unfulfilled expectations, and emotions that time has carefully preserved. These feelings are not signs of weakness; they are signals. They invite reflection, not resistance.

The Sufi mystic Jalal al-Din Muhammad Rumi once

wrote, “The wound is the place where the Light enters you.” What we feel is not meant to be pushed away, but understood. There are moments when everything outside seems perfectly in place, yet something within feels unsettled. I recall, at the age of 67, picking up my paintbrush — an activity that had always brought me joy. But that day, the colours felt distant, the strokes mechanical. My hands moved, but my heart did not.

Instead of forcing the moment, I chose stillness. Sitting quietly with my eyes closed, I began to observe. Thoughts surfaced - memories, unspoken emotions, faint expectations. It felt as though the mind had been collecting these fragments for years, and now, in silence, they were asking to be seen. Gradually, a realisation emerged: nothing was wrong in the present. What I was experiencing belonged to something older, something deeper.

As I continued to observe without judgement, the heaviness began to soften. The urge to fix or control faded, replaced by a gentle lightness. Often, when we feel out of rhythm, it is not because something is missing outside, but because something within is ready to be released.

Nature reflects this truth with quiet wisdom. Trees do not cling to old leaves; they let them fall to make space for new growth. Rivers do not resist obstacles; they flow around them. The lotus blooms in muddy waters, yet

remains untouched. Life, too, asks us to release, renew, and rise. One of the deepest emotional currents in later life flows through relationships, especially with children. We give them love, care, and presence, often carrying an unspoken expectation — to be remembered, included, and prioritised. But the pace of the modern world has changed how love is expressed. This quiet mismatch between expectation and reality can become a source of pain. The poet Khalil Gibran wrote, “Your children are not your children. They come through you but not from you.” When this understanding settles within, love becomes lighter and freer of expectation. There is strength in stepping back — not in withdrawal, but in awareness. Emotions and memories will return, but awareness gives us a choice. Before reacting, we can pause and ask whether the feeling belongs to today or to the past. In that pause lies transformation.

Healing comes from understanding our emotions, not ignoring them. Silence, nature, prayer, gratitude, and love without expectation can gently dissolve the weight we carry. You are not fading — you are deepening. This phase of life is not just about ageing; it is about awakening.

The author is a spiritual-lifestyle mentor and founder of Amritam Divine Valley

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Invest more in mine action

Explosive devices continue to kill and maim innocent people across the world, long after wars have ended. The socioeconomic development of nations is severely affected when communities live under constant fear of landmines and unexploded devices. Mines, explosive remnants of war, and Improvised Explosive Devices (IEDs) remain among the most dangerous threats to humanity even today.

The International Day for Mine Awareness and Assistance in Mine Action, observed on April 4 every year, reminds the world about the urgent need to eliminate these hidden killers. Clearing landmines is not merely a military task but a humanitarian necessity. It saves lives, protects livelihoods, and allows displaced families to return home safely and rebuild their lives.

The United Nations Mine Action Service (UNMAS) has been working for years to remove explosives, assist victims, and help countries recover from conflict. This year’s theme, “Invest in peace; invest in mine action,” highlights the importance of global cooperation and funding for mine clearance.

A safe future truly begins with mine-free land and secure communities.

GANAPATHI BHAT | AKOLA

Attack on judiciary is dangerous

The gherao of judicial officers in Malda, West Bengal, and their confinement without food or water represents not merely a breakdown of law and order but a serious crisis of governance. Such incidents are rarely spontaneous expressions of public anger; rather, they often reflect organised intimidation and political pressure on institutions meant to function independently. When officers entrusted with implementing court directives are subjected to humiliation and unlawful confinement, it sends a deeply disturbing signal about the erosion of institutional authority. The rule of law cannot survive if public officials are prevented from performing their duties through coercion and mob pressure. Equally troubling is the apparent failure of local authorities to prevent or promptly control such incidents. This raises serious questions about administrative accountability, political influence, and the weakening of enforcement mechanisms.

If judicial officers acting under the authority of the Supreme Court can be targeted in such a manner, the safety and independence of other officials become even more uncertain. Such incidents must be addressed firmly to prevent the normalisation of mob interference in governance and justice.

N SADHASIVA REDDY | BENGALURU

Film stardom not equal to votes

Cinema fame is no longer a guaranteed pathway to political success in Tamil Nadu, as the political landscape in the state has significantly changed since the era of MGR and Jayalithaa. They were not just film stars but leaders who built strong political organisations and maintained deep connections with the public over many years. While film actors continue to enjoy large fan followings, converting popularity into electoral success has become increasingly difficult. The legendary actor Sivaji Ganesan is a classic example, as he failed in electoral politics despite immense popularity and respect. Even in recent years, several actors who entered politics have struggled to achieve meaningful electoral success. Modern Tamil Nadu politics demands sustained grassroots engagement, organisational strength, and consistent public service, rather than relying only on cinematic image or fan clubs. Established political parties have strong local networks and long-standing voter connections that cannot be easily replaced by digital campaigns or celebrity appeal.

Actor Vijay’s party is still new and untested in electoral politics, and only election results will determine its political strength and public acceptance.

RANGANATHAN SIVAKUMAR | CHENNAI

FREEBIES CULTURE THREATENS FISCAL DISCIPLINE AND ECONOMIC STABILITY

The growing trend of offering widespread freebies in public policy raises serious concerns about fiscal prudence and governance priorities. While welfare measures are necessary in a diverse and unequal society, the increasing dependence on unconditional giveaways risks creating long-term economic and social distortions. Public funds are limited, and their use must balance immediate relief with sustainable development and growth. One major concern is the strain on government finances. Large-scale freebies often increase fiscal deficits and public debt, reducing the state’s capacity to invest in critical sectors such as infrastructure, healthcare, education, and employment generation. Over time, this weakens economic growth and affects the quality of essential

public services that benefit society as a whole.

There is also a social dimension that cannot be ignored. Continued dependence on handouts may gradually reduce the incentive to work, learn new skills, and become self-reliant. Among younger populations especially, it may create a mindset that prioritises short-term benefits over long-term productivity and financial independence.

A balanced approach is therefore necessary. Welfare policies should be targeted, transparent, and linked to outcomes such as education, skills, and employment. Public policy must ultimately aim to empower citizens, not create dependency, while maintaining fiscal responsibility and sustainable development.

M BARATHI | BENGALURU

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Is India’s electoral system losing its citizen focus?

As India’s electoral machinery embraces cutting-edge platforms like ECINet, a troubling paradox has emerged: it has not been matched by institutional transformation. The evolving landscape raises a fundamental question – can digital governance truly succeed without a corresponding shift in mindset?

FIRST
Column



RAJEEV
KUMAR

As technology reshapes governance, India’s electoral machinery has adopted state-of-the-art digital systems-collectively embodied in ECINet-across most electoral processes. Yet, the bureaucracy operating these systems continues to struggle with procedural inertia and outdated thinking. Modernising elections, therefore, is not merely about deploying technology, but about transforming the institutional mindset that governs it.

Not long ago, the Election Commission of India (ECI) actively promoted voter participation, even enlisting celebrities to encourage citizens to vote. Over the past year, however, this relationship appears to have been fundamentally inverted. Instead of facilitating voters, the system has compelled large sections of the electorate to queue up-often with folded hands-seeking inclusion, correction, or relief.

What is particularly striking is the breadth of those affected: from former Secretaries to the Government of India, senior civil and police officials, Director Generals, and police chiefs, to members of the judiciary, as well as professionals from science, technology, academia, and the media. This is no longer an isolated administrative inconvenience; it reflects a systemic shift in which the burden of compliance has been transferred from the institution to the citizen. Hardly any sector remains untouched, raising serious concerns about accessibility, accountability, and institutional intent.

At the centre of this transformation stands the current Chief Election Commissioner (CEC), an IIT Kanpur graduate with a doctorate from Harvard, whose administrative experience across Kerala and at the national level has consolidated unprecedented authority within the ECI. Under his tenure, the institution has dominated public discourse to an extraordinary degree-occupying space across citizens’ minds, the media, the higher judiciary, and the broader political-administrative landscape for nearly a year. Measures such as SIR (Special Intensive Revision), though not new in concept, have assumed a scale and intensity that have effectively reshaped electoral governance for a billion-plus electorate. This centralisation of influence,



IN THE DECADES THAT FOLLOWED, INDIA’S ELECTORAL SYSTEM CONTINUED TO EVOLVE, WITH THE NATION ANNUALLY OBSERVING NATIONAL VOTERS’ DAY AS A REAFFIRMATION OF ITS CONSTITUTIONAL COMMITMENT TO DEMOCRACY

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coupled with an unyielding administrative posture, raises important questions about institutional balance, accountability, and the limits of authority in a constitutional democracy.

At the heart of the current challenge lies a fundamental disconnect between a techno mindset and a bureaucratic attitude. A techno mindset treats technology as an enabler of transparency, efficiency, and real-time accountability-designed to simplify processes, empower users, and build trust through data-driven decision-making. In contrast, a bureaucratic approach often reduces technology to a superficial layer over legacy procedures, preserving opacity, control, and compliance-heavy workflows.

The result is a structural paradox: advanced platforms such as ECINet exist, yet their potential remains underutilised, while citizens continue to face complexity and uncertainty. Bridging this gap requires more than the deployment of digital tools; it demands a cultural shift from rule-bound administration to responsive, technology-led governance that places the citizen at its core.

Seen in this context, the concerns raised here are not adversarial but principled-anchored in the doctrine of “na kaahoo se bair, na kaahoo se dostee”. They reflect the lived experience of ordinary, law-abiding citizens who fulfil their constitutional duties and expect, in return, that their fundamental rights will not be disrupted without

cause. Yet, for over half a year, millions have faced uncertainty and anxiety while navigating the opaque and often arbitrary processes surrounding SIR 2.0. The issue is not technology itself, but the mindset governing it: when digital systems amplify complexity rather than reduce it, they risk becoming instruments of distress-undermining both credibility and public trust in the electoral process.

Perhaps the most telling irony of the present system is the visual and behavioural contrast witnessed during nomination filings: the Election Officer remains seated, while elected representatives and candidates stand-often with folded hands-submitting their papers. This is not merely a matter of protocol; it reflects a deeper institutional attitude. Are we so bound by outdated bureaucratic customs that an official remains fixed to his chair, even as public representatives stand in deference? In a citizen-centric democracy, such interactions should reflect mutual respect, not hierarchical distance. At the very least, institutional conduct should convey that authority flows from the people, not above them.

This posture reveals more than a procedural habit-it signals a mindset. The bureaucracy, despite operating within a democratic framework, often projects itself as a controlling authority shaped by residual colonial attitudes rather than as a facilitating

service.

In a responsive system, officials would engage with stakeholders as equals, guiding and supporting them through enabling processes. Instead, such scenes reinforce an implicit hierarchy, where the system appears elevated and the citizen-represented here by candidates-appears subordinate. This is not merely optics; it reflects an administrative culture that continues to equate position with power rather than responsibility.

Equally important is the second, subtler dimension of this imagery. When candidates stand with folded hands before officials, it creates a powerful visual narrative that is later projected to the public-as if these same individuals embody humility, accessibility, and respect towards citizens. Yet, this symbolism is often illusory. The deference shown before authority is not always reflected in their engagement with the electorate. Such imagery risks becoming a tool of political signalling rather than a genuine expression of democratic conduct.

This duality-deference before the system and assertion before the citizen-creates a misleading perception. It enables political actors to project modesty while maintaining distance from those they represent. The result is a layered illusion: a bureaucracy that appears authoritative and distant, and a political class that appears humble but may

not consistently practise that humility in public life. Together, they reinforce a culture where appearances substitute for accountability. In a mature democracy, both institutions must move beyond such symbolic contradictions. Bureaucracy must shed its residual hierarchy and embrace a service-oriented ethos, while political representatives must demonstrate authenticity in their engagement with citizens-not merely through gestures, but through consistent conduct. Otherwise, what appears respectful on the surface risks becoming a carefully staged performance-reminding us that, indeed, everything that glitters is not gold.

In the decades following Independence, ECI functioned largely as a passive institution-more an observer than an enforcer-rarely assertive, seldom feared, and often ignored by the police, district administrations, and state secretariats. This institutional quietude allowed political parties considerable latitude, frequently operating in collusion with local officials and, at times, relying on muscle power to influence outcomes. Voting slips were commonly distributed by party agents or candidates themselves, reflecting the Commission’s limited authority and reach. In such an environment, electoral malpractices, including selective rigging, were not uncommon-underlining the systemic weaknesses of a bureaucratic framework that lacked both resolve and effective enforcement.

This legacy was decisively overturned with the arrival of T. N. Seshan, widely regarded as the “Bulldog” of electoral reform. As the then sole CEC, he brought rare fearlessness, persistence, and uncompromising resolve to an institution long seen as passive. He enforced the Model Code of Conduct with unprecedented rigour, introduced voter identity cards, imposed strict limits on campaign expenditure, and ensured the deployment of officials from outside poll-bound states to curb local collusion. Malpractices such as voter bribery and intimidation, misuse of state machinery, communal appeals, distribution of liquor, and unregulated campaigning were firmly checked. His directives were treated as final and non-negotiable, with non-compliance inviting swift consequences-fundamentally altering the conduct of political actors and administrative machinery alike. Under his leadership, the ECI emerged as a strong and credible constitutional authority.

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Misinformation has a patron: The ego that calls itself post-truth



ACHARYA
PRASHANT

Serious institutions in the world now seem engaged in fighting misinformation. Governments are regulating, platforms are fact-checking, and journalists are building verification desks with a rigour they have not applied to anything in years. The question at the foundation of the entire enterprise, however, has not been asked.

The fundamental question to ask, before talking of misinformation, should be: what is information? Information, at its most basic, is that which informs, that which moves a person from not knowing towards knowing, towards a more accurate picture of what is. Which means that before we can speak about misinformation, we must speak about the instrument through which information is received and processed. That instrument is the mind. In its innocent biological state, it is a neutral instrument: memory and intellect, neither desiring nor fearing nor choosing. Those operations belong to the ego, the felt sense of “I am this,” this identity, this tribe, this ideology, this wound, which commandeers the mind’s machinery and directs it not towards what is true but towards what is safe. And what is safe for the ego is not accurate information. It is confirming information, information that strengthens the positions already held and reinforces the identities already inhabited.

This condition has a precise shape: not ignorance in the sense of knowing nothing, but fragmented knowing, the accumulation of vast information about the world while remaining structurally unaware of the one doing the knowing. The information sought is downstream of the identity being protected. We call this an information crisis.

Who decides what is false?

If the ego is always filtering information through what it has already decided to protect, then what does misinformation actually mean? Both misinformation and disinformation assume a stable, agreed-upon baseline of truth against which the falseness of a given claim can be measured; they assume, in other words, a shared epistemic ground.

This is the assumption that has not been examined. And it is precisely the assumption that the condition we are living through has already dissolved. The conflict now is not only over facts; it is over the authority to name them as facts. The world that gave birth to the misinformation crisis is the same world that named itself post-

truth. Post-truth names a real condition: the condition in which facts no longer settle disputes, in which evidence no longer commands consensus across communities, in which two groups can look at the same event and inhabit incommensurable versions of what occurred, each version internally coherent, each supported by its own sources and experts, and neither capable of producing a fact that the other is compelled to accept as decisive. This is the problem at the heart of the enterprise. Misinformation, as a category, requires the existence of a shared truth baseline. If the shared ground has dissolved, then calling something misinformation is not a description of a fact about the content. It is an assertion of a contested position. In a post-truth world, the label “misinformation” is itself an act of power, not an act of description.

The closed circuit

The misinformation debate has treated producer and consumer separately, focusing almost entirely on the consumer: the person who receives, believes, and spreads false content. That separation does not survive scrutiny. The ego that manufactures misinformation and the ego that consumes it are in a closed circuit. The producer does not invent freely; it creates what the consumer structurally requires. The supply of false content is not independent of the demand for it; it is generated by the demand. To address the supply without addressing the demand is to cut a weed at its stem while leaving the root untouched. Lies do not spread. They are summoned.

The circuit is not new. What has changed is the voltage running through it. Modernity has systematically dismantled the structures, among them religion, caste, and nation, through which the ego previously borrowed its confirming identity passively and continuously. But as they thin, fragment, or lose their authority, the ego does not lose the hunger they fed. It becomes more desperate for its satisfaction. The old scaffolding weakened; the appetite did not. It simply entered the marketplace and began scrolling. The post-truth era is not a new phenomenon. The ego has always been post-truth. It simply has better tools now.

The only question that reaches the root

If the problem is external, a problem of content rather than of the instrument receiving it, then the solutions will be external: better algorithms, content authentication, digital literacy, platform governance. They are not useless; they address real symptoms of a real problem. But what they cannot address is the condition generating the demand for false content in the first place, because that condition is not a property of the content. It is a property of the one consuming it. Even a correction leaves the structure that gen-

erated the false belief intact; only the surface belief changes. Improve the algorithm and the ego finds a new channel; authenticate the content and it learns to trust only sources not yet discredited. Meanwhile, when falsehood spreads, the primary agents are not bots but human beings choosing to share what confirmed their existing beliefs. Under the conditions in which the ego is most invested, correction can actively deepen what it was designed to dissolve.

The misinformation debate is conducted entirely in the register of content. It asks only about the content: is this claim accurate? It never asks about the one consuming the content: who is this person, what do they need this claim to be, what identity does it protect? Those deeper questions are the territory of honest self-examination, and no external apparatus has ever found its way into that territory.

The post-truth world will not be mended from outside. The shared ground does not return through better content moderation or more comprehensive fact-checking portals. It returns, if it returns, one person at a time, when the person asking how to identify misinformation becomes willing to ask instead: what is my own relationship to what is true?

The asking is not an intellectual exercise. It begins, in practice, at the level of sensation: when a claim arrives that disturbs a settled position, the first response is not reasoning but a tightening resistance. This is the ego identifying a threat: not to the person but to the story the person has become. The move is to turn towards the resistance, to stay with it long enough to ask what is being protected and why it requires this particular claim to be true. What identity would be disturbed if this claim were accurate? What would have to be relinquished? That inquiry, not more balanced information consumption, not a diversified media diet, not fact-checking habits, is what self-examination actually means. That inquiry does not resolve the information crisis. It does not restore consensus or silence a single deepfake. What it does is something quieter and more consequential: it changes the person making the next choice. The ego that has genuinely seen its own selection does not become wiser or more balanced; it becomes less desperate for the next confirmation. And in a crisis whose engine is not the lie but the ego that needed the lie, that change is the only one that has ever reached the root. The question the world is asking, how to identify misinformation, is the right question. It has simply been directed at the wrong person. The claim in front of us may or may not be false. The certainty receiving it is almost never innocent.

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Modi’s will, Shah’s skill: Naxal enigma finally broken



RAMAN
SINGH

For decades, Naxalism stood as one of the gravest challenges to India’s internal security and development. It thrived in regions marked by isolation, underdevelopment, and a breakdown of trust between the state and its people. Today, as we stand at a defining moment, it is evident that this long-standing menace is being decisively defeated. The credit for this transformation goes to the unwavering resolve of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the determined, strategy-driven leadership of Union Home Minister Amit Shah.

Naxalism was never merely a local law-and-order issue. It was an ideologically driven movement influenced by Maoist thought, which sought to challenge India’s democratic structure through violence. Early figures such as Charu Majumdar, Kanu Sanyal, and Jangal Santhal mobilised marginalised communities by raising issues of land, inequality, and justice. However, over time, this movement deviated into a violent insurgency that exploited innocent tribal populations and obstructed development.

Chhattisgarh, particularly the Bastar region, became one of the worst-affected areas. Rich in forests and mineral resources, yet historically deprived of development, Bastar became fertile ground for extremist expansion. Incidents that weakened public trust in governance only deepened the crisis, allowing Naxal influence to spread further.

When I had the opportunity to serve as Chief Minister, we recognised that the fight against Naxalism could not be won by force alone. We adopted a two-pronged approach- development and security. We expanded infrastructure, increased the number of districts, strengthened healthcare and education systems, and implemented welfare schemes aimed at improving the lives of tribal communities. Initiatives such as forest rights distribution, affordable food schemes, and support for forest produce were designed to bring people into the mainstream.

However, despite these efforts, the absence of a strong, coordinated national strategy limited the pace of progress. The real turning point came after 2014, when, under the leadership of Narendra Modi, a comprehensive approach was adopted. Development was taken to the last mile, and governance became more responsive and inclusive.

At the same time, Amit Shah brought a new level of clarity and determination to the security response. His zero-tolerance policy towards



Naxalism, combined with improved intelligence, modernisation of forces, and close coordination between the Centre and states, fundamentally changed the dynamics of this conflict.

Security operations became more precise and effective, targeting the leadership and infrastructure of Naxal groups. Campaigns such as Operation Kagaz dealt decisive blows to their command structure. Hundreds of extremists were neutralised, thousands arrested, and many more surrendered. Areas once considered inaccessible have now seen the return of governance and development.

Equally important has been the restoration of public trust. My experience has taught me that the most powerful weapon against Naxalism is the confidence of the people. When communities stand with the state, extremism loses its base. Local youth have been empowered, trained, and integrated into security forces, playing a crucial role in this transformation.

Today, the results are visible. Violence has declined, development has accelerated, and hope has returned to regions that were once engulfed in fear. The so-called “Red Corridor” is shrinking, and the dream of a Naxal-free India is closer than ever.

The leadership of Narendra Modi and Amit Shah has demonstrated that even the most entrenched challenges can be overcome with determination, strategy, and a clear vision. Their efforts have not only strengthened internal security but also reaffirmed faith in India’s democratic framework.

As we move forward, it is essential to consolidate these gains. Development must continue, governance must deepen, and the trust of the people must remain at the centre of all efforts. Only then can we ensure that the shadow of Naxalism never returns.

The battle that once seemed endless is now nearing its conclusion. With sustained commitment and collective resolve, a peaceful, prosperous, and Naxal-free India is within our reach.

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GOLD ON **HOLD**

It is the rupee, stupid, not gold. While most reports, including official explanation, reveal that the recent curbs on imports of gold and silver were due to misuses, the real reason seems to be the currency. Ever since, the exchange rate breached the ₹95 to a dollar mark a few days ago, the central bank, and policy-makers were in a tizzy. There was, and is, a genuine scare, say sources that speculators led by a major force were hell bent to weaken the rupee to ₹100 a dollar. This was a psychological barrier that they did not want to be crossed. If it went past ₹100, who knows where it would stop. The rationale was that at that exchange rate level, the currency would be completely in the grips of a cartel, led by a renowned currency-buster, and the economy would be held hostage. In the minds of the policy-makers, the attack on the British pound in September 1992 (beginning Black Wednesday), and on the Asian currencies in 1997 were the top-of-the-mind recall.

To break the back of the speculators, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) initiated several steps to drastically limit short positions, apart from other measures to curb the trading in derivatives, which form an important component of modern attacks on assets, commodities, and currencies. This did help, after an initial reversal, when the speculative attacks intensified. Now, with curbs on imports of bullion, the policy-makers hope to correct the macro indicators, i.e., to reduce imports, and somehow manage the trade deficits in an era of lower exports, capital flight from the stock markets, and limited inflows of investment capital. In some senses, the fear is that if the Iran war drags on, India may find itself in a external environment that is akin to the late 1980s, and early 1990s, when India had to physically ship gold out of the country to boost the dwindling foreign exchange reserves, and listen to the diktats of the global agencies, and relentlessly pursue reforms.

While the reforms in the 1990s proved to be good for the country, the foreign exchange crisis was a scare that no nation wishes to go through. Today, a similar situation may have wider ramifications that will extend beyond growth, and envelope inflation, short-ages, and civil unrest. In the case of the Asian currency crisis, several nations witnessed huge dips in GDP, and widespread social unrest. In the case of the pounding on pound, Britain withdrew from European Exchange Rate Mechanism, a step that twistedly led to Brexit, or a break from the European Union decades later. India feels that a similar push on the rupee may make it inward-looking, and shy away from globalisation, which will be worse for the society where aspirations are high, ambitions overrule realities, and the youth is stressed. There may be political and electoral fallout, which may linger on for a decade or so, and the ruling regime may find itself out of the favour of the voters.

Experiences related to the pound prove the political impact. “The ERM (exchange rate mechanism) crisis, and the sight of flailing ministers caused a huge shock to the reputation of the Conservative management of the economy. Despite having just won an election, support for the Conservatives plummeted from 42 per cent to 29 per cent overnight, and it never recovered. The rest of Parliament would be dominated by scandal, sleaze, a diminishing majority, rebellions by increasingly Euro-sceptic backbenchers, and a general sense in the country that 18 years of Conservative government was too much,” explains a website. If similar feelings emanate due to the rupee crisis, the ruling regime may find itself in a spot, politically, and electorally. The momentum it built over the past 11 years may reverse, and quite rapidly. The opposition may revive instantly, and be back in the electoral game. Apart from the central power, power in the states may slip out, and for a long time.

One of the worst experiences of the Asian currency crisis was the social rout. “In Thailand, the crisis led to a dramatic rise in unemployment, with millions of people losing their jobs as businesses scaled back operations in the wake of reduced consumer spending and investment. The construction and tourism sectors, which had been the pillars of the Thai economy, were particularly hit hard. Many families faced dire financial situations, leading to increased poverty rates. Estimates suggested that the crisis pushed approximately 10 million Thais into poverty, significantly impacting their quality of life,” explains a website. In Indonesia, the social unrest due to the crisis, led to a regime change, a regime that had ruled for three decades.

Hence, the official reason for the import curbs on bullion, which is that the traders misused the import duty differential due to the free trade agreement with ASEAN nations, may be a smokescreen. Yes, gold imports have zoomed in the first eleven months of 2025-26, to nearly \$60 billion. But the policies imposed, which is a virtual ban on almost everything, including contracts signed, and shipments about to ensue, shows a fear psychosis that goes beyond foreign exchange. It is the rupee, which is in focus, on the radar, and within the crossfire.

The Pioneer



NEW DELHI | SATURDAY | APRIL 4, 2026

BUSINESS

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AI forces intelligence rethink in IT

Labour arbitrage will give way to outcome-based arbitrage

Artificial Intelligence (AI) adoption among Indian firms is more than 25 per cent, and the new tools can add more than \$400 billion to the GDP over the next decade. As productivity gains shoot up, and layoffs become the norm, as we have mentioned several times in these columns, they create structural tensions, and a rethink about existing business models within the IT and software services sector. Tech that promises growth begins to weaken the earlier tech that built the former. For three decades, Indian IT scaled on a simple equation. More clients, more work per vendor, more people, more revenues, and more profits.

Billings are tied to efforts, teams are sized to timelines, and global clients outsourced works and processes to take advantage of Indian scale. AI breaks this equation. When the same work is done faster, with fewer employees, due to high productivity gains, there is a shakedown. Demand does not disappear. But billings based on manpower use shrink. In a business where billings matter, the killings begin, as the shillings begin to vanish. There are huge gaps in work flows that need fillings, but only if the affected firms are willing to do so.

This is the paradox of the \$250-billion IT industry. Adoption remains high, productivity improves, and demand for tech is intact. Yet, the businesses are in trouble, which is reflected in their stock prices. The link between the delivered work and earned revenue begins to diverge, and growth is no longer guaranteed by scale. Big may not necessarily be beautiful, and although it is not a scary axiom, being big is not necessarily the only route to success. Big can turn ugly. In effect, smaller firms with smart AI can deliver better and faster.

Coding, testing, maintenance, and parts of consulting are now assisted by AI models trained on

large datasets. Sequential tasks are parallel and simultaneous. Iteration cycles shrink. In some cases, projects that require weeks are completed in days. What changes is not the existence of work, but the quantum of human effort required. The implications create pricing pressures, as firms race to cut costs by doing the one thing they know best, i.e., mass sackings. Clients question why, with the advent of AI, the same work costs the same, especially if the timelines tighten. AI, in some senses, is deflationary for IT services.

Hence, the historical advantages collide with the future transition. IT was built essentially on labour arbitrage, whatever the firms may claim. It was the ability to deliver high-quality work at lower costs, either at the client's end (onshoring), or in Indian campuses (offshoring and outsourcing) that defined success. AI introduces another form of arbitrage. What matters now is access to intelligence, models, and data, and the ability to deploy them effectively. The transition is from labour to intelligence arbitrage. IT needs less people, but more skilled people that can multitask, and handle multiple roles. It is a new paradox.

In an intelligence-based system, the growth is not linear (more work, more people, more work) but non-linear. AI can scale across clients without proportional increases in headcount. Hence, the new ecosystem needs a massive redesign to create and capture new values. Some of it is underway. One direction is outcome-based pricing, where clients pay for results rather than hours. In theory, this allows firms to gain from faster deliveries. In practice, it introduces new risks. Revenue is tied to performances, accuracy, and measurable outcomes. Managers need to rejig their mindset, and reduce focus on HR, hirings, and attritions.

Another shift is towards platform-led models. Instead of building custom solutions for each client, firms invest in reusable AI layers that are deployed across industries. Hence, there may be no dedicated teams to handle specific clients. Code-generation frameworks, testing engines, and domain-specific models for specific sectors will rule the show. The objective is to move from project-based revenues to scalable, repeatable products. Indian IT did this in some ways by engineering processes and systems that were replicable and scalable. But this will not work. The focus needs to change from people to tech, as it was in the 1980s.

A third layer relates to AI infrastructure. As firms deploy AI systems, they require support in areas such as data pipelines, model governance, compliance, and security. This creates a new category of services that is less about building software, and more about the operations and maintenance of the AI-driven systems. Hence, hardware to handle huge amounts of data is as important as AI. More importantly, the new hardware will cost a lot, unlike the old one, where costs tumbled. Data centres and power systems hint at brick-n-mortar solutions.

Economic risks hover. If the productivity gains are passed on to the clients via lower prices, margins compress. Revenue growth decouples from contracts and outsourced work. The industry grows, but with a different and potentially weaker economic profile. There is the positioning risk. Indian IT operates on a global scale, where competitors move along different trajectories. In the US, large tech firms embed AI into products and platforms, and capture value through IPRs. In China, firms leverage scale, data, and ecosystem integration. India's strength remains in services, execution, and talent at scale.

At the same time, India retains advantages that are not easily replicated. It has one of the largest talents of tech pools, a growing base of digital infrastructure, and an expanding dataset. The ecosystem is moving, even if unevenly. The challenge lies in translating this into defensible advantage. The unevenness is crucial as IT sits between demand and capability, and its evolution will depend on how effectively it can reposition itself within this equation. If the shift succeeds, Indian firms will emerge stronger, with higher margins, leaner structures, and more scalable revenue streams. If not, there is trouble in paradise.

Growth may come from deploying capabilities. This seems to be the only way to stall value erosion, and enhance the chances of future existence. Hence, AI may not necessarily be a destabiliser, but a hidden opportunity to change models, and survive profitably. More importantly, this is not a fight between tech, like radio versus TV versus Internet versus AI. It is a form of internal transition within tech, like software-hardware to Internet to AI. Thus, adaptation and adoption are distinct possibilities. Indeed, many IT firms are in the middle of such changes. The terms to profit from the new opportunity have changed. It is imperative for the industry to do so too.

ARUN GOYAL

India's policy-move to help the local users of petrochemicals will yield limited benefit, both in terms of period (three months), and costs (a mere five per cent). On Thursday (April 2), the Government exempted 40 petrochemicals from the payment of basic Customs duty. Applicable until June 30, 2026, or just about here months, an analysis by us reveals that the average cut will translate into an average saving of five per cent, thanks to several factors. In actual terms, the duty cuts may range from a low of 2.5 per cent to a high of 7.5 per cent.

However, the list includes crucial inputs and raw materials for crucial sectors such as textiles, plastics, fertilisers, and soaps and detergents. Yet, one is not sure of the benefits that will accrue to the user industries. This is because the decrease is in basic duties, but the other tax components such as IGST and anti-dumping will continue to apply on some of the petrochemicals. According to our database, eight of the 40 items mentioned in the notification are subjected to the anti-dumping duties, which are not covered under the exemption.

One needs to add that given the near doubling in global naphtha price to \$1,100 per tonne, dumping may have lost some meaning in the current context. Current prices may not allow global sellers to get rid of the products at below-market rates, and five per cent effective-average duty cut may not support under-invoicing of imports. A similar conclusion will hold for non-tariff barriers, which are not relevant during periods of severe shortages in the world market. At present, India imports about half of its petrochemical requirements.

What is relevant is that the 40 petrochemicals are only a part of the \$100 billion petrochemical import market, which is still subjected to a rather high import tariff of 7.5 per cent on most products. Importers need to pay a social welfare surcharge on top of it. Couple this with IGST of 18 per cent, and the end-result is a duty liability of 27.735 per cent. If the average cut is five per cent, or less than a fifth of the overall duty, due to the basic relief, importers or users are unlikely to benefit much from the move, though it is a step in the right direction.

Consumers will get some relief but the measure will hardly solve the problem of price rises. The Government may be better off, or users may be in a better position, if the former switches over to a system of Customs duties and IGST that are based on the global prices of crucial and sensitive petrochemicals

Custom case of too little, too late

Average cut in import duties on 40 petrochemicals is five per cent

indicators, like naphtha. This will factor in the dynamic and changing international prices in the domestic system and equations. As it is, the users have suffered the price rises during March, and the relief begins in April, and lasts till June.

According to reports, the fertiliser industry, and select components of the petrochemical users have lost a lot, and have been hit the worst during the past month. The current measure, which is applicable for only three months, will compound the confusion and distortion in the economy, besides hurting the producers and government revenues. One hopes that the June deadline is not a fixed one but a flexible one, and if the Iran war continues, the Government may extend the deadline, and further reduce the duties over the next few weeks.

Although the duty cut will impact several Indian refiners, and one of the worst sufferers in the private sector may be Reliance Industries, which is the country's largest producer-user of several items in the list. According to reports, there may be higher competition from imports, which may put downward pressure on local prices. It will translate into low prices in the user segments such as plastics, packaging, and textiles. Hence, a vertically-integrated business,

like Reliance Industries, may be hit at both ends, inputs and finished products.

In the recent past, Reliance Industries, along with the other refiners, was slapped with windfall taxes on jet fuel and diesel, although petrol remained untouched. This was abolished in 2024, after being introduced in 2022 in the wake of the Russia-Ukraine war. A combination of windfall taxes, although limited, cut in import duty, restricted to 40 items at present, lower refining margins, and high crude oil prices may have a complex impact on Reliance Industries' revenues and profits. Experts and analysts are still trying to gauge the overall effects.

One of the prime reasons, as we stated earlier, is that the windfall tax is only on two products, although they are major ones. According to media reports, of the two refineries that the firm operates, one domestic and the other export-oriented, the latter may not need to pay the windfall tax. Hence, the impact will be less than expected, or minimal. In the same way, since the petrochemicals businesses are integrated with the downstream user ones in Reliance Industries, which is both a producer and user, it may be in a better position, compared to others, to absorb the impact on competition, and local prices.

However, the volatility in the stock price movement of Reliance Industries in the past month shows the uncertainty among the investors. From a price that was below ₹1,350 on March 4, five days after the beginning of the Iran war, it shot up to almost ₹1,425 within five days, then moved down and up, before settling down at around ₹1,350 yesterday. Hence, it gained ₹75, or more than 5.5 per cent from the month's low, and then shed the gains over the next three weeks or so, largely because of the windfall tax, and import duty cuts.

Before the announcement of the windfall tax, analysts had estimated that “if gasoil, gasoline, and jet fuel cracks sustain at about \$15, \$5, and \$15 per barrel above historical averages in the first half of 2026-27, Reliance Industries' EBIDTA could increase by ₹17,000 crore, lifting its FY27 EBIDTA by nearly 8.5 per cent.” Earlier, in 2022-23 and 2023-24, the firm's EBIDTA rose by 18 per cent, and remained stable, respectively, because of the Russia-Ukraine war. The upward profitability curve may still turn out to be true if the firm's SEZ refinery does not pay the export tax. There is some lack of clarity on the issue, although reports indicate that the tax will not be applicable.

(The author is Director, Academy of Business Studies, New Delhi)

India largely safe US tariffs on patented drugs due to generic export strength: GTRI

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

India is unlikely to be significantly impacted by US President Donald Trump's announcement of 100 per cent tariffs on certain patented drugs, as the country primarily exports low-cost generic medicines to America, think tank GTRI said on Friday. Trump signed an executive order on April 2, announcing the imposition of a 100 per cent ad valorem duty rate on the import of certain patented pharmaceuticals and associated pharmaceutical ingredients.

The order, issued on April 2, 2026, builds on a Section 232

investigation launched on May 1, 2025, which cited national security risks from dependence on foreign drug supplies.

The Global Trade Research Initiative (GTRI) said the move has left "India largely protected, given its dominance in low-cost generic drug exports to the US".

Generic medicines make up over 90 per cent of US drug use and are exempt for now, likely for about a year, to avoid shortages and price increases, it added.

In 2025, India exported USD 9.7 billion worth of pharmaceuticals to the US, accounting for 38 per cent of its global pharma exports

of \$25.8 billion. "However, Indian firms producing branded or speciality drugs, or supplying inputs for patented medicines, could face tariff pressure. The larger concern is future uncertainty if tariffs are extended to generics," GTRI founder Ajay Srivastava said.

The order timing, issued on the first anniversary of the earlier "Liberation Day" tariff push, signals a continuation of Washington's aggressive trade strategy, he added.

On April 2 last year, the US announced sweeping tariffs on about 60 countries, including India. The 100 per cent tariffs will



mainly affect Ireland, Germany, Switzerland, Belgium, Denmark, the United Kingdom and Japan, which are major exporters of patented and high-value drugs, including biologics, to the US, he said, adding that the order does not exempt countries with trade arrangements with the US, including the European Union and Japan.

He also said that with the US Supreme Court striking down reciprocal tariffs, Washington is likely to rely more heavily on tools such as Section 232 of the Trade Expansion Act of 1962 (national security) and Section

301 of the Trade Act of 1974 (foreign trade barriers) to justify tariffs on a wide range of products and countries.

"In effect, the court's decision has not changed the tariff strategy, it has only pushed the administration to shift the legal basis while keeping the pressure intact," Srivastava said, adding that this creates a deeper problem for trading partners, and even countries that sign trade deals with the US are not insulated from such actions, as these investigations can still be launched irrespective of existing agreements.

RBI gives nod to Emirates NBD Bank to acquire up to 74 pc stake in RBL Bank

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) has accorded approval to Dubai-based Emirates NBD Bank to acquire up to a 74 per cent stake in RBL Bank, paving the way for the bank to become a foreign lender.

The approval from RBI came on April 1 with one year validity, RBL Bank said in a regulatory filing on Thursday. The approval follows Emirates NBD Bank, the second largest in UAE, expressing its interest in October 2025 to acquire a majority 60 per cent stake in RBL Bank for \$26.853 crore.

As per the approval letter, the Emirates NBD (ENBD) would acquire and maintain a shareholding of at least 51 per cent of the paid-up share capital of the RBL Bank and the bank would be classified as a foreign bank in subsidiary mode, with the Investor as its parent foreign bank.

"The provisions applicable to foreign banks operating in wholly owned subsidiary mode, as set out in Chapter IV of the Reserve Bank of



India (Commercial Banks — Governance) Directions, 2025 dated November 28, 2025, shall be applicable to the bank, except the requirement to have at least half of the directors attending board meetings to be independent directors shall not apply," it said.

The bank has been advised to suitably amend its Articles of Association and obtain approval of the RBI in this regard, and the bank will take the necessary steps accordingly, it said.

The Reserve Bank has no objection to ENBD being classified as the promoter of RBL Bank, subject to applicable Securities and Exchange Board of India regulations, it

said. The voting rights of ENBD shall be capped at 26 per cent of the total voting rights of RBL Bank, in accordance with Section 12(2) of the Banking Regulation Act, 1949, it said. The ENBD is exempted from the requirement of single mode of presence until the Indian branches of the investor are amalgamated with the Bank, or within one year, whichever is earlier, it said.

It further said that the RBI approval is subject to receipt of necessary approval from Government of India for investment beyond 49 per cent in the bank under the approval route and compliance with the relevant provisions of the Banking

Regulation Act, 1949, RBI (Commercial Banks—Acquisition and Holding of Shares or Voting Rights) Directions, 2025, dated November 28, 2025, provisions of the FEMA 1999, regulations issued by Securities and Exchange Board of India, and any other statutes, regulations and guidelines, as applicable.

The proposed transaction remains subject to receipt of certain other regulatory approvals and customary conditions precedent as mentioned in the Investment Agreement dated October 18, 2025 entered into between the Investor and the bank, it added.

Exports notch positive growth despite global issues, says Official

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

India's exports have sustained healthy momentum despite global headwinds and are expected to post positive growth in 2025-26, a senior official of the commerce ministry said on Friday.

The exports and imports data for the month of March and the full 2025-26 fiscal year will be released by the commerce ministry on April 15.

"At the end of March 31, despite the war, we will be closing the year with positive growth. US tariffs, so many dis-



turbances all through the year, Ukraine war is continuing, Iran war started, despite all, merchandise, exports have maintained their momentum," the official said.

The country's merchandise exports dropped marginally by 0.81 per cent year-on-year to \$36.61 billion in February, and the trade deficit narrowed to \$27.1 billion compared to the previous month.

Coal India arm NCL supplies 137 MT dry fuel in FY26

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Coal India arm NCL on Friday said that it supplied a record 137.08 Million Tonnes (MT) of coal to its customers in power and other sectors during 2025-26, significantly reinforcing India's energy security amid surging domestic demand and shifting global dynamics.

Of the total dispatch, approximately 86 per cent, equivalent to 117.85 MT, was supplied to coal-based power plants.

"Amid evolving global energy dynamics and rising power demand in the country, NCL's consistent performance has played a significant role in supporting the country's energy security. Reinforcing its contribution to national energy security, NCL dispatched 137.08 million tonnes of coal to the power sector and other consumers during FY 2025-26," Northern Coalfields Ltd (NCL) said in a statement.

In line with its commitment to sustainable operations, 85.51 per cent of the total coal dispatch was carried out through environment-friendly modes. Northern Coalfields Ltd produced 140.5 million tonnes of coal in 2025-26, registering a growth of 1.08 per cent from the year-ago period.

"The company has successfully met its annual production target during the year, with all its projects achieving their respective coal production goals, reflecting strong operational coordination across its 10 highly mechanised



mega opencast mines," it said. Among individual projects, Jayant recorded the highest production at 30 MT, followed by Dudhichua and Nigahi projects at 25 MT each. Other projects also contributed significantly to the overall performance while achieving their individual targets.

Overburden removal, which is a key parameter in the opencast mine operation, stood at 461.7 million cubic metres during the year.

The consistent performance of NCL is due to its sustained focus on operational efficiency and coordinated efforts across projects, it said.

Headquartered in Singrauli, Madhya Pradesh, NCL operates in the Moher Sub-Basin of the Singrauli Coalfield, covering parts of both Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh.

Singrauli is popularly known as the 'energy capital of India,' and NCL's coal alone contributes to 10 per cent of the country's electricity generation. The company supplies coal to many of the country's thermal power plants, including NTPC Vindhyachal.

Russia offers to scale up crude oil, LNG supplies to India

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

With the West Asia crisis continuing to drive volatility in the global energy market, Russia has offered to increase supply of crude oil and natural gas to India even as the two sides agreed to further enhance the overall bilateral ties.

The energy cooperation figured prominently in meetings Russia's First Deputy Prime Minister Denis Manturov held with National Security Advisor Ajit Doval and External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar on Thursday, people familiar with the matter said.

Manturov also held talks with Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman and called on Prime Minister Narendra Modi last evening.

A Russian readout of the First Deputy Prime Minister's engagements in New Delhi said special attention was accorded to bilateral cooperation in the oil and gas sector.



"Denis Manturov confirmed that Russian companies have the capacity to steadily increase supplies of oil and liquefied natural gas to the Indian market," it said.

The comments came as the West Asia crisis continued to put strain on global energy market largely due to disruptions in supplies of crude oil and gas through

the Strait of Hormuz.

Global oil and gas prices have surged after Iran virtually blocked the Strait of Hormuz, a narrow shipping lane between the Persian Gulf and the Gulf of Oman, that handles roughly 20 per cent of global oil and LNG (Liquefied Natural Gas). West Asia has been a major source of India's

energy procurement.

Various issues relating to bilateral ties were deliberated extensively at the India-Russia Inter-Governmental Commission on Trade, Economic, Scientific, Technological and Cultural Cooperation (IRIGC-TEC). It was co-chaired by Manturov and Jaishankar.

Expanding mutually beneficial trade, investment, and industrial cooperation was one of the key topics on the agenda, the Russian readout said.

"Specific steps were discussed to create favorable conditions for increasing bilateral trade turnover in the present context," it said.

Manturov noted that Russia increased supplies of fertilisers to India by 40 per cent by end of 2025 and is ready to continue meeting India's needs, it said.

The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said both sides held wide ranging discussions focusing on

trade, industry, energy, fertilizers, connectivity and mobility in addition to new opportunities in technology, innovation and critical minerals.

The two sides also reviewed the progress on the implementation of the various outcomes of the 23rd India Russia Annual Summit held in December last year, it said.

Russian President Vladimir Putin visited India for the summit. Following the summit talks between Modi and Putin, India and Russia unveiled a raft of measures including a five-year roadmap to build a robust economic partnership and to increase the annual trade to \$100 billion by 2030.

Jaishankar and Manturov also exchanged views on regional and global developments including the conflict in West Asia, the MEA said.

The Russian readout also mentioned bilateral cooperation in the civil nuclear energy sector.

Oil prices surge while Asian share prices rise



YURI KAGEYAMA ■ Tokyo

Oil prices continued to surge on worries of a prolonged Iran war, but the Asian markets that were open Friday rose moderately in cautious trading, while others were closed for the Good Friday holidays.

Benchmark US crude rose 11.4 per cent to \$111.54 a barrel. The price of Brent crude, the international standard, jumped 7.8 per cent to \$109.03 per barrel.

"A more extended conflict raises the threat to physical infrastructure, extends disruptions through the Strait of Hormuz, and will entail a longer post-war recovery period, with price impacts spilling over later into the year," according to a report from BMI, a unit of Fitch Solutions.

The US only relies on the Persian Gulf for a fraction of the oil it imports, but oil is a commodity and prices are set in a global market.

The situation is very different in Asia. Japan, for example, relies on access to the Strait of Hormuz for much of the nation's oil import needs and would need to rely on alternative routes. But some analysts say Japan and other nations are counting on an agreement with Iran to allow transports.

Japan's benchmark Nikkei 225 gained 0.9 per cent in Friday morning trading to 52,938.62. South Korea's Kospi

jumped 2.1 per cent to 5,344.41. The Shanghai Composite sank 0.5 per cent to 3,899.57. Trading was closed in Hong Kong, Singapore, Australia, New Zealand, the Philippines, Indonesia and India.

Wall Street, where trading is closed on Friday, finished its first winning week since the start of the Iran war, although trading started out with a decline driven by a surge in oil prices.

That came after US President Donald Trump late Wednesday vowed the US would continue to attack Iran and failed to offer a clear timetable for ending the conflict in the Middle East.

The S&P 500 rose 7.37 points, or 0.1 per cent, to 6,582.69. Several days of solid gains this week helped the benchmark index notch a 3.4 per cent gain for the week. The Dow Jones Industrial Average fell 61.07 points, or 0.1 per cent, to 46,504.67. The Nasdaq composite rose 38.23 points, or 0.2 per cent, to 21,879.18. Both indexes also notched weekly gains.

Treasury yields remained relatively steady in the bond market. The yield on the 10-year Treasury fell to 4.30 per cent from 4.32 per cent.

In currency trading, the US dollar edged up to 159.66 Japanese yen from 159.53 yen. The euro cost \$1.1535, inching down from \$1.1537. (AP)

Telangana to be textile capital of South Asia by 2047: Reddy

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Hyderabad

Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy on Friday declared his ambitious goal to transform the state into the 'textile capital of South Asia' by 2047.

Speaking at the Asian Textiles Conference 2026 (ATEXCON), he said the government offers the best of infrastructure, land, power, water, incentives and "fastest execution" to the industry.

Noting that the state government's 'Telangana Rising 2047' vision seeks to catapult the state



towards a \$3 trillion economy by the centenary of the country's independence, he said the initiative holds significance for the textile industry.

"By 2047, we will transform Telangana into the textile capital of South Asia," Reddy said.

Jan Vishwas Bill implementation to ease compliance burden on businesses

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Industry lobby CII on Friday welcomed the passage of the Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Bill, 2026, by Parliament, saying that once implemented, it will substantially ease the compliance burden on businesses, accelerate dispute resolution, and help strengthen investor sentiment.

Parliament on Thursday passed the Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Bill, 2026, to amend 784 provisions in 79 central laws for decriminalising and rational-



ising minor offences to further improve the business environment and check harassment of people.

"CII warmly welcomes the passage of the Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Bill, 2026, which is a mile-

stone that reaffirms India's resolve to build a modern, trust-based regulatory environment conducive to investment and growth," CII Director General Chandrajit Banerjee stated.

The Bill introduces mean-

ingful structural improvements: replacing imprisonment provisions for minor infractions with proportionate monetary penalties or warnings; graded enforcement mechanisms that extend leniency to first-time contraventions; and rationalisation of fines in line with the severity of offences, he observed.

"Together, these measures will substantially ease the compliance burden on businesses, accelerate dispute resolution, and reduce the caseload on an already stretched judicial system," Banerjee said.

TAFE tractor sales rise 23 pc to 2,14,951 units in FY26

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Tractors and Farm Equipment Ltd on Friday reported a 23 per cent rise in total tractor sales with a record 2,14,951 units in 2025-26 as compared to 1,74,785 units in the preceding fiscal.

The company concluded the fiscal year on a strong note, delivering 37.4 per cent growth in March 2026, Tractors and Farm Equipment Ltd (TAFE) said in a statement.

It also achieved the highest-ever domestic sales with both the company's brands, Massey Ferguson and Eicher tractors, recording their highest sales, TAFE added.

Commenting on the performance, TAFE Vice Chairman Lakshmi Venu said this has been a very positive year for both the tractor market and for farmers across the country.

In addition to favourable monsoons, the government's move to reduce GST has provided significant relief to the farming sector, she added.



"We are now seeing a very encouraging trend in the penetration of mechanisation in rural areas. This year marks a meaningful shift in the access to mechanisation for small farmers with many first-time users entering the mechanisation ecosystem," Venu said.

This will go a long way in improving farm productivity

and strengthening farmer incomes across the country, she added.

At TAFE, Venu said, "We have remained sharply focused on the rapidly evolving preferences of our customers in this sector, and it is this focus that has enabled us to perform well in the market this year."

FROM THE WORLD

GERMANY

Man held after attack on train

A man was arrested on Thursday after threatening an attack on a high-speed train in Germany, police said. Several people were slightly injured when firecrackers were set off. The train was en route from Cologne to Frankfurt on Thursday evening. It was evacuated in Siegburg, not far from Cologne, and federal police said the man was restrained and arrested, the German News Agency reported. They said he had a knife in his backpack. The man had shut himself in a bathroom on the train, according to police. German newspaper Bild reported that the firecrackers were thrown into an aisle. Police said several people sustained superficial flesh wounds. There was no immediate information on the suspect.

ISLAMABAD

Pak to repay loan to UAE

Pakistan has decided to repay a loan of \$2 billion to the United Arab Emirates (UAE) on its demand, a media report said on Friday. The UAE had provided the fund to support the balance of payment, and it was being rolled out until recently. The UAE recently asked for the immediate return of the funds in the wake of the recent situation in the Middle East following the US-Israel war on Iran, sources said. Citing sources, Geo News reported that the amount was kept with the State Bank of Pakistan (SBP) as a safe deposit. Pakistan will return \$2 billion to Abu Dhabi by the end of this month, it added. The insiders said Pakistan has been paying around 6 per cent interest on the amount. In the past, the UAE used to roll over the deposit on a yearly basis. However, in December 2025, the amount was extended first for one month and then for two months until April 17. For the current fiscal year, Pakistan needed a rollover of approximately \$12 billion in external deposits, including \$5 billion from Saudi Arabia, \$4 billion from China and \$3 billion placed by the UAE.

Paramilitary forces in Sudan kill 10 people



FATMA KHALED
■ Cairo

Sudan's paramilitary forces killed at least 10 people on Thursday in a drone attack that hit a hospital in the south-central part of the country, said a medical group. Doctors Without Borders, also known as MSF, said the Sudanese paramilitary Rapid Support Forces, RSF, launched two drone strikes on Al-Jabalain Hospital in the White Nile province, hitting an operating theatre and a maternity ward. The strikes, the latest in an intensifying drone warfare between the army and the RSF, killed 10 people, including seven medical staffers, and injured at least 19 people. Those injured were transferred to a hospital in Kosti, which is around 50 miles (80 kilometres) away, said MSF. The strikes are the latest in a series of attacks on the health care system in Sudan that continues to be

Myanmar's parliament elects ruling general as president

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Bangkok

Myanmar's Parliament on Friday elected Min Aung Hlaing, a general who ousted Aung San Suu Kyi's civilian Government in 2021 and kept an iron grip on power for the past five years, as the country's new president. The move marks a nominal return to an elected Government but is widely considered as an effort to keep the army in power after an election organised by the military that opponents and independent observers deemed neither free nor fair, and as civil war rages. Transitioning to an elected Government is also seen as a way to improve frosty relations with some Southeast Asian neighbours following the military takeover. China and Russia have supported

the military administration, while Western powers imposed sanctions. **Min Aung Hlaing won an expected lopsided victory:** Min Aung Hlaing was one of three nominees for the president's post, but was virtually guaranteed the job as law-makers from military-backed parties and appointed members from the army hold a commanding majority in parliament. The vote was held in the newly renovated parliament building in the capital, Naypyitaw, which was damaged in last year's earthquake. Aung Lin Dwe, speaker of parliament's combined upper and lower house, announced that Min Aung Hlaing won 429 out of the 584 votes. The two runners-up become vice presidents. Nyo Saw, a former general, had served as an adviser to Min



Aung Hlaing, and Nan Ni Ni Aye, an ethnic Karen politician from the pro-military Union Solidarity and Development Party, will be the country's first female vice president. All three are expected to be inaugurated next week. Min Aung Hlaing, who holds the rank of senior general, earlier this week relinquished his post of commander-in-chief because the constitution prohibits the president from simultaneously holding the top military position. A close aide, Gen. Ye Win Oo, took over the powerful job. Meanwhile, much of the country remains enmeshed in a bloody civil war. **Opposition group says struggle for real change continues:** Nay Phone Latt, a spokesperson for the National Unity Government — Myanmar's main opposition organisation, which views itself as the country's legitimate government — charged that Min

Aung Hlaing is responsible for numerous war crimes, and his easy assumption of the presidency proved that the political change some countries had hoped for would not materialise. "The Myanmar people do not accept it. The revolution will continue with great momentum," he told The Associated Press. The 69-year-old Min Aung Hlaing had been the military chief since 2011. Under the military-imposed constitution, he held significant powers even before overthrowing Suu Kyi's government. Parliament members were elected in three phases in December and January. Major opposition parties, including Suu Kyi's former ruling National League for Democracy, were either blocked from running or refused to compete under conditions they deemed

unfair. Suu Kyi, 80, is serving a 27-year prison term on charges widely viewed as politically motivated. Myanmar was under military rule from 1962 to 2016, when Suu Kyi's party won a landslide election victory. It won an even greater mandate in the 2020 polls, but the army staged a takeover in 2021 before the new parliament could convene. Peaceful protests against military rule were then put down with deadly force, pushing pro-democracy activists to turn to armed resistance and ally themselves with ethnic minority groups who have been battling for greater autonomy for decades. **Deadly repression birthed an ongoing civil war:** Security concerns meant voting in the recent election could be held in only 263 of the country's

330 townships. Nearly 8,000 activists and civilians have been killed since the 2021 army takeover, and some 22,872 political detainees are imprisoned, according to the Assistance Association for Political Prisoners, an independent group that tracks rights violations. The military's major reliance on airstrikes — 1,140 strikes in 2025 alone, according to the US-based Armed Conflict Location & Event Data Project — accounts for hundreds of civilian casualties. "If Min Aung Hlaing thinks that an official civilian title will shield him from prosecution for the many grave violations of international law that he is accused of overseeing as head of the military, that is not how international justice works," Amnesty International Myanmar researcher Joe Freeman said in a statement.

Islamic State-linked rebels kill 43 in attack in eastern Congo

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Goma (Congo)

Rebels affiliated with the Islamic State group killed at least 43 people in eastern Congo, officials said Thursday. Fighters with the Allied Democratic Forces, or ADF, killed the civilians Wednesday night in Bafwakoa village. The Ugandan Islamist group operates on both sides of the porous border. "They set fire to houses in the village," Samuel Banapia, a member of civil society in the area, said by phone.

Congo's military in a statement said 43 had been killed, while local officials said the toll was at least 56, with several people missing and at least two taken hostage. Congo's army has struggled to contain the ADF as it battles several other rebel groups in the east. The most prominent is the Rwandan-backed M23 which last year seized major cities in the east. "The ADF avoids direct combat with the army and all its partners. That's why they attack the population in a way that sabotages peace efforts and acts of revenge



against the population, thus reprisals against our people," Lt Jules Ngongo, a spokesperson for Congo's military in

the east, said by phone. The number of ADF fighters in Congo is unclear, but they are a significant pres-

ence in the region and regularly attack civilians. The group originated in the late 1990s in Uganda and became affiliated with IS in 2019. Muslims make up about 10 per cent of the Congolese population, most of them in the east. In recent years, ADF attacks have intensified near the border with Uganda and spread toward Goma, eastern Congo's main city, as well as neighbouring Ituri province. Last year, the ADF killed 66 people and abducted several more in a neighbouring area.

Google now letting users change Gmail address

KELVIN CHANAP
■ New York

Good news for people who regret the Gmail address they came up with when they registered for an account: Google is now letting users change it. Google started quietly rolling out the change late last year in India and said this week in a blog post that it's now available for all Google Account users in the United States. There were no details on when it would be available to users in other countries. Google's CEO suggested the update will be welcomed by people who want to keep their accounts but have outgrown the awkward, embarrassing or nonsensical Gmail handles they created after the service launched 22 years ago. "2004 was a good year, but your Gmail address doesn't need to be stuck in it," Sundar Pichai wrote in a post on X, adding that the policy change



means users could "say goodbye to v0t3f0rp3dR02004@gmail.com or mrbright-side416@gmail.com (or whatever you were into at the time)." The company also updated a help page to reflect the new policy. Here's a quick run-through: It's a simple process: The procedure is fairly easy to follow. First, go to your Google Account page. From

the Google homepage in your computer browser or the Google mobile app, click the account icon in the top right corner, and then click or tap Manage your Google Account, then Personal info, then Email. You should be able to click Change Google Account email. If you don't see it, you might not have the option yet. Google says it's "gradually rolling out to all users." Now you'll have to enter

your new address so make sure you have an idea for what you want. Then click to confirm that you want to make the change. Google says addresses can't be identical to any existing address or one that was "used by someone in the past and then deleted." **Second thoughts:** But what if you miss your old Gmail address? Don't worry, you'll still be able to access it because Google is effectively creating a second Gmail address. The old address will remain as an alternate and messages sent to either the old or new addresses will appear in your Gmail inbox. To find out which address an email was sent to, check the "to" field. You can switch back to the old address by changing the settings in your Google account. If you don't like the new Gmail address you've created, unfortunately you're out of luck — at least for the next year. Google won't let

you create another Gmail address for your account until 12 months have passed. And you can only do so three times in total. **Potential issues to keep in mind:** Gmail addresses are also used to sign in to other Google services like YouTube, Google Docs as well as third-party websites and apps. But the company warns that some non-Google apps and services might not recognise you with the new Gmail address, so it provided some troubleshooting tips on a help page. Google also says Chromebook users might encounter problems, though many issues will go away after a few hours. It advises users to check a troubleshooting page but warned that if the problems persist, "you may need to change back to your previous Google Account email," although the new address can still be used to send and receive messages. (AP)

Zohran Mamdani wants to crack down on bad landlords



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ New York

On a recent weeknight, three tenants of an ageing Bronx building were trading apartment horror stories inside a packed ballroom lined with city bureaucrats. The occasion was the third in a series of "rental rip-off hearings," a new forum launched by New York Mayor Zohran Mamdani for disgruntled renters to air their complaints directly to housing officials — and in some cases, the mayor himself. As she waited in line, Gulhwa Yuldosheva said she worried that noxious mould in her apartment had worsened her child's asthma. Nearby, her downstairs neighbour, Marina Quiroz, was showing a video of rats scurrying through her kitchen to a representative of the city's tenant protection office. Ann Maitin, a longtime resident of the same building, had just met with the mayor. "He let me go over my three minutes," she said, holding up a spiral notebook's worth of grievances. Mamdani, a democratic socialist, swept into office on a promise of zealous tenant advocacy, framed

the event as a struggle session for renters, assuring the standing room only crowd that their stories would guide the city's efforts "to actually hold landlords accountable when they don't follow the law." To the residents of 705 Gerard Avenue, this raised a practical problem: No one seemed to know who actually owned their building. "It feels like such a basic question," said Maitin, a retired Verizon technician who recently organised the building's tenant association. "You'd think we'd have the right to that information." Their situation is hardly unique. As corporate owners and investor groups have grown their share of the rental market in New York City, they are increasingly shielding their identities behind limited liability companies, or LLCs. The practice, which has also been spreading nationally, is legal. But experts warn it could complicate Mamdani's promised crack-down, making it harder for the city and tenants to track the chronically negligent owners whose buildings the mayor has vowed to target and even seize.

White House set to release Trump's budget

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Washington

The White House is set to release President Donald Trump's 2027 budget on Friday, a sweeping blueprint that could boost Pentagon spending to \$1.5 trillion, the largest of its kind in decades, as the US focuses on military investments rather than other domestic programs. Even before the US-led war against Iran, the Republican president had indicated he wanted to bolster defense spending to modernise the military for 21st-century threats. Separately, the Pentagon last month proposed \$200 billion for the war effort and to

backfill munitions and supplies. Trump, speaking ahead of an address to the nation this week about the Iran war, signaled the military is his priority, setting up a clash ahead in Congress. "We're fighting wars. We can't take care of day care," Trump said at a private White House event Wednesday. "It's not possible for us to take care of day care, Medicaid, Medicare — all these individual things," he said. "They can do it on a state basis. You can't do it on a federal." The president's annual budget more broadly is considered a reflection of the administration's values and does not carry the force of law. The massive docu-



ment typically highlights an administration's priorities, but Congress, which handles federal spending issues, is free to reject it and often does. With the nation running nearly \$2 trillion annual deficits and the debt swelling past \$39 trillion,

UN lauds efforts by Indian peacekeepers in opening key corridor in South Sudan

YOSHITA SINGH
■ United Nations

The UN has lauded efforts by Indian peacekeepers deployed in South Sudan to re-open a critical supply route impacted by floods last year, emphasising the "vital role" played by peacekeeping missions in assisting local communities. Stephane Dujarric, spokesman for Secretary-General Antonio Guterres,



said amid these difficult times, there are some hopeful developments to in South Sudan. "Our Peacekeeping Mission there (UNMISS) reports

that in Upper Nile State, Indian peacekeepers from the Engineering Unit have successfully reopened a key section of the Malakal-Renk main supply route, which had been closed since last year's floods," he said at the daily press briefing. He said the new road alignment, which entailed reclaiming land from floodwaters to restore the road, will provide safer access. (PTI)

Cuba pardons 2,010 people

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Havana

The Cuban Government said Thursday it had pardoned 2,010 people at the same time the Trump administration has placed extreme pressure on the Government and suffocated the island with an oil blockade. Cuba's government said the pardons were a "humanitarian gesture" in connection with Holy Week and didn't mention mounting pressures with the US. The Government



said it had "released" foreigners and Cubans, including women, the elderly and young people. Cuban authorities didn't name who was released or under what conditions, nor did it mention the crimes they were accused of committing.

Iran fires on targets across Mideast while Israel-US hit Tehran

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Dubai

Iran fired on targets on Friday across the Middle East, damaging a desalination plant and setting a refinery ablaze in Kuwait, while American and Israeli airstrikes hit the Islamic Republic as the war neared the end of its fifth week. Tehran has kept the pressure on Israel and its Gulf Arab neighbours, despite US and Israeli insistence that Iran's military capabilities have been all but destroyed. In a sign that part of Iran's theocracy could be willing to negotiate, the country's former top diplomat published a proposal for ending the conflict in an influential American magazine.

Iran's attacks on Gulf energy infrastructure and its tight grip on the Strait of Hormuz, through which a fifth of the world's oil and natural gas transits in peacetime, have roiled stock markets, sent oil prices skyrocketing, and threatened to raise the cost of many basic goods, including food. Iran's ability to wreak havoc in the global economy has proved a major strategic advantage, and world leaders have struggled to figure out how to reopen the waterway. The UN Security Council was expected to look at a new proposal. **Iran's former top diplomat suggests terms to end the war:** Former Iranian Foreign Minister Mohammad Javad



Zarif - a seasoned diplomat with long experience negotiating with the West who remains close to a pragmatic wing of Iran's leadership —

wrote on Friday that the time has come to end the suffering on both sides. "Prolonged hostility will cause a greater loss of pre-

cious lives and irreplaceable resources without actually altering the existing stalemate," Zarif, who helped negotiate Iran's 2015 nuclear

deal with world powers, wrote in Foreign Affairs magazine. The US has presented Iran with a 15-point plan for a ceasefire that includes reopening the Strait of Hormuz, dismantling Iran's nuclear facilities and limiting its missile production in exchange for sanctions relief. But no signs of progress were apparent in the diplomatic effort. Iran's initial five-point counterproposal aired by hard-line state television included recognising Iran's sovereignty over the strait, the removal of US bases from the region, compensation for war damage, and a guarantee against further aggression — all things likely unpalatable to the Trump administration. Zarif's proposal included

elements of both plans. Iran "should offer to place limits on its nuclear program and to reopen the Strait of Hormuz in exchange for an end to all sanctions — a deal Washington wouldn't take before but might accept now," he wrote. Tehran and Washington were in talks about Iran's nuclear programme when the US and Israel began bombing on February 28 — the second time under President Donald Trump that the US has attacked while in high-level negotiations. It's not clear how much to read into Zarif's proposal. While he has no official position now in Iran's government, he helped get reformist President Masoud Pezeshkian

elected and would likely not have published such a piece without at least some authorisation from senior leaders. But it also remains clear who in Iran has the authority to negotiate since many of Iran's leaders have been killed in the war. Immediately after the piece came out, Zarif wrote he had been "torn" about it — a sign he may already face pressure at home. What's more, it's not clear how Trump will respond. He has vacillated between saying the US is negotiating an end to the war and threatening to expand it. Thousands of US Marines and paratroopers have been ordered to the region, raising speculation that there could be a ground offensive.

Hegseth asks Army's top uniformed officer, 2 others to step down

KONSTANTIN TOROPIN
Washington

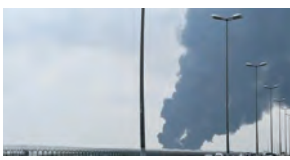
Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth has ousted the Army's top uniformed officer and two other generals, the Pentagon said Thursday without giving a reason for the departures while the United States is waging a war against Iran. Gen Randy George "will be retiring from his position as the 41st Chief of Staff of the Army effective immediately," said Sean Parnell, the Pentagon's top spokesman. George has held the post of Army chief of staff, which typically runs for four years, since August 2023 under the Biden administration. The ouster, reported earlier by CBS News, is just the latest of more than a dozen firings of top generals and admirals by Hegseth since he took office last year. Like many of those other firings, Pentagon officials are not offering a reason for George's departure, which comes nearly five weeks into US-Israel attacks on Iran and with no clear timeline from President Donald Trump on when the war may end. Hegseth also has ousted Army Gen David Hodne and Army Maj Gen William Green, according to a Pentagon official who



spoke on condition of anonymity to discuss sensitive leadership changes. A reason for their departures also was not given. **General who rose rapidly under Hegseth will fill in:** Gen Christopher LaNeve will be stepping in as acting Army chief of staff, the Pentagon official said. LaNeve was serving as Hegseth's top military aide when Trump suddenly nominated him to be the Army's vice chief of staff last October. It is a meteoric rise for an officer who was only a two-star general two years ago. He would take over for George, who is a graduate of West Point Military Academy and an infantry officer who served in the first Gulf War as well as Iraq and Afghanistan. He also served as Defence Secretary Lloyd Austin's top military aide from 2021 to 2022 during the Biden administration before taking on top leadership roles in the Army. George made it through

the initial round of firings under the Trump administration in February 2025, when Hegseth removed top military leaders, including Adm Lisa Franchetti, the Navy's top uniformed officer, and Gen Jim Slife, the second in command at the Air Force. Trump also fired Gen Charles "CQ" Brown Jr as chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff. Since then, more than a dozen other top military generals and admirals have either retired early or been removed from their posts. Among those departures was George's deputy, Gen. James Minguis, who was vice chief of staff of the Army for less than two years. LaNeve was nominated to that post after earlier being plucked from commanding the Eighth Army in South Korea after less than a year in the job to be Hegseth's top military aide. A spokesman for George could not be reached for comment. **Two other Army generals fired:** Of the other generals who were fired, Hodne had been head of the Army Transformation and Training Command, a unit that was only stood up in December as part of George's effort to modernise the Army and amid Hegseth's push to reduce the number of general officers in the military. (AP)

Iranian attack damaged desalination plant: Kuwait



ASSOCIATED PRESS
Dubai

Kuwait said on Friday an Iranian attack damaged a desalination plant. The attack came after an oil refinery was hit by drones on Friday morning, Kuwait said without elaborating that the attack on the desalination plant caused "material damage to some of the plant's components." Desalination provides the majority of the water for the Gulf Arab states and Iran, drawing the salty waters of the Persian Gulf into drinking water for the desert region.

Suicide car bomb blast kills 5 in Pakistan



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Peshawar

A suicide car bomb blast targeting a police station in northwest Pakistan's Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province killed five persons including three women and a child late Thursday, police said. Several nearby houses were also damaged in the blast. At least four police personnel were reported injured. Emergency response and rescue operations are ongoing as authorities continued to assess the situation. Police said a suicide bomber aboard a car hit a police station in Domel tehsil of Bannu district, triggering a powerful explosion that was heard even from afar. The intensity of the blast and the reverberating explosion triggered panic among residents. Gunfire erupted immediately after the explosion, further heightening tension in the area.

We will work together on Hormuz: French-South Korean leaders

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Seoul

French President Emmanuel Macron and South Korean President Lee Jae Myung agreed on Friday to work together to help reopen the Strait of Hormuz and ease global economic uncertainties caused by the war in the Middle East. Their summit in Seoul came as US President Donald Trump slammed allies for not supporting the US and Israeli war against Iran. Macron was making his first visit to South Korea since taking office in 2017 as part of an Asian tour that already has taken him to Japan. Macron told Lee at the start of the meeting that the two countries can play a role in helping to stabilise the situation in the Middle East, including the Strait of Hormuz, according to South Korean media. At a joint televised briefing



afterwards, Macron underscored the need for France and South Korea to cooperate to help reopen the strait and de-escalate Middle East animosities, while Lee said the two affirmed "their resolve to cooperate to secure the safe shipping route in the Strait of Hormuz." The two leaders did not take questions and did not elaborate on how they

would help reopen the strait, the narrow waterway between Iran and Oman through which about one-fifth of the world's oil passes. Lee said he and Macron agreed to expand cooperation in technology, energy and other areas. South Korean and French officials also signed agreements to cooperate on nuclear fuel supply chains, jointly invest in an offshore

wind project in southern South Korea and to collaborate on critical minerals. Macron's Asia trip comes as Trump has ramped up his frustration with allies. In a speech on Wednesday, Trump said Americans "don't need" the Strait but the countries that do "must grab it and cherish it." "Let South Korea, you know, we only have 45,000 soldiers in harm's way over there, right next to a nuclear force — let South Korea do it," Trump said. "Let Japan do it. They get 90 per cent of their oil from the Strait. Let China do it." Macron has said reopening the Strait of Hormuz through a military operation was unrealistic. South Korean officials have said they were in contact with Washington on the issue and that Seoul wasn't considering paying Iran transit fees to secure fuel shipments through the strait.

Pak rises petrol prices amid US-Iran war

SAJJAD HUSSAIN
Islamabad

Pakistan has announced an unprecedented increase of 43 per cent and 55 per cent in the prices of petrol and High-Speed Diesel (HSD), respectively, in response to spiking global oil prices amid the US-Israel war on Iran. The Ggovernment made the announcement on Thursday. The price of petrol has been increased by ₹137.23 per litre (42.7 per cent) to ₹458.41 from ₹321.17, while HSD by ₹184.49 per litre (55 per cent) to ₹520.35 from ₹335.86, with immediate effect. The price of kerosene was also increased by ₹34.08 per litre to ₹457.80. The Government also adjusted the petroleum levy rates to limit the increase in diesel prices as the levy on petrol was increased to



₹160 per litre from ₹105, while it was reduced to zero on diesel from ₹55. Petroleum Minister Ali Pervaiz Malik while making the announcement, which he termed as a "difficult decision", said that the objective was to restrict subsidies to the most deserving segments while maintaining fiscal discipline and preserving economic stability. Advisor to Prime Minister on Economic Affairs,

Khurram Shehzad, said in an interview with the Geo News that the Government increased the prices to control consumption after it recorded an 8 per cent increase in petrol and a 13 per cent rise in HSD consumption last month. "The government took the decision to increase prices after resisting the rise during the past three weeks when it first raised prices by ₹55 soon after the war started," he said. (PTI)

Leading Iranian human rights lawyer detained in Tehran, says Daughter

SARAH EL DEEB
Beirut

Leading Iranian human rights lawyer Nasrin Sotoudeh was detained by Iranian intelligence agents at her house in Tehran overnight, her daughter said Thursday. Prize-winning Nasrin Sotoudeh, 64, is renowned for defending activists, opposition politicians and women prosecuted for removing their headscarves. She has been imprisoned multiple times and is currently out on bail for health reasons. Her husband, Reza Khandan, also a well-known activist, is currently imprisoned in Tehran's infamous Evin prison. Mehraveh Khandan, speaking to The Associated Press from Amsterdam, said she received messages from her family in Iran through an intermediary, confirming her mother's arrest. Restrictions on communications and the internet imposed since January make contact with the outside world almost impossible. News of Sotoudeh's detention comes as Iranian authorities have intensified their crackdown on dissent and political activists even as



the war with the US and Israel rages. Since the war began in February 28, authorities have reportedly arrested hundreds, often for communicating with foreign media. Authorities have also stepped up executions of detained protesters, who were facing the death sentence. Rights groups have said the crackdown is meant to instill fear and deter new protests. Days before her arrest, Sotoudeh gave an interview published on Monday to a Persian media outlet abroad in which she commented on the war, saying the Islamic Republic's policies "have exposed us to death." She also spoke out against the government

crackdown on protests in January — the largest against the Islamic Republic in decades — which were met with a brutal crackdown. Khandan said she is worried about her mother, who has a heart condition, because of possible US-Israeli attacks on detention facilities and because "our regime became even more brutal after this war started." Sotoudeh's arrest also comes after news that Iran's imprisoned Nobel Peace Prize laureate Narges Mohammadi may have suffered a heart attack. Mohammadi's French lawyer Chirinne Ardakani told AP Thursday that her legal team learned of Mohammadi's condition during a brief prison visit last week. "She appeared extremely emaciated, pale, weak, and had difficulty moving. In fact, she was even accompanied to the waiting room by a nurse. "We learned from Narges Mohammadi that she had a heart attack on March 24th, that she was found unconscious in her cell, and that it was actually her fellow inmates who took her to the infirmary," Ardakani said. (AP)

Drafting proposal with Oman to monitor Hormuz: Iran

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Dubai

Iran claimed its drafting a proposal with Oman to 'monitor' Strait of Hormuz. The comments by Kazem Gharibabadi, an Iranian diplomat, quoted by the state-run IRNA news agency, described the proposal as "intended to facilitate and ensure safe passage and provide better services to ships passing through this route." Iran's attacks on shipping in the region, as well as reportedly demanding as much as \$2 million for passage through the narrow mouth of the Persian Gulf, have created a stranglehold on the route. It is unclear what the proposal would mean. Oman did not immediately acknowledge it.



Artemis II astronauts rocket toward moon after spending day around Earth

MARCIA DUNNAP
Cape Canaveral (US)

NASA's Artemis II astronauts fired their engines and blazed toward the moon Thursday night, breaking free of the chains that have trapped humanity in shallow laps around Earth in the decades since Apollo. The so-called translunar ignition came 25 hours after liftoff, putting the three Americans and a Canadian on course for a lunar fly-around early next week. Their Orion capsule bolted out of orbit around Earth right on cue and chased after the moon to nearly 400,000 km away. It was the first such engine firing for a space crew since Apollo 17 set out on that era's final moonshot on December 7, 1972. NASA reported that preliminary reports indicate

it went well. NASA had the Artemis II crew stick close to home for a day to test their capsule's life-support systems before clearing them for lunar departure. Now committed to the moon, the Artemis II test flight is the opening act for NASA's grand plans for a moon base and sustained lunar living. Commander Reid Wiseman, pilot Victor Glover, Christina Koch and Jeremy Hansen will dash past the moon then hang a U-turn and zip straight home without stopping on land. In the process, they will become the farthest humans have ever traveled from Earth, breaking the Apollo 13 distance record set in 1970. They also may become the fastest during their reentry at flight's end on April 10. Glover, Koch and Hansen already have

made history as the first Black, the first woman and the first non-US citizen to launch to the moon. Apollo's 24 lunar travelers were all white men. To set the mood for the day's main event, Mission Control woke up the crew with John Legend's "Green Light" featuring Andre 3000 and a medley of NASA teams cheering them. "We are ready to go," pilot Victor Glover said. Mission Control gave the final go-ahead minutes before the critical engine firing, telling the astronauts that they were embarking on "humanity's lunar homecoming arc" to bring them back to Earth. Koch replied: "With this burn to the moon, we do not leave Earth. We choose it." The next major milestone will be Monday's lunar flyby. Orion will zoom 6,400 km



beyond the moon before turning back, providing unprecedented and illuminated views of the lunar far

side, at least for human eyes. The cosmos will even treat the Artemis II astronauts to a total solar eclipse as the

moon temporarily blocks the sun from their perspective. While awaiting their orbital departure earlier

Thursday, the astronauts savoured the views of Earth from tens of thousands of miles high. Koch told Mission Control that they can make out the entire coastlines of continents and even the South Pole, her old stomping ground. "It is just absolutely phenomenal," radioed Koch, who spent a year at an Antarctic research station before joining NASA. NASA is counting on the test flight to kickstart the entire Artemis program and lead to a moon landing by two astronauts in 2028. Orion's toilet may need some design tweaks before that happens. The so-called lunar loo malfunctioned as soon as the Artemis crew reached orbit Wednesday evening. Mission Control guided astronaut Koch through some plumbing tricks and she

finally got it going, but not before having to resort to using contingency urine storage bags. Controllers also managed to bump up the cabin temperature. It was so cold earlier in the flight that the astronauts had to dig into their suitcases for long-sleeved clothes. The contingency urine bags came in handy later in the day. Mission Control ordered the crew to fill a bunch of the empty bags with water from the capsule's dispenser. A valve issue arose with the dispenser following liftoff, and NASA wanted plenty of drinking water on hand for the crew in case the problem worsened. The astronauts used straws and syringes to fill the pouches with more than two gallons worth before pivoting to the moon. (AP)

PROSPECT



BCCI Secretary Devajit Lon Saikia speaking at the A Tribute to Premadhar Sarma, a solemnly organised memorial by Guwahati Sports Association, Gauhati Town Club and Assam Sports Journalists' Association



Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma at an election rally in Barak Valley in Assam



BJP National President Nitin Nabin at a public rally in Kamalapur, near Guwahati

Catholic union seeks withdrawal of FCRA Amendment Bill

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The All India Catholic Union on Friday demanded the complete withdrawal of the FCRA Amendment Bill and said the Christian community “cannot be fully satisfied”

until it is scrapped entirely. The union said, “With its memory of Government intransigence and political perfidy, the Christian community cannot be fully satisfied until the Union Government withdraws the FCRA Amendment Bill, 2026.

Delhi Budget: A Thinking Govt with Visible Intent



RAJ KUMAR BHATIA

When a bird takes flight, it does not just look at the sky. It looks for a safe nest for its young.

That is the difference between ordinary governance and a thinking Government.

The Delhi Budget 2026–27 is not just ₹1,03,700 crore. It is not just numbers. It is intent, empathy, and vision. It reflects what Prime Minister Narendra Modi has consistently emphasised: “Governance must transform lives, not just create schemes.”

This philosophy is clearly reflected in the governance approach of the Rekha Gupta Government, which is focused on delivering outcomes on the ground with accountability, transparency, and speed. Under the leadership of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, governance in Delhi is being redefined — from announcement-driven to delivery-driven, from intent to impact.

The Chief Minister has consistently emphasised that “Development is meaningful only when every citizen feels secure and empowered.” This guiding principle is visible in every layer of this Budget.

This is a Budget that begins with life itself.

Fifty-six tests for newborns under the ANMOL scheme are not merely a policy decision; they are reassurance for every mother.

This is a Budget that empowers a young girl. An allocation of ₹90 crore to provide bicycles to more than one lakh girls is not about mobility alone; it is about freedom, confidence, and dignity. Women's safety has been strengthened through investments in surveillance systems, better lighting, and safer public transport. This is not infrastructure alone; this is trust built into the system.

Beyond these immediate interventions, the Budget adopts a broader, life-cycle approach to governance, addressing the needs of citizens at different stages of life. It seeks to connect policy not only with infrastructure, but with lived experience.

Healthcare continues to be a central pillar. With more than ₹12,000 crore allocated to health and the development of 750 Ayushman Arogya Mandir, there is a clear effort to expand access to quality care. At the same time, the increase in undergraduate medical seats from around 600 to over 800 reflects a long-term investment in healthcare capacity.

Education is being aligned more closely with opportunity. The introduction of a Talent Hunt Scheme and the expansion of skill development initiatives signal a move towards identifying and nurturing potential, enabling young citizens to move towards self-reliance.

Infrastructure development remains a key focus, guided by the Four S framework articulated by Prime Minister Narendra Modi — scope, scale, speed, and skill. Allocations of ₹5,900 crore for public



works and ₹7,900 crore for urban development reflect this direction.



Visible improvements are planned in everyday infrastructure, including end-to-end recarpeting of 750 kilometres of roads. Targeted investments in Trans-Yamuna development and Delhi Gram Vikas Board initiatives indicate an effort to ensure more balanced regional growth.

Basic services are also being strengthened. With ₹9,000 crore allocated to the Delhi Jal Board, the expansion of water supply and sewerage infrastructure aims to address long-standing urban challenges.

Transport planning reflects a forward-looking approach, with metro expansion, increased deploy-

ment of electric buses, and a broader push towards sustainable mobility. Environmental priorities are further reinforced through the expansion of the green Budget and the scaling up of waste processing to 15,000 metric tonnes per day.

An important dimension of the budget is its emphasis on dignity across generations. The introduction of initiatives such as Vayo Anand Yojana creates meaningful spaces for senior citizens to engage, participate, and live with joy. It recognises that development is not only about growth, but also about respect and care for those who have built the foundations of society.

Similarly, initiatives such as Mahila Haat (Rani Haat) provide platforms for women artisans to connect directly with markets. These are not merely economic measures; they are pathways to self-reliance, entrepreneurship, and dignity, where skill is transformed into sustainable livelihood and

independence.

Another important dimension of the Rekha Gupta Government's approach is compassion as a governing principle. Investments in veterinary hospitals and gaushala facilities reflect a broader understanding of responsibility within an urban ecosystem.

As Prime Minister Narendra Modi has observed, “Good governance must become a people's movement.” This Budget reflects that vision by reaching multiple sections of society and integrating welfare with development.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta has also emphasised that “We are not planning for the next year; we are planning for the next generation.” This long-term orientation is visible in the budget's focus on sustainability, capacity building, and institutional strengthening.

What ultimately defines this Budget — and the governance approach of the Rekha Gupta Government — is its attempt to balance scale with sensitivity. It recognises the concerns of households, the aspirations of young people, and the dignity of senior citizens, while building systems that are efficient, inclusive, and forward-looking.

It may therefore be seen not merely as a financial Budget, but as a statement of direction—one that seeks to build a Delhi that is not only more developed, but also more inclusive, secure, and humane.

The author is Member of Legislative Assembly from Adarsh Nagar constituency of Delhi

Swami Avdeshanand Giri delivers first Dr Bindeshwar Pathak memorial lecture

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The inaugural memorial lecture in honour of Dr Bindeshwar Pathak was delivered in the national Capital on Thursday by spiritual leader and scholar Swami Avdeshanand Giri, who paid tributes to the late reformer's enduring legacy. Remembering Dr Pathak as a “true saint and visionary”, Swami Giri highlighted his lifelong commitment to restoring dignity to millions through sanitation reform, eradication of untouchability and upliftment of marginalised communities. He underscored that Dr Pathak's work transcended cleanliness, evolving into a broader movement for social justice and human dignity.

Kumar Dilip, President of Sulabh International, described the event as more than just a tribute and called it a “collective resolve” to carry forward the reformer's unfinished mission. He also announced the institution of the Dr Bindeshwar Pathak Memorial Award from 2027, which will include a cash prize of ₹11 lakh, a gold medal and a citation to honour outstanding contributions in social reform and sanitation.

Convenor Nitya Pathak also expressed gratitude to Swami Avdeshanand Giri for delivering the inaugural address, stating that his thoughts and blessings would guide future efforts. Meanwhile, Vice President Dr Sutirtha Sariah reflected on Dr



Pathak's transformative impact, noting that he “did not merely build toilets, but restored dignity”, redefining sanitation as a matter of human freedom and social justice.

The lecture followed a day-long conference on the Sociology of Sanitation, chaired by noted scholar Professor Neel Ratan, where academics from across the country presented research on sanitation as a driver of public health, gender equality and social transformation. The memorial lecture and academic conference together marked a significant step in sustaining Dr Pathak's intellectual and humanitarian legacy, reaffirming Sulabh International's commitment to inclusive development.

Rajesh Kumar takes charge as Director (Finance) of REC Limited

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



Rajesh Kumar on Thursday formally assumed charge as the Director (Finance) of REC Limited, a premier Non-Banking Financial Company (NBFC) under the Ministry of Power. The appointment, approved by the Appointments Committee of the Cabinet (ACC) on March 25, marks a significant leadership transition for the corporation as it spearheads India's ambitious energy transition and infrastructure development.

Kumar, an alumnus of the prestigious Shri Ram College of Commerce (SRCC), brings more than three decades of exhaustive experience in the public sector, specifically within the power and infrastructure financing domains. A dual-qualified professional — holding both Chartered Accountant (CA) and Cost & Management Accountant (CMA) credentials — his expertise spans accounts, taxation, treasury, project appraisals, and regulatory compliance.

Prior to his elevation to the Board, Kumar served as the Executive Director (Finance) at REC Limited. His career trajectory

is defined by two decades of service at REC Limited, where he deepened his expertise in power sector financing and resource mobilisation, alongside a decade-long stint with a CPSE specialising in engineering and project consultancy. Furthermore, he has demonstrated versatile leadership as the Chief Executive Officer of REC Power Development and Consultancy Limited (RECPDCL). During his tenure at REC, Kumar has been credited with transforming the organisation's domestic resource mobilisation strategy through the introduction of sophisticated financial instruments. He was instrumental in launching Tax-Efficient Hybrid Bonds and AAA-rated Perpetual Bonds, alongside CBDT-notified Zero Coupon

Bonds and Capital Gain Bonds, which significantly expanded the investor base and reduced borrowing costs.

Beyond resource mobilisation, Kumar has provided strategic oversight for multilateral funding, Environmental, Social, and Governance (ESG) projects, and the corporation's digital transformation. His interventions in complex tax matters have reportedly resulted in substantial savings for corporation, while his knack for innovation led to initiation of new business policies that have bolstered the company's financial standing.

Kumar's appointment comes at a crucial juncture as REC undergoes restructuring aimed at achieving greater scale and efficiency within public sector NBFCs. As a former Board Member of various DISCOMs and transmission companies, his governance experience is expected to be vital in navigating the current phase of consolidation. Officials noted that as the corporation continues to lead the financing of India's energy transition, Kumar's profound expertise in strategic investments will be central to achieving long-term financial goals.

Speaker Om Birla completes digital self-enumeration for Census 2027

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla on Friday participated in the first phase of Census 2027 by completing his self-enumeration at his official residence in New Delhi.

Highlighting the significance of the exercise, Birla observed that the national Census marks the dawn of a new era in governance. He noted that for the first time in India's history, the entire Census process is being conducted through digital platforms. This shift, he emphasised, empowers every citizen with the right and the convenience to personally record their household details through a process that is “extremely secure, accurate, and user-friendly”.

Birla further remarked that

the transition to digital enumeration is a testament to India's technological advancement, ensuring that national data is more precise and reflective of the ground reality.

Reaffirming the vision of ‘Jan Ganaana se Jan Kalyan’ (Census for Public Welfare), the Speaker made a fervent appeal to all citizens to participate actively in this vital national process.

During the self-enumeration process, the Registrar General and Census Commissioner of India, Mritunjay Kumar Narayan, was present to facilitate the registration.

DAILY SUDOKU

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

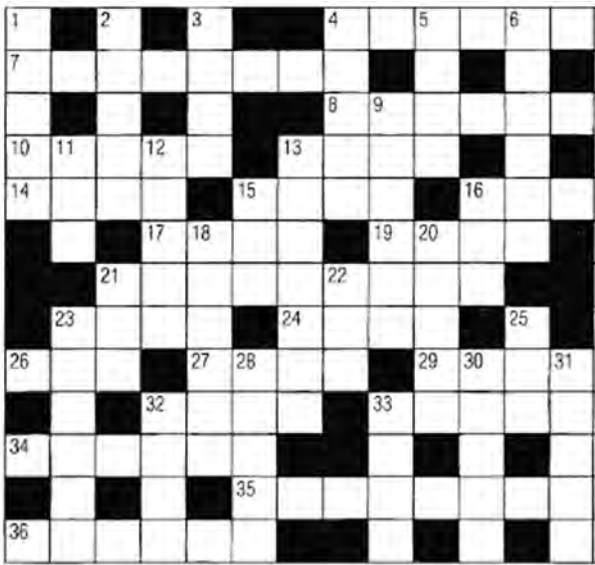
Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9×9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3×3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (03.04.26)

2	8	4	7	6	3	5	1	9
1	6	5	4	2	9	7	8	3
7	9	3	5	8	1	6	2	4
8	3	9	2	1	5	4	7	6
5	7	6	8	3	4	1	9	2
4	1	2	6	9	7	3	5	8
3	5	8	1	4	2	9	6	7
6	4	7	9	5	8	2	3	1
9	2	1	3	7	6	8	4	5

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
SATURDAY | APRIL 4, 2026



ACROSS

- 4 These people can set a shining example (6)
7 Talk in opposition (8)
8 A case of one and two not making three (6)
10 Rich, having some wealth, nevertheless mortal (5)
13 A win in a wagon (4)
14 A spare tyre? (4)
15 Determination not to be intestate? (4)
16 Member of a popular movement (3)
17 The disgrace of a big-headed clique? (4)
19 It goes a little way to stave off starvation (4)

DOWN

- 1 Mock one's food? (5)
2 Insanitary female? (5)
3 One is presumably properly drilled (4)
4 To break a plate is a bit of a bloomer (5)
5 Legal right to a number of points (4)
6 It's hard to reverse, perhaps, without starting! (6)
9 The brotherly Mr. Wright? (6)
11 Everything in show would be superficial (3)
12 Though good, he makes a bad start in a faulty boat (5)
13 Weakens, but keeps her wits about her! (7)

- 21 Have raw recruits never been there? (9)
23 Legendary lovers of pipe music (4)
24 Goes astray badly in outer Serbia (4)
26 There's precious little of it! (3)
27 Foreigner returning from Breslau (4)
29 Exploits us two ways (4)
32 He gets conflicting directions from females (4)
33 Was inclined to have a bit of fun when let out (5)
34 Some more pasta to make a meal of (6)
35 Building in Crete, possibly, with German capital (8)
36 Gentle as nurse (6)

- 15 Initially works well as a cooking utensil (3)
16 Consumed some water! (3)
18 Can be severe, or maybe less so (6)
20 One can take it to be disputative (5)
21 A moving part, albeit mechanical (3)
22 In “Major Barbara”, an associate of royalty (3)
23 Think awfully highly of Paul (6)
25 Keen desire for money (3)
28 Go into forbidden territory (5)
30 Nominally shaky ideas (5)
31 Drama coach? (5)
32 It's tough being deceived outright (4)
33 Defeat at a good speed (4)

SOLUTION (03.04.26)

- ACROSS
1. Potter
7. Ex-citing
8. Di-Al
10. R-e-ally
11. Resign
14. Coe
16. R-emit
17. Tier
19. Toast

21. Me-tre
22. Yacht
23. Loom
26. Late-r
28. Lip
29. Alas-Ka
30. Cave-RN
31. O-wen
32. Kare-Nina
33. Trying.

- DOWN
1. Parrot
2. Te-ilo-r
3. R-Ely
4. Di-verse
5. Mini-m
6. Age-NT
8. D-ace
9. Ale
12. Set
13. GI's-MO
15. Moths

18. I-deal
19. Tec
20. Art
21. Marking
22. Yes
23. Livery
24. Open
25. Mining
26. L-acks
27. Tarry
28. Law
30. Co-at.

BRIEFLY

Aditi highest placed Indian at Aramco Championship golf



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Las Vegas

Aditi Ashok was the top placed Indian at Tied-58th spot after the first round of the Aramco Championships golf tournament. She carded 2-over 72.

Among other Indians, Avani Prashanth, Diksha Dagar and Pranavi Urs were way down. Avani and Diksha carded rounds of 3-over 75 to find themselves at T-71 while Pranavi carded 4-over 76 to put herself at T-90.

The projected cut is set at 2-over par and this puts Aditi on the brink while the rest are in danger of an early end to their week. The leaders after the first round were Miyu Yamashita and Nasa Hataoka of Japan along with American Lauren Coughlin. All three carded 5-under 67. One shot behind the leaders in T-4 are Hyo Joo Kim of South Korea along with Americans Nelly Korda and Jing Yan.

Kim enters this week having won her last two events and will be looking to capitalise on another strong start.

Nelly Korda who lost out to Kim last week by two strokes is also in with a chance.

Sudarshan Yellamaraju tied 31st after Rd1 of Texas Open



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ San Antonio (USA)

India-born Canadian golfer Sudarshan Yellamaraju opened with a roller-coaster three-under 69 to be tied-31st at Valero Texas Open.

The leader at the end of the first day was Mark Hubbard. Hubbard carded seven-under 65 after starting his round on the front-nine.

He dropped his only bogey on the fourth hole before striking eight birdies in the round to close the day at seven-under par.

Yellamaraju started his round with three straight birdies on the 10th, 11th and 12th before dropping shots on the 15th and 18th. He picked another birdie on the 17th hole.

On the front nine, the 24-year-old started with two birdies before dropping shots on the fifth and seventh and closing the round with a birdie on the ninth.

Five players shared the second spot with a score of six-under. The players in this group are Tony Finau, Davis Thompson, Andrew Putnam, Robert MacIntyre and Steven Fisk.

Tommy Fleetwood was tied seventh alongside seven other players after carding five-under 67 on the first day.

PSB seeks 3 fold increase in annual sports budget



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Karachi

The State controlled Pakistan Sports Board (PSB) has requested Prime Minister Shahbaz Sharif to increase its annual budget from 1.2 billion rupees to 4.9 billion rupees to keep up with the ever changing demands of national and international sporting events.

The decision to increase the annual budget was taken at the 36th annual general body meeting of the PSB in Islamabad this week to strengthen the sports eco system in Pakistan.

Compared to neighbouring India and other countries in Asia, the Government's budget for sports is considered the lowest, leading to just one gold medal in the Olympic games since 1984. Another significant decision taken at the meeting was the approval of a Long-Term Athlete Development Programme (LTADP), designed to shift Pakistan's sports system from an activity-based model to a performance-driven structure aligned with international standards and Olympic cycles.

National federations have been directed to submit four-year development plans within 90 days, with funding to be tied to performance and compliance.

The meeting, chaired by Rana Sana Ullah Khan, Federal Minister for Inter-Provincial Coordination and President PSB, endorsed key structural changes aimed at improving governance, athlete development and international competitiveness.

The meeting also emphasised on national federations to strictly adhere to the term limitations for various positions.

Barcelona in Women's Champions League semis

KAREL JANICEK ■ Barcelona

Barcelona scored six goals again to outclass Real Madrid 6-0 and reach a record-extending eighth straight semifinal in the Women's Champions League.

Caroline Graham Hansen scored twice on Thursday and Alexia Putellas, Irene Paredes, Ewa Pajor and Esmee Brugts all scored a goal apiece for the three-time champion in the second leg of their quarterfinal to advance on a 12-2 aggregate score.

Barcelona will face Bayern Munich for a spot in the May 23 final in Oslo.

It was Barcelona's sixth win over Madrid in the women's clasico in all competitions this season and it was watched by 60,067 spectators in the women's first game at the newly revamped Camp Nou.

Later on Thursday, OL Lyonnes needed extra time to beat Wolfsburg 4-0 and will take on defending champion Arsenal in the last four. Barcelona didn't waste time in proving its superiority, giving Madrid no chance for an unprecedented quarterfinal turnaround after last week's 6-2 result in the Spanish capital.

In the eighth minute, Pajor's attempt



from the left side of the box was saved by goalkeeper Misa Rodriguez. But Putellas scored off the rebound to mark the two-time Ballon d'Or winner's 500th Barcelona appearance.

With the goal, Putellas became the first Spanish player to have 30 goals in women's club competitions, according to UEFA.

Seven minutes later, Graham Hansen headed in the second from close range.

Paredes made it 3-0 with another header off a corner from Graham Hansen in the 27th.

The home team went into halftime with a 4-0 lead after Pajor's seventh goal in the Champions League this season and career 40th in European club competitions.

Graham Hansen chipped the ball over Rodriguez 10 minutes into the second half for a 5-0 lead. Clara Serrajordi set up Brugts to tap in the sixth.

Barcelona seeks to reclaim the title it lost to Arsenal last season. The Catalan club topped the league phase with an unbeaten campaign that included 20 goals scored and three against.

Substitutes save Lyon: Substitutes Melchie Dumornay and Damaris Egurola scored off corner kicks five minutes apart at the end of the first half of extra time, and another substitute - Tabitha Chawinga — sealed the win, 4-1 on aggregate, to send the record eight-time champions to the next round.

Leading 1-0 from the first leg, Wolfsburg relied on defense and some great saves by goalkeeper Stina Johannes. Lily Yohannes, an 18-year-old United States international, erased the one-goal deficit with a deflected low shot in the first half. (AP)

Indian-origin Bodhana Sivanandan is England's top-rated female chess player

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Indian-origin chess prodigy Bodhana Sivanandan has become England's top-rated female player, according to the latest rating list of the International Chess Federation (FIDE).

The 11-year-old, whose parents moved from Tiruchirappalli in Tamil Nadu to England in 2007, has 2366 FIDE rating points.

The primary school student based in North London has overtaken four-time British women's champion, Lan Yao, who is 25, at the top of the FIDE list for England. With this, she has also broken into the world's top 100 women for the first time, currently sitting at number 72, stated the English Chess Federation in a press release.

"It is an extraordinary rise for a Harrow schoolgirl who took up the game during (the 2020 COVID-19) lock-



down after finding a chessboard and set in a bag her father wanted to throw out," the release added.

Former British Prime Minister Rishi Sunak, who is also of Indian origin, congratulated Sivanandan and

recalled the time he played a game with her at his official residence.

"Huge congratulations to Bodhana Sivanandan on becoming England's top female chess player at just 11 years old. We once played each other in the Downing Street garden. Let's just say her success has not come as a shock," he posted on 'X'.

Sivanandan became a Woman International Master last year.

She went on to outwit Ukraine's former world champion, Grandmaster Mariya Muzychuk, at the European Club Cup in Rhodes, Greece.

"She is blazing a trail not just for women and girls in the game, but for all chess players in England. Across all sports, she must be one of the most prodigious talents England has ever produced," Richard Walsh, CEO of the English Chess Federation, said.

Mickelson cites family health matter in pulling out of Masters

DOUG FERGUSONAP ■ Augusta (US)

Three-time champion Phil Mickelson withdrew from the Masters, citing a personal health matter with his family that kept him out of all but one of the five LIV Golf events this year.

"Unfortunately I will not play in the Masters Tournament next week and will be out for an extended period of time as my family continues to navigate a personal health matter," Mickelson posted on social media on Thursday.

Tiger Woods said on Tuesday he was taking an indefinite leave to seek treatment after his arrest on suspicion of driving under the influence in a Feb. 27 crash in Florida.

It will be the first time neither

Woods nor Mickelson will be at the Masters since 1994, when Woods was a senior in high school and Mickelson had broken his leg while skiing earlier that year.

Mickelson called the Masters "definitely the most special week of the year," and his record reflects that. He won his first major at Augusta National in 2004, the last player to win the Masters by one shot with a birdie putt on the 72nd hole.

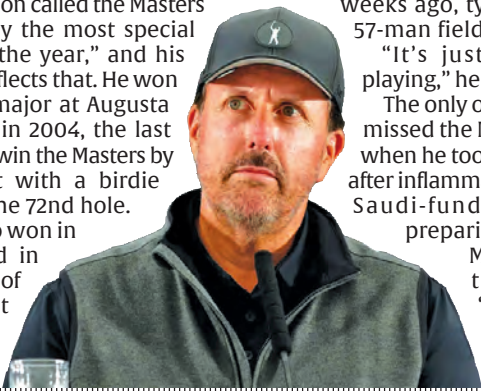
He also won in 2006 and in 2010, one of only eight players to win

the Masters at least three times. Mickelson has not shared details of the personal family matter. He sat out LIV's four events to start the year and returned in South Africa two weeks ago, tying for 48th in the 57-man field.

"It's just fun to be back playing," he said in South Africa.

The only other time Mickelson missed the Masters was in 2022, when he took a leave of absence after inflammatory remarks as the Saudi-funded LIV Golf was preparing to launch.

Mickelson accused the PGA Tour of "obnoxious greed" in a Golf Digest interview. (AP)



After crash, Tiger Woods told deputy he was 'talking to president', body camera shows

RJ RICO ■ Orlando

After crashing his SUV last week in Florida, Tiger Woods took out his phone and told a deputy, "I was just talking to the president," according to body camera footage released showing Woods' arrest on a DUI charge.

The phone conversation was not captured on video, and it wasn't clear if Woods was referring to President Donald Trump, whose former daughter-in-law, Vanessa Trump, is dating Woods.



Shortly after the golfer's March 27 arrest, Trump was asked about Woods and told reporters: "I feel so badly. He's got some difficulty. Very close friend of mine. He's an amazing person. Amazing man. But, some difficulty."

The White House did not immediately respond to a request for comment on whether Trump spoke to Woods after the crash.

The footage also shows how Woods appeared to be astonished as he was handcuffed after failing a sobriety test and a video from the back of the patrol car shows the handcuffed golfer hiccupping, yawning and repeatedly appearing to nod off during the 15-minute ride.

Woods on Thursday told authorities he was looking at his phone and changing the radio station when his speeding Land Rover clipped the back of a truck and rolled

onto its side on a residential road on Jupiter Island. No one was injured.

"I looked down at my phone, and all of a sudden — boom," Woods told an officer as he knelt on a lawn, prior to his arrest. Body camera footage shows Martin County Sheriff's Deputy Tatiana Levenar then conducting a roadside sobriety test and telling Woods: "I do believe your normal faculties are impaired, and you're under an unknown substance, so at this time you're under arrest for DUI."

"I'm being arrested?" Woods responded.

"Yes, sir," Levenar said.

After handcuffing Woods, authorities searched his pockets and found two white pills. "That's a Norco," Woods said after an officer pulled out the pills, referring to a painkiller that contains acetaminophen and the opioid hydrocodone. Authorities would later confirm that Woods was in possession of hydrocodone. (AP)

India surpasses Kenya in AIU's list of ineligible athletes due to doping

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

India has surpassed Kenya to top the Athletics Integrity Unit's (AIU) list of ineligible persons due to doping violations with 148 suspended track and field athletes, which is two more than the African nation.

The latest updated list is for the period up to April 1 this year. Russia took the third spot with 66 suspended athletes.

Prominent Indian athletes in the list include women's

100m national record holder Dutee Chand, who has been serving a four-year suspension since December 2022, middle distance runner Parvej Khan, whose six-year suspension will run till July 2030, and Tamil Nadu sprinter Sekar Dhanalakshmi who was suspended for eight years in 2025.

The list includes persons serving a period of ineligibility as a result of national level cases and decisions.

It also includes persons who have committed non-doping



violations such as tampering, evading testing, trafficking, or missing whereabouts, which carry the same penalties as a doping offence.

The Athletics Integrity Unit is an independent anti-doping watchdog established by the World Athletics. It has jurisdiction over international level athletes and their support persons.

In order to tackle the doping menace, the Athletics Federation of India (AFI) has taken up strict measures,

including tracking down those centres in the country which are linked to the menace.

Asserting that trainers also play a big role in doping of their wards, the AFI has also asked all the coaches to register with it. Unregistered coaches will be blacklisted, and their trainees will be deemed ineligible for national awards.

After the 2024 Paris Olympics, the AFI has decentralised the national camps. Currently, the AFI is only conducting national camps for relay teams.

Nikhat, Priya and Preeti reach Asian Boxing Championships semifinals

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Ulaanbaatar (Mongolia)

Nikhat Zareen, Priya and Preeti Pawar qualified for the semifinals of the Asian Boxing Championships, assuring India of at least three medals on Friday. Nikhat was in complete control in the women's 51kg quarterfinal, sealing a first-round RSC (referee stops contest) victory over Xian Baguhin from the Philippines in a dominant outing.

Nikhat will face a stern challenge in the semifinals against China's Wu Yu, who won the 2024 Olympics gold medal.

In the women's 60kg category, Priya showcased composure and maturity to defeat China's Chengyu Yang 4-1. Priya will take on Mongolia's Namun Monkhori for a place in the final. Meanwhile, in the women's 54kg category, Preeti, the gold medalist at the World Boxing Cup Finals, pro-



duced one of the most clinical performances of the fifth day.

Preeti defeated Mongolia's Mungun Tsetseg with a 5-0 unanimous decision victory, setting up a semifinal contest against Im Aeji. Meanwhile, in the men's 70kg category, Deepak exited the competition following a 1-4 loss to Jordan's Zeyad Eashash in the quarterfinals.

Bogey free Kochhar lies T-2 in Japan, Jeev makes cut

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Chiba (Japan)

India's Karandeep Kochhar fired a flawless 6-under 65 in the second round to propel himself to Tied-2 position at the halfway stage at International Series Japan at the Caledonian Golf Club here Friday.

Kochhar's second successive bogey-free round, punctuated with six birdies meant that he jumped 7 places from his overnight Tied-9th at the \$ 2 million event, and just one shot behind leader Hongtaek Kim of Korea.

Meanwhile, Indian legend Jeev Milkha Singh, a two-time Asian Tour Order of Merit winner, showed his class today by making his first cut on the Asian Tour since 2024. The 54-year-old, who now plays mainly on the Senior Tours, returned a 69 to finish on the one under par, right at the cutline.

Kim added a 67 today to his



64 in the first round for 11-under, while Kochhar (67-65) and Japan's Shugo Imahira (67-65) shared the second spot in the season opening event of the year on The International Series, and the third stop on the Asian Tour.

Kochhar's round was reflective of his strong start to the season and he is currently in sixth place on the Asian Tour Order of Merit.

"I mean to stay bogey free I think everything has to be

pretty much good, I would say. I think though it's my iron play majorly. And the putter, I feel like that's the streaky one. I think that kind of dictates how I play, so I think the putter has cooperated so far quite well," said Kochhar.

Kim, winner of the GS Caltex Maekyung Open on the Asian Tour two years ago, managed to do what every great player is capable of at this level which was to work out what was wrong with his game after

hitting a difficult patch.

"I wasn't hitting my shots very well early in the round, but I was able to figure out what I was doing wrong and make adjustments. After that, I was able to settle in and play much better."

He made a bogey on the third to fall back into the chasing pack but his experience quickly kicked in as that was his only dropped shot. He made five birdies later to move into pole heading into the weekend, when rain has been forecast.

"With the rain, I probably won't be able to get as much distance, so keeping the ball in the fairway will be very important," he said. "From there, I'll focus on staying patient, saving par when needed, and playing well around the greens."

Imahira is one of the most decorated Japanese players in the field and showed that today when he eagled two of the par fives, the sixth, where he chipped, and the 18th.

Shreyas steers Punjab Kings to 5-wicket win

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Chennai

Skipper Shreyas Iyer's half-century draped in elegance and aggression in equal measure was the centre-piece in Punjab Kings' five-wicket win over Chennai Super Kings in their IPL match here on Friday.

Shreyas (50, 29 balls) and his 59-run alliance with Nehal Wadhwa for the fourth wicket helped Punjab end up at 210 for five while chasing a competitive 209 on a dew-less Chepauk night, also consigning the hosts to their second successive defeat.

It was Punjab's second win on the trot, but there were other heroes too on the night for the PBKS. Chasing a target at a run-rate closer to 11 required consistent and calm run-making and that was what PBKS precisely did through their top-order, with just about everyone chipping in.

Priyansh Arya (39, 11 balls), Prabhsimran Singh (43, 34b), Cooper Connolly (36, 22b) all came up with mentionable contributions.

Arya was quite brutal while vandalising CSK attack - Khaleel Ahmed was put away for a 4 and six while Matt Henry was dispatched for 4, 6, 4 in his first over that leaked 20 runs.

Arya and Prabhsimran cracked 61

runs in just 4.2 overs that gave a strong portend to the route the match was taking.

The Delhi batter was cleaned up by Henry to give a token relief to CSK, but none was more significant in PBKS's march than their skipper Shreyas, who unfurled his full range of shots. Shreyas started a bit slow reaching 8 off 9 balls, as Connolly was doing the bulk of the work. But once the Australian fell to Anshul Kamboj, Shreyas took over the chase.

As expected, he hammered the spinners, and the shot of the innings was an inside-out six off leg-spinner Rahul Chahar.

Shreyas brought up his fifty in 26 balls with a boundary off Kamboj, but soon fell to the bowler, chasing a wide delivery.

Wadhwa fell in the first ball of the next over to Henry as PBKS slipped to 186 for five from 186 for three.

However, that proved a minor aberration. Earlier, Ayush Mhatre showcased his abundant talent with a 43-ball 73, powering the Super Kings to a competitive 209 for five. Mhatre and skipper Ruturaj Gaikwad (28) added 96 runs for the second wicket after Sanju Samson returned to the hut early.

Samson inexplicably moved



Punjab Kings' captain Shreyas Iyer plays a shot during an Indian Premier League (IPL) 2026 T20 cricket match between Chennai Super Kings and Punjab Kings, in Chennai, Tamil Nadu

down to the leg-side and tried to cart Xavier Bartlett's out-swing over covers, but all he could manage was a healthy edge to Prabhsimran behind the wicket.

But his dismissal proved a minor jitter, as Mhatre tore apart Punjab's bowling with power and precision.

Pacer Bartlett was the aggrieved party early as Mhatre smashed him for three fours in a row - a loft through mid-wicket, a flick and a pull. His audacity helped CSK reach 57 for one in the Power Play.

Mhatre seemed to have put behind, at least for now, his issues

against short-pitched balls, as the Mumbai young man later pulled Marco Jansen for a six.

Mhatre also punished Marcus Stoinis for two sixes in a row — both down the ground — and the first maximum also fetched his fifty in 29 balls.

But he shrugged a bit against the guiles of Yuzvendra Chahal, failing to read him well.

The veteran leg-spinner foxed Mhatre, 17 years younger to him, with a series of googlies, but fortune was not in favour of the former.

On 59, Mhatre was dropped by Vijayakumar Vyshak inside the circle and later on 67 by Shahshank Singh in the deep.

But luck eventually ran out as Mhatre's attempt to steer Vyshak ended in the hands of Chahal at short third man, as both of them got their own piece of revenge.

Gaikwad was ousted by Chahal as CSK's march dulled a bit between 10th and 15th overs, making just 45 runs.

Sarfraz Khan (32, 12 balls) tried to instil some urgency into CSK innings while playing his trademark dabs and close-to-body shots for a flurry of boundaries.

Agenda, jealousy after KKR's defeats: Rahane



TAPAN MOHANTA ■ Kolkata

Kolkata Knight Riders captain Ajinkya Rahane has hit back at criticism around his strike rate, suggesting that there is a "certain agenda" and an element of "jealousy" behind the chatter.

Questions on his strike rate came up after KKR slumped to a 65-run loss to Sunrisers Hyderabad on Thursday. Chasing a steep 227, the home side never had any impactful partnership despite a promising start and folded for 161 in 16 overs to remain winless so far this season.

The loss placed the focus on Rahane's own performance and strike rate. The KKR skipper, who managed 8 off 10 balls on Thursday, was uncharacteristically sharp as he reacted to the criticism.

"My strike rate, I think I have one of the best strike rates so far from 2020. People who are talking about me, probably not watching the game or they have certain agenda against me. They don't like me playing," he said without mentioning anyone in specific in the post-match media interaction.

"They don't like to watch me play. The amount of success which I got, I guess they are jealous of me. I am not too worried."

Approaching 38, the out-of-favour India player has

been a transformed batter and was Mumbai's top run-getter in the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy, scoring 391 runs from 10 innings at a strike rate of 161.57, finishing among the top five batters in the competition.

Rahane was also KKR's leading run-scorer last season despite a poor eighth place finish in their title defence. As a result, the franchise kept faith in him as its skipper.

QUESTIONS ON HIS STRIKE RATE CAME UP AFTER KKR SLUMPED TO A 65-RUN LOSS TO SUNRISERS HYDERABAD ON THURSDAY

But his middle-over slow-down has been a concern. Against Mumbai Indians in their opening game, Rahane cruised to 36 off 18 balls but only managed 31 off next 22 balls without a boundary.

"People who are talking, they don't understand the game and I think they want me to play a different kind of inning. They didn't expect that Ajinkya Rahane will basically improve his game this much. So I am happy they are talking about me, negative or positive either way. (PTI)

Nitish Reddy credits special person for bowling transformation

TAPAN MOHANTA ■ Kolkata

Sunrisers Hyderabad's India all-rounder Nitish Kumar Reddy has credited a "special person" for helping him rediscover his rhythm with the ball after a difficult, injury-hit phase but chose to keep the identity under wraps for now.

The 22-year-old all format player, who has been seen as a potential successor to India's premier pace-bowling all-rounder Hardik Pandya, has had his progress stalled by recurring fitness issues over the past year.

Multiple setbacks including a neck spasm, a left quadriceps injury in 2025 meant he missed crucial game time in the build-up to the 2026 T20 World Cup, where Shivam Dube eventually got the nod as the second seam-bowling all-rounder.

Reddy admitted that injuries had held him back from improving his bowling.

"It's always been a point that I wanted to work on my bowling, but it's just the injuries which I have gone through last year, I was not pretty sure that I didn't get the time to work on myself," Reddy said after being adjudged player-of-the-match in their win over Kolkata Knight Riders in an IPL match here on Thursday.

"But thankfully, I got a little bit of time for myself before



the season and yeah, I did pretty good in one week training with a specific person. So, that really helped and makes sense whatever he had said to me. So, it's going good now."

Asked about the identity of that "special person", the soft-spoken all-rounder just smiled and said: "I will do

that later on." The impact of that short but focused preparation was evident on Thursday as Reddy delivered a fine all-round performance — scoring 39 off 24 balls and returning with 2/17 from his two overs — to help SRH thrash Kolkata Knight Riders by 65 runs and secure their first win of the season.

Coming in at a tricky stage with SRH at 118/4 after a mini-collapse, Reddy stitched a crucial 82-run stand for the sixth wicket with Heinrich Klaasen (52), rebuilding the innings after a blazing start from Travis Head and Abhishek Sharma.

With the bowl, he bowled two crucial overs 12th and 14th and picked up two wickets.

One of them was the dangerous KKR vice-captain Rinku Singh with a well-executed slower ball, a delivery he described as one of his "strengths".

Reddy said he read the "two-paced" wicket while batting and adapted accordingly and used the slow ball to greater impact.

"It's just when I batted, I honestly thought that wicket is a bit too paced because when bowlers try to bowl slow bouncers, sometimes it's sticking and sometimes it's just rushing to the batsman. (PTI)

Abhishek Sharma fined 25% of match fee

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Kolkata

Sunrisers Hyderabad vice-captain Abhishek Sharma has been fined 25 per cent of his match fees and has also accumulated one demerit point for breaching the IPL Code of Conduct during his team's IPL match against Kolkata Knight Riders.

He admitted to the Level 1 offence under Article 2.3 and accepted the match referee's sanction.

For Level 1 breaches of the Code of Conduct, the match referee's decision is final and binding.

He scored 48 runs off 21 deliveries to get SRH to a flier in the powerplay.

SRH registered their first win of IPL 2026, with a thumping 65-run win, with Abhishek playing his part with the bat, hitting four fours and as many sixes.

But he was sanctioned for showing dissent on TV umpire Nitin Menon's decision after Varun Chakravarthy took a diving catch off Blessing Muzarabani the ninth over but there seemed to be no



But Menon deemed the catch to be legal which the batter disagreed and expressed his disappointment while walking off.

Delhi Capitals seek top-order stability against in-form MI

APARAJITA UPADHYAY ■ New Delhi

The spotlight will firmly be on Delhi Capitals' top order when they square off against a confident Mumbai Indians in their first home fixture of the IPL 2026 season here on Saturday.

DC, who shuffled as many as seven opening combinations last year, had hoped for greater stability this season, but early signs suggest the issue persists.

Chasing a modest 142 against Lucknow Super Giants in their opener, the Capitals' top order crumbled swiftly, with KL Rahul falling for a first-ball duck, while Nitish Rana, and Patum Nissanka departed in quick succession, leaving the side tottering



scripted a six-wicket victory with an unbroken stand that rescued DC.

While Rizvi's fearless strokeplay stood out, the vulnerability at the top is a concern, particularly against a Mumbai attack marshalled by the

redoubtable Jasprit Bumrah. Still in pursuit of their elusive maiden IPL title, the Capitals will be eager to see greater stability at the top. They have the option of turning to either Abhishek Porel, who displayed flashes of brilliance last season or the mercurial Prithvi Shaw who struggles with consistency. In contrast, DC's bowling unit looked far more assured even in the absence of Australian quick Mitchell Starc, who remains unavailable.

South African pacer Lungi Ngidi continues to astutely use slower deliveries and T Natarajan, who has spent considerable time on sidelines due to injury, chipped in with a three-wicket haul against LSG, while Mukesh Kumar was economical. (PTI)

When I was down emotionally, Dinesh Karthik told me to take a break, says Jitesh Sharma

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Bengaluru

Royal Challengers Bengaluru vice-captain Jitesh Sharma thanked former India wicket-keeper Dinesh Karthik for helping him during an emotionally difficult phase where he took some time off from the game after his father's demise.

Jitesh said Karthik encouraged him to step away briefly and recover emotionally after his father passed away in February this year. "DK anna asked me to take a break, put



Jitesh had spoken extensively to PTI last month about how priorities changed in his life briefly after his father's passing and that he was able to spend the last few days by his bed-side.

Jitesh had played a massive role in RCB's maiden IPL triumph last year during which Karthik had also contributed as a batting coach and mentor.

"A lot of the credit for my growth goes to DK 'anna'. He helped me understand my game better, use my strengths properly and improve mentally," he said.

quality domestic attack.

On Saturday at the Narendra Modi Stadium, Sooryavanshi will once again try to meet fire with fire but there will be three international bowlers of repute in Rabada, Siraj and Prasidh, who would like to test the batting flagbearer for the 'Gen Alpha'. For Titans skipper Shubman Gill, one would expect that he would take a few more prudent decisions unlike the opener in Mullanpur where Siraj was given only two overs and Prasidh was introduced as late as in the 13th over.

On the batting front, the track at the Narendra Modi Stadium is expected to be a paradise where one can hit through the line. The trend in the tournament so

PSL technical committee upholds two-match ban on Fakhar Zaman for ball-tampering

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Lahore

A three-member technical committee of the Pakistan Super League has rejected opener Fakhar Zaman's appeal against the two-match ban imposed on him for ball-tampering during a match.

The committee held a hearing and after going through all available evidence, upheld the ban imposed by match referee Roshan Mahanama. He had charged the Lahore Qalandars' skipper with a level three offence for changing the condition of the ball.



on the plea that there is no conclusive evidence available to confirm he changed the condition of the ball and the ban should be retracted.

and are fighting their own little demons. Worse, their Indian middle order comprising Shahrux Khan, Washington Sundar and Rahul Tewatia doesn't inspire confidence of the highest order.

Washington, a player highly rated for his multi-dimensional skills and was also recently a part of the T20 World Cup winning squad, has been an enigma in this format. With 529 runs and a batting strike-rate of 125 over 67 IPL games in the past decade along with 40 wickets at an economy rate of 7.71, the Tamil Nadu man in the shortest format has been at best a bits and pieces cricketer, who doesn't fit any particular role or slot.

far has been to chase and Rajasthan Royals with Nandre Burger and Jofra Archer, two tearaway quicks at its disposal would like to ask probing questions to Gill, Sai Sudharsan and Jos Buttler first up.

The problem with GT line-up is their top three batters, who aren't exactly scoring at 200 plus strike-rate. Both skipper Gill (39 off 27 balls) and Buttler (38 off 33 balls) didn't look in their element against Punjab Kings at Mullanpur. Sudharsan (13 off 11 balls) is also trying to get into the groove post injury break.

Gujarat Titans pace unit face Sooryavanshi test on batting deck

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Ahmedabad

A pace attack comprising Kagiso Rabada, Prasidh Krishna and Mohammed Siraj does bear an intimidating look but the troika will have its task cut out when 'Boy Wonder' Vaibhav Sooryavanshi faces them on a batting featherbed with Rajasthan Royals starting as favourites against Gujarat Titans in an IPL match on Saturday.

The season two of "Vaibhav Kand" has started with the 15-year-old demolishing the Chennai Super Kings attack for a 15-ball-50 but that was in a chase of 127 and against a poor

